

My Sister's Keeper



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF JODI PICOULT

Picoult was born on Long Island in 1966. She was interested in writing from a young age, having written her first story at age five. She studied creative writing at Princeton and published two short stories in *Seventeen* while still in college. She published her debut novel, *Songs of the Humpback Whale*, in 1992. The novel, about a woman driving across the country to escape her abusive husband, was the first of many novels exploring ethical dilemmas and life situations. She gained a larger following after the publication of her 2007 novel *Nineteen Minutes*, a novel about a school shooting, when the novel reached number one on the *New York Times* bestseller list. In addition to her writing career, Picoult is also an advocate for a variety of causes, such as anti-death penalty activism and initiatives to boost the voices of marginalized writers. Today, she lives in Hanover, New Hampshire with her husband and her three children. She and her daughter Samantha have written two books together.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

The early 2000s, much like today, were a time of heated debates about bodily autonomy and the ethical limits of individuals having complete control over their medical decisions. In particular, the turn of the 21st century saw increased anxiety around in vitro fertilization (IVF) and the theoretical possibility of parents being able to “design” their babies in order to remove “undesirable” traits. Much of this anxiety came from a wariness around eugenics, a 20th-century movement pioneered by America and later adopted by Nazi Germany that advocated for “cleansing” humanity of undesirable peoples. The fact that Sara and Brian conceive Anna specifically to be a donor for Kate intentionally evokes questions about how much of a right people have to artificially engineer their children for their own ends.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

Many of Picoult's novels focus on families who find themselves entangled in difficult moral dilemmas. One Picoult novel that shares many themes and plot elements with *My Sister's Keeper* is her 2009 novel *Handle With Care*. This novel focuses on a pair of parents who struggle with their daughter Willow's osteogenesis imperfecta (or “brittle bone syndrome”), with the mother ultimately choosing to sue her OB/GYN for not informing her of the OI during her pregnancy and thus making it impossible for her to make an informed decision about

whether or not to terminate the pregnancy. Like *My Sister's Keeper*, *Handle With Care* grapples with difficult questions around parenthood and bodily autonomy, with these questions being debated within the walls of a courtroom. Outside of Picoult's bibliography, John Green's 2012 novel *The Fault in Our Stars* is another contemporary literary work that has become famous for its unflinching look at cancer. The novel's protagonist, Hazel Grace, suffers from metastasizing thyroid cancer and falls in love with a boy named Augustus who is in remission from osteosarcoma. The fate of their relationship, in which the seemingly healthier love interest dies suddenly and leaves the sicker one alone, mirrors the doomed relationship of Kate and Taylor in *My Sister's Keeper*. Picoult herself praised *The Fault in Our Stars* for its adept combination of tragedy and humor.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** *My Sister's Keeper*
- **When Written:** Early 2000s
- **Where Written:** New Hampshire, United States
- **When Published:** April 6, 2004
- **Literary Period:** Contemporary
- **Genre:** Novel
- **Setting:** Upper Darby, Rhode Island, 2004
- **Climax:** Anna confesses on the witness stand that she did not file her lawsuit for her own benefit. Kate asked her to refuse to donate her kidney and, in doing so, let Kate die.
- **Antagonist:** Sara Fitzgerald
- **Point of View:** First Person (multiple narrators)

EXTRA CREDIT

A Controversial Adaptation. *My Sister's Keeper* was adapted into a film in 2009 and generated significant controversy due to major alterations it made to the novel's plot against Picoult's wishes.

Book Ban. According to the American Library Association, *My Sister's Keeper* was number seven on the list of most commonly banned books in 2007. It has generated controversy due to its depiction of adolescent sexuality and dark themes. Picoult herself has spoken out against the banning of her books.



PLOT SUMMARY

The protagonist of *My Sister's Keeper* is 13-year-old Andromeda “Anna” Fitzgerald, the youngest of three children. Her 16-year-

old sister Kate has battled acute promyelocytic leukemia (APL) since the age of two. Shortly after Kate's diagnosis, Anna's parents Sara and Brian decided to conceive a child via in vitro fertilization who could serve as a donor for Kate. This child turned out to be Anna, who, by the time the novel begins, has donated cord blood, bone marrow, and lymphocytes to Kate. Anna and Kate are quite close, but Anna struggles with feeling as though she only exists to save Kate.

At age 16, Kate is in remission from her leukemia, but she is suffering from kidney failure due to the strain of over a decade of treatment. As a result, Sara, a stay-at-home mother who has been fiercely devoted to Kate's treatment since her diagnosis, expects that Anna will donate a kidney in order to save Kate's life, even though Kate's oncologist Dr. Chance has informed the Fitzgeralds that there is a high chance of Kate dying during the transplant, which would leave Anna with one less kidney for nothing. Brian, a firefighter, is more ambivalent about having Anna donate a kidney, but he does not make his protests known. The Fitzgeralds' son, Jesse, often acts out and is generally isolated from the family, though he still lives at the family house.

Tired of being a constant donor for Kate, Anna decides to sue her parents for medical emancipation. Without telling her parents, she seeks out Campbell Alexander, a well-known and haughty attorney who keeps a service dog but refuses to tell anyone the dog's purpose. Campbell initially rejects Anna due to her young age, but when she tells him the details of her case, he is intrigued and decides to take her on pro bono. However, when Sara is served papers for the lawsuit in Kate's hospital room and grows irate, Anna begins to second-guess her decision to file the lawsuit. Her wishy-washy attitude frustrates Campbell, who doubts her commitment to the case and fears that he will not be able to prove her right to autonomy if she cannot stick to her own decisions.

Judge DeSalvo, who lost his 12-year-old daughter to a drunk driver a few years earlier, is assigned to the case. Sara is a former lawyer who is still accredited by the bar, so she chooses to represent herself. The first time all the parties meet, Anna becomes distraught due to pressure from Sara to retract her lawsuit and cannot make up her mind about what to do. Unsure about Anna's intentions, Judge DeSalvo appoints her a guardian ad litem to help guide Anna in her decision-making and make a recommendation to the court about what would be best for Anna. This guardian ad litem ends up being Julia Romano, Campbell's ex-girlfriend that he abruptly dumped in high school. This leads to tension between the two of them, particularly since Julia suspects that Campbell has only taken Anna's case for the publicity, since Sara and Brian have been publicly scrutinized for conceiving a "designer baby."

Shortly after Anna's lawsuit commences, Kate becomes extremely ill and has to be hospitalized, further straining tension in the Fitzgerald household. Jesse, unbeknownst to his

firefighter father, has been setting **fires** around town. Meanwhile, Sara increases her pressure on Anna to drop her lawsuit. Brian decides to allow Anna to stay at the fire station with him so that she can have time to process her feelings without Sara's pressure, which causes Sara to feel betrayed by Brian. During this time, Julia gets to know Anna better, although she also has trouble ascertaining Anna's true motivations for filing the lawsuit. Campbell speaks to Brian, who tells him that he would be willing to testify on Anna's behalf at the hearing.

Shortly before the hearing begins, Campbell and Julia go out to talk about the case and end up sleeping together, but Campbell leaves before Julia wakes, making her feel abandoned once again. At the hearing, both Campbell and Sara call a variety of witnesses who present various arguments both for and against Anna's emancipation. Campbell feels confident that he will win the case since he has one of Anna's parents as a witness, but when Brian takes the stand, he cannot in good conscience testify in favor of a decision that would result in Kate's death and breaks down on the stand. Campbell tells Anna that she'll have to testify instead, but Anna staunchly refuses, causing the two to get into a major argument.

Judge DeSalvo calls Julia to the stand to make her recommendation on Anna's behalf, but for the first time in Julia's career, she is unable to make a conclusive recommendation due to the ethical complexity of the Fitzgeralds' situation. This spurs Anna to take the stand, where she confesses that Kate, ready to die, asked Anna to file her lawsuit in order to get out of donating her kidney. As Anna testifies, Campbell has a seizure, forcing Judge DeSalvo to call for a recess in order for him to recuperate. During the recess, Campbell confesses to Julia that he developed epilepsy after receiving a concussion and broke up with her because he thought she deserved better. Julia rejects this and vows to stay by his side. Campbell also confesses to Anna, who speculates that Campbell took her case because he knows what it's like to lose control over his own body.

Judge DeSalvo speaks privately with Kate and declares that court will reconvene the next morning. That night, Sara and Brian spend time with Kate, coming to terms with the fact that she'll soon die. In court, Judge DeSalvo declares his ruling: he will grant Anna her medical emancipation. His reasoning is that, since the situation is so complicated and there is no correct decision, it makes sense to leave the decision up to whether Anna wants to donate her kidney or not. Anna is deeply conflicted over the verdict, but both Sara and Brian reassure her that they're all right with the outcome.

Sara and Brian head home ahead of Anna since she has legal paperwork to fill out, so Campbell drives Anna home afterwards. It is raining heavily, and during the drive, Campbell is T-boned by a large truck. Brian, the firefighter on duty, shows up and realizes Anna has been grievously injured. At the

hospital, the doctor informs him that Anna is braindead. Campbell, who was granted medical power of attorney for Anna, signs off on her organs being donated so that Kate can receive Anna's kidney. After Anna's organs are extracted, Sara and Brian turn off her life support, and she dies.

In the epilogue, Kate is in her 20s, having survived the kidney transplant and remaining in remission from her leukemia despite her prognosis. After Anna's death, the entire Fitzgerald household was thrown into intense grief, but the family eventually began to recover. Brian struggled with alcoholism but eventually recovered, and Jesse became a police officer. Kate herself became a ballet instructor and carries Anna with her wherever she goes.



CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

Andromeda "Anna" Fitzgerald – Anna is the protagonist of the novel. A 13-year-old girl and the youngest of three children, Anna was conceived via in vitro fertilization so that she could be a donor for her sister Kate, who suffers from acute promyelocytic leukemia. Throughout her life, she has been a donor for Kate multiple times, including for painful procedures such as bone marrow donations. At the novel's outset, Anna's parents want her to donate a kidney to Kate, leading Anna to sue them for medical emancipation. Anna's decision causes considerable tension between her and her mother Sara, although her father Brian, Kate, and her brother Jesse are more ambivalent. Throughout her lawsuit, Anna often cycles between standing up for herself and second-guessing her decisions, causing her lawyer, Campbell, to doubt her commitment to her case. However, it is eventually revealed that Anna's conflict is due to the fact that Kate herself asked her to file her lawsuit so that she can die on her own terms and Anna can have a life beyond being Kate's donor. This latter future is indeed desirable for Anna, which causes her profound guilt as she struggles to reconcile her love for Kate with her desire for freedom. Although Anna ultimately wins her case, she never gets the chance to decide either way, as she is tragically killed in a car accident that renders her brain-dead. Before removing her life support, Campbell, Sara, and Brian decide to donate her kidney to Kate.

Kate Fitzgerald – The middle child of the Fitzgerald family, Kate is 16 at the start of the novel—an age she was never expected to reach. At age two, Kate was diagnosed with acute promyelocytic leukemia and was not expected to live more than a few years. However, her parents Sara and Brian conceived Anna in order for Kate to have a match for donations. As a result, Kate has long surpassed her prognosis, but is now dying due to kidney failure. Although Sara and Brian, the girls' parents, want Anna to donate her kidney to Kate, Kate herself

is taciturn about her own desires throughout the novel and occasionally lashes out at Sara for being overbearing. She also struggles with isolation from her peers, especially after her boyfriend Taylor dies from complications of his own cancer. In court, Anna eventually confesses that Kate has attempted suicide before and asked Anna to fight for her right to keep her kidney, as she no longer wants to keep fighting her illness. However, after Anna's sudden death in a car crash, Kate receives Anna's kidney and goes on to survive into adulthood, becoming a ballet teacher. She feels that she carries Anna with her everywhere she goes due to Anna's blood, marrow, and kidney keeping her alive.

Sara Fitzgerald – Sara is the mother of Jesse, Kate, and Anna Fitzgerald. She was deeply devastated by Kate's cancer diagnosis, vowing to keep her daughter from dying at all costs. As a result, Kate's treatment is her top priority, with her and her husband Brian going so far as to conceive Anna as a donor for Kate. Sara is extremely protective of Kate and strongly disagrees with Anna's decision to sue for medical emancipation. Although Sara has been a stay-at-home mother since the birth of her children, she is a former lawyer and returns to the law in order to represent herself in Anna's case. She frequently attempts to get Anna to back out of her case, growing angry when she is unable to do so. As a result, Anna and Sara's relationship becomes strained throughout the course of the novel, but the two eventually reconcile after the revelation that Kate asked Anna to file her suit. After their reconciliation, Sara accepts Kate's impending death and lets go of the need to keep her alive against her will. After Anna's sudden death, Sara struggles with grief for many years but ultimately is able to reforge her bonds with the rest of her family.

Brian Fitzgerald – Brian is the father of Jesse, Kate, and Anna and the husband of Sara. A **firefighter**, Brian is somewhat less involved in Kate's treatment than Sara is, which is partially intentional on his part, since he tries to avoid the emotional pain of his home life. Brian is also closer to Anna than Sara is and is more conflicted over pushing Anna into being Kate's donor; although he supported taking Anna's cord blood for Kate since it was a non-invasive procedure, he expressed uncertainty over her donating bone marrow. As a result, he is not angry at Anna for her lawsuit and allows her to stay with him at the fire station during the case so that she can have space to process her thoughts and emotions without Sara's influence. Brian also later gives more attention to Jesse, whom he and Sara had previously all but given up on because of his misbehavior. Brian, who has been investigating an arsonist at his job, eventually realizes that Jesse is the arsonist in question and confronts him, resulting in Jesse breaking down and admitting that he's suffering with his grief over Kate. In this way, Brian is the gentler of the two Fitzgerald parents, although he admits that he has not been able to confront Kate's illness in the way that Sara has. After Anna's death, he's grief-stricken

and struggles with alcoholism for many years before recovering.

Jesse Fitzgerald – Jesse is the oldest child of the Fitzgerald family and receives the least attention from his parents. Although he's shown to be a bright and curious child in flashbacks, these positive traits are later buried under a veneer of delinquency and rage as he lashes out in response to his family's situation. Jesse is not a donor match for Kate and therefore cannot donate anything to help her, which makes him feel useless and invisible in comparison to Anna. He's also physically and emotionally isolated from the rest of the family, living in the garage away from his parents and siblings. In his adolescence, he begins to commit acts of **arson** in an attempt to feel a semblance of control over his life and make himself feel less invisible. Despite his edgy demeanor and criminal background, however, Jesse does genuinely care for his sisters. He fully supports Anna during her lawsuit, often driving her places she needs to go when she cannot ask her parents, and he keeps Kate company in the hospital when everyone else is at court. When Brian discovers his identity as the town arsonist and confronts him, Jesse expects to be punished but breaks down when Brian forgives him. After Anna's death, he leaves his criminal past behind and becomes a police officer.

Campbell Alexander – Campbell Alexander is Anna's attorney, representing her in her petition for medical emancipation. A wealthy lawyer interested in bolstering his own reputation, he initially refuses to take on Anna's case but, intrigued by her situation, decides to represent her pro bono. Campbell and Anna often butt heads during her case due to Anna's fickleness and lack of communication with Campbell, but he gradually softens towards her and defends her fervently in court. Campbell also has a tense relationship with Julia, Anna's guardian ad litem, due to a relationship in high school that Campbell abruptly ended, breaking Julia's heart. For much of the novel, Campbell refuses to tell her or anyone else the reason that he's isolated himself from other people: when he was 18, he suffered a concussion in a car crash and developed epilepsy as a result, which is why he keeps his service dog Judge. This backstory comes out when Campbell suffers a seizure during court, forcing him to confess the truth to Julia afterwards; she responds by telling him that she wants to be with him, repairing their relationship. Campbell successfully wins Anna her emancipation, but on the drive home from the courthouse, the two get in a terrible accident that leaves Anna brain-dead. Because Campbell has been granted medical power of attorney for Anna, he gives her kidney to Kate. The epilogue reveals that Campbell marries Julia but falls out of contact with the Fitzgeralds due to everyone's grief over Anna.

Julia Romano – Julia is Anna's guardian ad litem, assigned to her in order to act as an advocate for Anna in court. Julia cares deeply about Anna but struggles to ascertain her motivations and intentions due to Anna constantly changing her mind about

the case throughout the novel. Julia also has a long past with Anna's lawyer, Campbell, who abruptly dumped her when the two were in high school together. As a result of the breakup, Julia has low self-esteem and has struggled to connect with other men. Her twin sister, Izzy, hates Campbell and constantly warns Julia against talking to him, advice that Julia struggles to follow. Julia is skeptical of Campbell's motivations in taking the case and accuses him multiple times of taking Anna's case in order to bolster his own publicity. Even so, she struggles with her attraction to him throughout the novel, and her opinion on him changes considerably when he has a seizure in court and she discovers that he has epilepsy, which led him to break up with Julia since he believed that she deserved better. Julia rejects the idea that Campbell's epilepsy will stifle her independence and vows to stay by his side. Years later, the two get married.

Suzanne "Zanne" Crofton – Suzanne is Sara's older sister. In contrast to Sara, who left her profession as a lawyer to become a stay-at-home mom, Suzanne climbed the corporate ladder, never got married or had children, and became quite wealthy. Suzanne and Sara have occasionally butted heads over their different lifestyles—Suzanne in particular feels that Sara has wasted her potential—but the two reconnect after Kate's diagnosis, with Suzanne becoming a key support person during the course of Kate's treatment. She often babysits and housesits for Sara and Brian when they need to be at the hospital—or, later, at court.

Dr. Chance – Dr. Chance is Kate's primary oncologist after she is diagnosed with APL. Since he begins treating her at age two and is still overseeing her care when she is 16, he knows the Fitzgeralds quite well and is deeply invested in Kate's situation. He is shown to be patient with the Fitzgeralds when they get upset, especially Sara, who occasionally lashes out at him in her grief. He testifies at Anna's hearing, arguing in favor of Anna donating a kidney to Kate and claiming that all the procedures Anna has undergone for donations have been of minimal risk.

Judge DeSalvo – Judge DeSalvo is the judge presiding over Anna's case. A few years before the events of the novel, Judge DeSalvo's 12-year-old daughter was killed by a drunk driver. This tragedy initially makes Campbell worried that Judge DeSalvo will not be able to be impartial during Anna's case, as he speculates that the prospect of Kate's death will remind him of his own loss. However, Judge DeSalvo consistently works to keep things impartial, assigning Anna a guardian ad litem when he sees her struggling with her decisions. He also discourages Sara from talking to Anna about the case. In the end, he rules in Anna's favor, granting her medical emancipation from her parents.

Isobel "Izzy" Romano – Izzy is Julia's twin sister. The two are quite different from each other, with Izzy selling jewelry made of found materials while Julia works a typical 9-5 job. Izzy moves in with Julia after breaking up with her girlfriend,

causing tension between the two. Izzy is especially critical of Campbell and Julia's reunion with him, warning Julia that Campbell will hurt her again. Even so, she's unequivocally supportive of Julia when she struggles with her feelings for Campbell.

Judge – Judge is Campbell's service dog, specifically a German Shepherd. For much of the novel, Campbell refuses to tell anyone Judge's specific purpose, but after Campbell has a seizure in court, it's revealed that Judge is a seizure dog. Judge can sense when Campbell is going to have a seizure about 20 minutes in advance and, when Campbell seizes, is trained to assist him in order to prevent any injuries. Judge goes with Campbell everywhere; any time he gets agitated, it's a clue that Campbell is close to having a seizure.

Taylor Ambrose – Taylor is Kate's first boyfriend. The two meet at the hospital while Kate is undergoing chemo for her cancer. Taylor has acute myeloid leukemia (AML), which has a much better prognosis than Kate's APL. The two attend the hospital prom together and share a first kiss. However, shortly after, Taylor stops returning Kate's calls. Sara learns that he passed away from an infection shortly after the prom, but she hides this from Kate for a month, leading Kate to believe that Taylor simply abandoned her. When Kate discovers the truth, she is devastated and does not speak to Sara for weeks.

Jenna Ambrose – Jenna is Taylor's mother. Sara briefly speaks with her after Taylor's death, at which point Jenna tells her that she sat with Taylor's body hours after he died and still thinks she can hear him moving about in his room. Sara views Jenna as a preview of what she will experience when she loses Kate.

Paulie – Paulie is one of Brian's colleagues. He is divorced after his wife left him for a cellist. Out of all the firefighters, he's known Brian the longest and can often sense when something is happening with Kate. He is present at the scene of Campbell and Anna's car crash, where Brian punches him when he attempts to pull Anna from the car.

Kerri Donatelli – Kerri is Campbell's receptionist. She is shown to be somewhat lazy, often reading magazines at the front desk. However, she reliably follows Campbell's orders and relays his phone calls to him. She is initially skeptical of Anna when she arrives at the law firm due to Anna's young age, but she softens when Anna stands up for herself.

Beatta Neaux – Dr. Neaux is a child psychiatrist who has spoken with Jesse, Kate, and Anna at multiple points throughout their childhoods. Sara calls her as an expert witness so that she can testify that donating a kidney would have a positive psychological effect on Anna. Campbell refutes this, pointing out that there is a good chance Kate will die during the transplant, which would obviously not psychologically benefit Anna.

Duracell Dan – "Duracell Dan," known by this name due to his penchant for collecting batteries, is a homeless man. Jesse

brings him meals in exchange for Dan looking after his arson paraphernalia. At one point, Jesse brings Dan along to watch as he burns a shed, at which point Dan tells Jesse that another homeless man known as the Rat lives inside it. This propels Jesse to enter the burning shed to rescue the Rat.

MINOR CHARACTERS

Seven – Seven is the bartender at a gay bar that Julia frequents during her rough patches with Campbell. Seven himself is straight and often commiserates with Julia about the difficulty of love.

Caesar – Caesar is one of Brian's colleagues. He is constantly falling for different women and writes love letters to them, causing Brian to give him love advice.

Red – Red is one of Brian's colleagues. He often cooks for the team and is described by Brian as a "confirmed bachelor." When Campbell and Anna get in their car crash, Red uses the Jaws of Life in an attempt to get them out.

Peter Bergen – Dr. Bergen is the head of the board of ethics at Kate's hospital. He testifies in court to confirm that the board never convened to discuss the ethical ramifications of Anna's donations to Kate, as they did not consider Anna a patient despite her multiple hospital intakes.

Hercules – Kate's pet fish whom she is very attached to. Hercules almost dies twice but is saved each time by Sara.

Campbell's Father – Campbell's father does not appear in the narrative present, but is shown in flashbacks to be extremely harsh and critical of Campbell in his adolescence. It is suggested that Campbell is emotionally closed off about his epilepsy due to his father's criticisms of him as weak.

Campbell's Mother – Campbell's mother is a rather emotional woman who frequently calls Campbell to accuse Campbell's father of dating various woman. She often threatens to institutionalize herself, a threat that Campbell does not take very seriously.

Vern Stackhouse – Vern is the town sheriff. He has a good relationship with the Fitzgeralds, which puts him in an awkward position when he has to serve Sara the papers for Anna's lawsuit. He calls down his journalist sister for the trial after Campbell manipulates him into doing so.

Kyle McFee – Kyle is Anna's crush whom she often daydreams about throughout the novel. The two go on a movie date together, but it ends awkwardly when Anna realizes Kyle has an erection.

Eldie Briggs – Eldie is an old woman who lives in a nursing home. She falls after having a stroke, resulting in Brian's team getting called out. Anna comes along with them and provides Eldie comfort as she's transported to the hospital.

Dr. Orestes – A doctor of oceanography at the University of

Rhode Island. Sara calls him to seek veterinary help for Kate's pet fish Hercules, who is lethargic. Dr. Orestes suggests giving the fish bottled water instead of tap, which saves the fish.

Judge Newbell – Judge Newbell has his yellow Hummer stolen by Jesse.

Bruce – Bruce is the prosecutor for the case when Jesse steals Judge Newbell's car. He has a murder case he wants to get back to, making him amenable to Campbell's plea bargain for Jesse.

Donna – Donna is one of Kate's oncology nurses. She provides Sara with emotional support one night at the hospital.

"The Rat" – The Rat is a homeless man who lives in a shed full of newspapers. Jesse sets his shed on fire, not realizing that anyone lives inside, then rushes in to rescue him when Duracell Dan tells him the shed is the Rat's home.

Nadya – Nadya is an interviewer for the local news. She interviews Sara and Brian about their decision to conceive Anna, subtly accusing them of making a "designer baby."

Dr. Wayne – Dr. Wayne is Kate's childhood pediatrician. She refers the Fitzgeralds to Ileana Farquard, a hematologist and oncologist, after two-year-old Kate's lab results point towards leukemia.

Ileana Farquard – Ileana Farquard is a hematologist and oncologist who first diagnoses Kate with APL.

Jimmy Stredboe – One of Anna's classmates who was bullied until he developed multiple sclerosis, after which point everyone started being nice to him.

Pawn Shop Owner – A shop owner to whom Anna sells her locket, a gift from Brian, in order to raise money for her lawsuit.

Luisa – A young girl whom Brian rescues from a house fire.

Mrs. Zegna – A woman who lost all of her clothes after her house burned down and now has to wear an octopus costume. She did not have home insurance and thus has lost all of her belongings and most of her assets.

TERMS

Acute Myeloid Leukemia (AML) – Acute myeloid leukemia is a blood and bone marrow cancer. It is the cancer that Kate's boyfriend, Taylor, is in remission from when the two meet. Prognoses for AML can vary wildly, but Taylor is said to have a good outlook and is unlikely to relapse. *My Sister's Keeper* portrays AML as a distinct cancer from Kate's cancer, APL, but the latter is actually a subtype of the former.

Acute Promyelocytic Leukemia (APL) – APL is a blood and bone marrow cancer and is the type of cancer that Kate suffers from. It is a rare form of leukemia, especially among children as young as Kate, who is diagnosed at the age of two. Although Kate receives a poor prognosis and is initially not expected to live past the age of five, in real life, APL is actually known as a fairly

treatable cancer with low rates of relapse. However, its acuteness means that it progresses quickly and leads to rapid death without quick treatment.

Guardian Ad Litem – A guardian ad litem is a legally appointed guardian to a minor, but only for the span of a court case. The phrase literally translates to "guardian for the lawsuit," reflecting the temporary nature of this responsibility. A guardian ad litem can be appointed for various reasons; in Anna's case, her guardian ad litem, Julia, is appointed to her to provide insight into what's best for Anna's wellbeing, since Anna's parents are being sued and thus cannot be impartial arbiters of care for Anna.

Emancipation – Emancipation—in this context—is the legal process by which a minor is granted the same rights to make their own decisions as an adult. In most cases, parents are able to make major decisions on behalf of their child, but a court may grant emancipation to a minor when there is evidence that their parents do not have their best interests in mind. In *My Sister's Keeper*, Anna is specifically suing for medical emancipation, but emancipation as a status usually encompasses decisions beyond the medical.

In Vitro Fertilization (IVF) – In vitro fertilization is a method of conceiving a child by combining an egg and sperm in a controlled laboratory setting rather than during sexual intercourse. IVF has many benefits, such as increasing rates of successful conception for individuals struggling to conceive and allowing for surrogate pregnancies for families that need them. However, IVF is also sometimes controversial due to the ability to screen embryos for genetic traits, which some people claim is a way of creating "designer babies." Sara and Brian use embryonic screening to conceive a perfect match donor for Kate, resulting in Anna's birth.

Power of Attorney – Power of attorney is legal authorization for one individual to act on behalf of another. The two primary types of power of attorney are financial and medical. In the former case, an individual can make monetary decisions on behalf of another person, and in the latter, they can make medical decisions. Power of attorney usually kicks in when an individual is indisposed and cannot make decisions for themselves. In *My Sister's Keeper*, Judge DeSalvo grants Campbell medical power of attorney over Anna after she's granted medical emancipation. As a result, when Anna is declared brain-dead after their car accident, Campbell is able to consent to her kidney being donated to Kate.



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don't have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in

black and white.



BODILY AUTONOMY

The question of bodily autonomy and its limits is the core issue of *My Sister's Keeper*. The novel's protagonist, 12-year-old Anna Fitzgerald, attempts to assert agency over her own body when she sues for medical emancipation from her parents in order to avoid donating her kidney to her older sister, Kate, who is suffering kidney failure after a decade of battling acute promyelocytic leukemia. The dilemma of the two sisters' conflicting interests forms the crux of the novel's conflict: although Kate deserves a chance to live, she is so weak that she might not even survive the procedure, and living with one kidney could affect Anna's quality of life. For example, Anna is a hockey player but would not be able to play contact sports with only one kidney.

The intricacies surrounding Anna's lawsuit become clearer when her case reaches the courtroom in the second half of the novel. Anna's lawyer, Campbell Alexander, defends her by highlighting the slippery slope that forcing her to donate an organ against her will would create. For instance, at one point, he asks Kate's oncologist, Dr. Chance, if it would be acceptable to sacrifice Anna if scientists came up with a cure for Kate's cancer that required Anna to donate her head. While such a hypothetical might seem like a gross exaggeration, it gets to the core question behind Anna's predicament: should a person be forced to sacrifice any part of their body for another, and if so, where is the line? The novel does not explicitly answer this question, instead challenging readers to think about the difficult, messy interplay of emotions and ethical quandaries that accompany such considerations.



SIBLINGHOOD

The deep relationship between siblings is a recurring theme in *My Sister's Keeper*. The most significant instance of this is the relationship between the protagonist, Anna, and her older sister, Kate. Although Anna is suing for the right to refuse to donate her kidney to Kate, this does not mean she hates Kate; on the contrary, the two are shown to be extremely close from their very first scene together, in which Anna knows the plot of Kate's favorite soap opera by heart. As a result of their closeness, though, Anna frequently struggles to reconcile her desire for her sister to live with the knowledge that she would be freer if Kate was gone. As it turns out, this sense of obligation is mutual—at the climax of the novel, it is revealed that Kate asked Anna to refuse to donate her kidney in order to spare Anna from any more sacrifices on Kate's behalf. In this way, Kate and Anna's relationship functions as the moral heart of the story, with their love for each other transcending all other ethical questions and material obstacles.

Furthermore, while Kate and Anna's bond is the most significant sibling relationship in the novel, their older brother, Jesse, is also an important figure in both of their lives. Although Jesse often lashes out and isolates himself due to his pain over not being able to help Kate, his isolation from family affairs often allows him to be an unexpected source of support for his sisters—especially Anna, whom he wholeheartedly supports throughout her entire lawsuit.

In addition to the Fitzgerald siblings, the novel features two adult sister pairs: the girls' mother, Sara, and her older sister, Suzanne, as well as Anna's guardian ad litem, Julia, and her sister Izzy. Interestingly, in both cases, Picoult portrays the sisters as opposites: Sara is a stay-at-home mother while Suzanne is an assertive corporate executive, and Julia works a 9-to-5 legal job while Izzy sells jewelry for a living. Despite these differences, though, the sisters are always there for each other in crisis, with Suzanne providing vital childcare during Kate's illness and Izzy comforting Julia during her ups and downs with Campbell. Thus, these adult sisters underscore how the bonds of siblinghood are powerful tools for overcoming life's most difficult moments.



PARENTHOOD

My Sister's Keeper explores the emotional and ethical complexities of parenting. The Fitzgerald family's progression from a happy young family to one struggling under the terror of childhood cancer is poignant and provides context for Sara and Brian's respective reactions to their daughter's lawsuit in the novel's present. The trauma of witnessing Kate suffer during her treatment makes it difficult for Sara to empathize with her other children's issues, which she views as trivial compared to Kate's. This, in turn, influences her parenting style for the next decade and causes her to deprioritize Anna and Jesse's interests in favor of Kate's. Brian, on the other hand, is able to stay more grounded. Although he of course is also terrified for Kate, he frequently expresses concern for Anna and Jesse and is often the parent to get through to them when they are emotionally distant. However, his closeness with the other children on top of his job as a **firefighter** means that he is not always as present for Kate's treatment as Sara is, leaving much of the burden to her. Thus, the benefits and drawbacks to each parent's approach highlights the difficulty of parenthood in general, emphasizing how even a well-intentioned and loving parent can act against their own child's interests without realizing it—or, to put it more broadly, the novel hints that there's often no perfect solution to certain parental dilemmas. However, it is also clear throughout the novel that, although they see things differently, Sara and Brian both love all three of their children fiercely, which allows them to stay connected to each other even as their marriage struggles under the weight of Kate's illness.



CONTROL

The attempt to regain control of one's life is present in nearly every aspect of *My Sister's Keeper's* plot. The most obvious instance of this is

Anna's lawsuit, in which she is attempting to assert control over her own body despite the potential effect this could have on Kate's health. However, the theme of control can also be seen more broadly in the trajectory of the characters' lives. Sara, for instance, desperately attempts to retain control over her family's life by doing everything she can to keep Kate alive, even when it makes Anna suffer and even, as seen later in the novel, when Kate does not particularly want to be saved and in fact is trying to assert control over her own death by refusing Anna's kidney. In contrast, Brian tries to regain control by avoiding his family and throwing himself into his work as a **firefighter** since, even if he cannot save Kate, he is able to take solace in having the ability to save others. Jesse, after his parents give up on him, finds control in setting fire to buildings in order to feel that he has an impact somewhere. The desire for control extends even beyond the Fitzgeralds, most notably to Campbell, who compensates for the *lack* of control over his body that comes with epilepsy by shutting people out and hiding his condition to keep up a façade of good health.

However, in almost every instance, the desire to maintain such tight control either fails or backfires. Both Sara and Brian ultimately have to accept that Kate will likely die before they're ready to lose her, while Jesse finds that arson doesn't fill his emotional void and ends up confiding in his father. Campbell, for his part, has a seizure in the courtroom, revealing his secret and shattering his mask of invulnerability. And although Anna and Kate seem to have the best chance of successfully enacting control over their fates, even this is tragically subverted when Anna dies suddenly in a car accident, causing Kate to receive her kidney despite the protracted legal battle over her right to not do so. While this loss of control is often difficult and tragic for the characters, the ability to embrace it ultimately allows the surviving characters to find freedom in their life, with the epilogue illustrating how they have been able to move on with their lives and find a sense of purpose.



ILLNESS AND ISOLATION

My Sister's Keeper spends considerable time exploring the isolating nature of severe illness. This, of course, most profoundly affects Kate herself.

Due to her aggressive leukemia, which keeps her out of school and causes her to appear visibly ill, she has never been able to have a normal group of friends. Although she eventually gets her first boyfriend, Taylor, she is devastated when he dies suddenly from complications of his own cancer, a tragedy that highlights just how precarious relationships can be when you're extremely ill. Kate's isolation is in some ways paralleled by that of Campbell, who breaks up with his first love, Julia, after

becoming epileptic. While Campbell's isolation is in some ways more voluntary than Kate's—he chooses not to divulge his disability due to pride and shame—both face profound loneliness due to both external and internal stigma surrounding illness, and particularly *visible* illness.

In addition, it is not only the ill people themselves who face isolation in the novel. Those close to them can also be affected. Julia, for instance, suffers severe loneliness after Campbell leaves her, as she believes something is wrong with her. However, this profound isolation is most clearly seen with the Fitzgeralds, who become isolated not just from outside society—such as when Anna is unable to attend hockey camp, since she has to stay close to home for emergencies—but from each other. Jesse, for example, gives up on connecting with his family due to the lack of attention he receives from them, and his parents give up on him in turn. Sara and Brian are also quite out of touch with Anna's wants and needs, hence their surprise at her lawsuit, and they also become emotionally estranged from each other during the long course of Kate's treatment. In one sense, then, Anna's lawsuit is a boon in that it requires the family to truly face the emotions and tensions they've been suppressing in the name of saving Kate. In the end, although Anna's story ends in tragedy, her family is able to overcome both Kate's illness and the resulting sense of isolation, ultimately becoming closer to each other by the end of the novel.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



FIRE

Fire in *My Sister's Keeper* reflects the lack of control the Fitzgeralds have over their life, as well as their attempts to regain said control. Fire, much like Kate's cancer, is a dangerous force that can spread quickly with no regard for people's lives. However, even though fire is potentially lethal, it is in many ways less frightening than cancer: there is a straightforward way to eliminate it, and even if it spreads, it will eventually burn itself out. Kate's leukemia, on the other hand, continues to return over and over again even after the difficult process of destroying it. With this in mind, it makes sense that Brian throws himself into his firefighting, as it allows him to face a problem with an easy—if difficult—solution. Jesse, on the other hand, turns to arson. While his crimes may initially appear to be the polar opposite of Brian's actions, the fires he sets are his own attempt to enact control over the chaos in his and his family's lives. However, in both cases, Brian and Jesse are only able to come to terms with the tragedy in their lives when they turn away from fire and accept their inability to save Kate. In

this way, fire illustrates the futility of trying to eliminate one's pain rather than accepting it.



STARS AND COSMOLOGY

In *My Sister's Keeper*, the stars and their various cosmologies represent the cruelty and beauty of fate. Brian, an amateur astronomer, often uses the stars to ponder his own place in the world. The ancient age of the stars, as well as the various myths told about them, signify individuals' small and insignificant place in the universe. During some parts of the novel, this fact becomes a point of comfort; for example, Brian and Anna go stargazing together while she stays with him at the fire station, allowing her to step away from the stress of her lawsuit and ponder her place in the wider universe. However, the vastness of space also serves as a reminder that the novel's characters are faced with an existence that they cannot fully control or predict. This is reflected in many of the myths that Brian tells Anna, such as that of Orpheus and Eurydice, where individuals' attempts to change their fate end in tragedy.



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Washington Square Press edition of *My Sister's Keeper* published in 2005.

1. Monday: Anna Quotes

☛ I was born because a scientist managed to hook up my mother's eggs and my father's sperm to create a specific combination of previous genetic material. In fact, when Jesse told me how babies get made and I, the great disbeliever, decided to ask my parents the truth, I got more than I bargained for. They sat me down and explained all the usual stuff, of course—but they also explained that they chose little embryonic me, specifically, because I could save my sister, Kate. "We loved you even more," my mother made sure to say, "because we knew what exactly we were getting."

It made me wonder, though, what would have happened if Kate had been healthy. Chances are, I'd still be floating up in Heaven or wherever, waiting to be attached to a body to spend some time on Earth. Certainly, I would not be part of this family. See, unlike the rest of the free world, I didn't get here by accident. And if your parents have you for a reason, then that reason better exist. Because once it's gone, so are you.

Related Characters: Andromeda "Anna" Fitzgerald (speaker), Kate Fitzgerald, Sara Fitzgerald, Brian Fitzgerald, Jesse Fitzgerald

Related Themes:



Page Number: 7-8

Explanation and Analysis

Anna introduces herself to the reader by describing the circumstances of her birth: namely, that she was conceived in order to be Kate's donor and save her life. While most other children are conceived via more traditional means—and often by accident—Anna's conception was not only deliberate, but carefully calculated.

In particular, Anna describes the emotional impact of being born in order to benefit someone else. Although Sara tells her that deliberately conceiving her increased her love for Anna, the second paragraph establishes that it's quite difficult for Anna to extricate her own identity from her role as Kate's savior. After all, as Anna points out, she quite literally would not exist without Kate, since the only reason she was conceived was to save her sister. The last two sentences of this quote highlight how significant this sense of identity is for Anna, in that she does not understand who she is if Kate disappears. In other words, although Sara clearly wants Anna to feel loved, the very fact of how she was conceived has shaped how she understands herself and has molded her self-esteem to revolve around Kate.

2. Monday: Campbell Quotes

☛ I tap my pen on the desk, and Judge—my dog—sidles closer. "What happens if you don't give your sister a kidney?" "She'll die."

"And you're okay with that?"

Anna's mouth is set in a thin line. "I'm here, aren't I?"

"Yes, you are. I'm just trying to figure out what made you want to put your foot down, after all this time."

She looks over at the bookshelf. "Because," she says simply, "it never stops."

Related Characters: Andromeda "Anna" Fitzgerald, Campbell Alexander (speaker), Kate Fitzgerald

Related Themes:



Page Number: 22

Explanation and Analysis

During Anna's first meeting with Campbell, he attempts to ascertain her motivations in filing her lawsuit. Although she admits that Kate will die if she refuses her kidney, she claims

that she still wants go through with her lawsuit.

Anna's steadfast commitment to her lawsuit is striking given that she does truly love Kate. With this in mind, it's clear that Anna's desire to file her lawsuit is not born out of malice or apathy towards Kate; on the contrary, her tense demeanor suggests that the gravity of what she's doing is extremely difficult for her.

Anna's comment that "it never stops" shows why she would pursue this lawsuit despite the high personal cost: the "it" in this statement represents the repeated demands that Anna donate parts of her body to Kate. Although she does not want to hurt Kate, she feels that, if she does not fight for herself, her right to control her own body will be more and more eroded. Thus, the contrast between Anna's love for Kate and her drive to keep her kidney anyway in this dialogue shows just how intensely she longs for independence and agency.

attempting to adopt and her true feeling that something is deeply wrong. This emotional dissonance will be a pattern for Sara, who often struggles to enact a sense of control over the difficult situations she finds herself in—but it is also representative of people in general, who often find themselves in denial during traumatic moments in life.

☝ "Providence Hospital doesn't know anything," he says fiercely. "Do you remember when the chief's son broke his left arm, and they put a cast on the right one?"

I stare at the ceiling again. "Just so you know," I say, more loudly than I've intended, "I'm not going to let Kate die."

There is an awful sound beside me—an animal wounded, a drowning gasp. Then Brian presses his face against my shoulder, sobs into my skin. He wraps his arms around me and holds on as if he's losing his balance. "I'm not," I repeat, but even to myself, it sounds like I am trying too hard.

3. 1990: Sara Quotes

☝ I think there are crossroads in our lives when we make grand, sweeping decisions without even realizing it. Like scanning the newspaper headline at a red light, and therefore missing the rogue van that jumps the line of traffic and causes an accident. Entering a coffee shop on a whim and meeting the man you will marry one day, while he's digging for change at the counter. Or this one: instructing your husband to meet you, when for hours you have been convincing yourself this is nothing important at all.

Related Characters: Sara Fitzgerald (speaker), Kate Fitzgerald, Brian Fitzgerald

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 30-31

Explanation and Analysis

While waiting for Kate to be diagnosed, Sara decides to page Brian away from work—a heavy decision, given that Brian works as a firefighter and thus could be in the middle of an emergency at any given time during his shift.

Sara's musings about "crossroads" describe the seemingly insignificant decisions in life that go on to have enormous ramifications. This is important since, as Sara admits, she has been trying to convince herself that nothing major is happening as she waits for Kate in the hospital. However, her decision to call Brian away from work reveals the discrepancy between the façade of normalcy she's

Related Characters: Sara Fitzgerald, Brian Fitzgerald (speaker), Kate Fitzgerald

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 36

Explanation and Analysis

After Kate's diagnosis, Sara and Brian lie in bed and attempt to process what has happened. Brian suggests that the hospital that diagnosed her could be mistaken, and Sara vows that she will not let Kate die, which brings Brian to tears.

In this scene, both Sara and Brian show signs of being in denial about the reality of Kate's diagnosis. For Brian, this denial manifests as him doubting Kate's diagnosis entirely. Sara, on the other hand, is more willing to acknowledge Kate's diagnosis—but she isn't able to accept that this will likely lead to Kate's death. Both Brian's tears and Sara's own self-doubt, however, suggest that they both know she has much less power over the situation than she claims.

Sara's attitude here is indicative of her general approach to Kate's illness. Although she often does not know the path forward when it comes to saving Kate, she refuses to ever give up on her, no matter the odds. This is both to Sara's credit and detriment; while her faith in Kate allows her to always fight for her, this scene also foreshadows how her refusal to acknowledge a lack of control can not only be useless but can even deepen the emotional pain of the Fitzgeralds' ordeal.

4. Monday: Brian Quotes

☞ Anna's real name is Andromeda. It's on her birth certificate, honest to God. The constellation she's named after tells the story of a princess, who was shackled to a rock as a sacrifice to a sea monster—punishment for her mother Casseopeia, who had bragged to Poseidon about her own beauty. Perseus, flying by, fell in love with Andromeda and saved her. In the sky, she's pictured with her arms outstretched and her hands chained.

The way I saw it, the story had a happy ending. Who wouldn't want that for a child?

Related Characters: Brian Fitzgerald (speaker), Andromeda "Anna" Fitzgerald

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 43

Explanation and Analysis

Brian describes the process of naming Anna, whose full name is Andromeda after the mythological princess who was sacrificed in punishment for her mother's sins but was ultimately rescued. Brian says that he chose it because he liked that it had a happy ending, which he wanted for his daughter.

Brian's reasoning for Anna's full name is revealing, in that he focuses on the happy ending of the story rather than the suffering that Andromeda underwent beforehand. Notably, Andromeda suffers for her mother Casseopeia's actions—a subtle reflection of how Anna has suffered due to Sara's desperate desire to save Kate. The fact that Brian focuses less on this aspect is also a reflection of how, although he clearly loves Anna and wants the best for her, he is somewhat oblivious to the pain that Anna is in on behalf of her family.

The fact that Andromeda only gains freedom over her body after being rescued by Perseus is a moment of subtle irony—since Anna, in contrast, has chosen to save herself.

5. Tuesday: Anna Quotes

☞ "For God's sake, Anna," my mother says. "Do you even realize what the consequences would be?"

My throat closes like the shutter of a camera, so that any air or excuses must move through a tunnel as thin as a pin. *I'm invisible*, I think, and realize too late I have spoken out loud.

My mother moves so fast I do not even see it coming. But she slaps my face hard enough to make my head snap backward. She leaves a print that stains me long after it's faded. Just so you know: shame is five-fingered.

Related Characters: Andromeda "Anna" Fitzgerald, Sara Fitzgerald (speaker)

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 54

Explanation and Analysis

Shortly after Sara is served the papers for Anna's lawsuit, the tension between the two boils over back at the Fitzgerald's house, resulting in Sara ultimately slapping Anna across the face.

Sara's outburst of violence against Anna shows how her attempt to enact control over both her household and her own emotions have failed. While Sara has tried to retain her identity as a mother by protecting Kate, her quickness to hurt Anna is the exact opposite: an abject failure of motherhood, where she harms one of her own daughters rather than protecting her. Her slap, then, symbolizes the larger harm she's dealt to Anna throughout her life.

Anna's statement about being invisible also reveals her greater emotional state and suggests that her lawsuit is an attempt to be seen by her family, especially Sara. In a way, the fact that Sara's slap leaves a long-lasting emotional imprint on her ultimately gives Anna what she wanted, but in a tragically ironic way: she is no longer invisible to her mother, but Sara is not seeing her in a positive way.

6. 1990: Sara Quotes

☝☝ My first strike was marrying a guy without a college degree. My second and third were getting pregnant. I suppose that when I didn't go on to become the next Gloria Allred, [Suzanne] was justified in counting me a failure. And I suppose that until now, I was justified in thinking that I *wasn't* one.

Don't get me wrong, she loves her niece and nephew. She sends them carvings from Africa, shells from Bali, chocolates from Switzerland. Jesse wants a glass office like hers when he grows up. "We can't all be Aunt Zanne," I tell him, when what I mean is that I can't be her.

Related Characters: Sara Fitzgerald (speaker), Suzanne "Zanne" Crofton

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 60

Explanation and Analysis

Sara describes the rift between her and her older sister Suzanne, who has become wealthy by ascending the corporate ladder in contrast to Sara's stay-at-home life, which she chose rather than continuing to be a lawyer.

The tension between Sara and Suzanne suggests that the former feels some insecurity around the life she's chosen. Although Sara is shown to love being a mother and does not regret leaving the law, Suzanne's judgement of her life causes her to feel as though she's failed for choosing a "traditional" life for a woman rather than breaking barriers. With this in mind, it's understandable that Sara feels considerable pressure to perform well as a mother in order to prove herself to Suzanne.

In addition, Sara and Suzanne's relationship is a sharp contrast to Anna and Kate's relationship. While the latter sisters are very close and dependent on each other, the adult sisters are estranged and critical of each other. In this way, Picoult continues to explore the ways that sisterhood can both be deeply fulfilling and a source of emotional pain—sometimes simultaneously.

7. Wednesday: Campbell Quotes

☝☝ "Anna," I say, at the exact same moment as Sara Fitzgerald. It is my responsibility to explain to Anna that Judge DeSalvo wants a few minutes in private. I need to coach her, so that she says the right things, so that the judge doesn't throw the case out before she gets what she wants. She is my client; by definition, she is supposed to follow my counsel. But when I call her name, she turns toward her mother.

Related Characters: Campbell Alexander (speaker), Andromeda "Anna" Fitzgerald, Sara Fitzgerald

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 84

Explanation and Analysis

After Sara and Campbell meet with Judge DeSalvo to discuss Anna's uncertain motivations surrounding her lawsuit, the two lawyers go out to talk to Anna directly. When both of them call Anna's name simultaneously, Anna turns to look at Sara, not Campbell.

This moment depicts Anna's torn loyalties between her family and her desire to have more autonomy. Sara symbolizes the former, while Campbell represents the latter. In calling her name at the same time, the two of them give Anna a chance to reveal where her allegiance currently lies: with Sara, and thus, with her family. This is in spite of the fact that, as Campbell points out, Sara is working against Anna while Campbell has been designated to advocate for Anna's interests. Even so, Anna's instincts in favor of her mother win out, reflecting the broader struggle she has to prioritize her own desires rather than fear losing Sara's love.

9. Wednesday: Jesse Quotes

☝☝ It would solve a thousand problems if I rolled the Jeep over an embankment. It's not like I haven't thought about it, you know. On my license, it says I'm an organ donor, but the truth is I'd consider being an organ *martyr*. I'm sure I'm worth a lot more dead than alive—the sum of the parts equals more than the whole. I wonder who might wind up walking around with my liver, my lungs, even my eyeballs. I wonder what poor asshole would get stuck with whatever it is in me that passes for a heart.

Related Characters: Jesse Fitzgerald (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 94

Explanation and Analysis

While driving on the highway, Jesse daydreams about what would happen if he died in a car accident. He muses about how he would be willing to give up his life in order for others to have his organs, as he feels he's worth more dead than alive.

Jesse's suicidal tendencies in this quote, exacerbated by his desire to become an "organ martyr," encapsulates one of the

key elements of his character: his feeling of worthlessness to his family, especially in comparison to Anna. Because Jesse is not a match for Kate, he cannot donate to her, making him effectively “useless” in the context of Kate’s treatment while Anna is able to function as her savior. As a result, Jesse’s daydream, while self-destructive, reflects his desire to be helpful to other people. Within the broader context of his character, it shows how, although Jesse’s first impulses often bring him towards destruction, these impulses often disguise a profound desire to find a deeper purpose in the world.

10. 1990-1991: Sara Quotes

☞☞ The baby’s head slips through the seal of my skin. The doctor’s hand holds her, slides that gorgeous cord free of her neck, delivers her shoulder by shoulder.

I struggle to my elbows to watch what is going on below. “The umbilical cord,” I remind him. “Be careful.” He cuts it, beautiful blood, and hurries it out to the room to a place where it will be cryogenically preserved until Kate is ready for it.

Related Characters: Sara Fitzgerald (speaker), Andromeda “Anna” Fitzgerald, Kate Fitzgerald

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 104

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Sara gives birth to Anna. Immediately afterwards, Sara sits up to make sure her umbilical cord is preserved so that its blood can be donated to Kate.

Sara’s reaction to Anna’s birth is extremely revealing when it comes to her priorities. Rather than focusing on Anna herself, Sara’s first thought is her umbilical cord due to its ability to save Kate. This is in spite of the fact that she’s just given birth to her third daughter; notably, Anna’s name does not even appear in this scene, and there’s no description of what’s done with her after Sara gives birth to her. Given that this chapter is in first person from Sara’s point of view, this suggests that Sara is paying very little attention to her newborn due to her concern for Kate. In other words, this moment shows how Sara has always prioritized Kate over Anna—even at the moment of the latter daughter’s birth.

11. Wednesday: Julia Quotes

☞☞ For a minute I look at [Anna]. What would I do, if I found out that Izzy needed a kidney, or a part of my liver, or marrow? The answer isn’t even questionable—I would ask how quickly we could go to the hospital and have it done.

But then, it would have been *my* choice, *my* decision.

Related Characters: Julia Romano (speaker), Andromeda “Anna” Fitzgerald, Isobel “Izzy” Romano

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 111-112

Explanation and Analysis

In attempting to empathize with Anna’s plight, Julia imagines what she would do if Izzy needed a donation from her in order to survive. Julia feels assured that she wouldn’t hesitate in helping her sister, but she acknowledges that it would be her choice to make.

As a sister herself, Julia is, in some ways, in a better position to empathize with Anna than someone like Campbell, who is an only child. At the same time, it is precisely her closeness with Izzy that makes it difficult to imagine doing what Anna has decided to do. Her struggle to put herself in Anna’s shoes highlights the difficult position that Anna is in. Like Julia, she loves her sister dearly and truly does want Kate to be okay. However, Julia’s observation that she would be able to make the choice to save Izzy highlights why Anna’s love for Kate is not enough: while she does not want Kate to die, the lack of agency she has over the decision to save Kate means that it is not a selfless act of sisterly love, but coercion.

12. Wednesday: Campbell Quotes

☞☞ “Do you have kids?” Anna asks.

I laugh. “What do you think?”

“It’s probably a good thing,” she admits. “No offense, but you don’t exactly look like a parent.”

This fascinates me. “What do parents look like?”

She seems to think about this. “You know about how the tightrope guy at the circus wants everyone to believe his act is an art, but deep down you can see that he’s really just hoping he makes it all the way across? Like *that*.”

Related Characters: Andromeda “Anna” Fitzgerald, Campbell Alexander (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 124

Explanation and Analysis

After Campbell comes over to check on Anna, the two talk about parenthood. Campbell asks Anna what a parent looks like to her, and she compares it to a tightrope artist hoping that he doesn't fall.

Anna's comparison between parents and a tightrope artist illustrates her belief that parents don't really have any more control over their lives or decisions than their children do. Like a performer in a high-risk situation, they feel pressure to put on a brave face, since their children are depending on them to give them a sense of stability. However, beneath this façade, they are just as precarious and anxious as someone on a tightrope with no net beneath them.

The fact that Anna is able to pick up on the performative aspect of parenthood shows that she's growing up and losing her innocence. While young children often buy into the myth that their parents know anything, an important part of growing up is realizing that one's parents are just people like anyone else.

ostracized for his geekiness until he was diagnosed with multiple sclerosis

and everyone started being nice to him. Anna compares this to her own experience, as everyone has always been nice to her due to her reputation as Kate's sister.

Anna's recounting of Jimmy highlights how being seriously ill or having a seriously ill family member leads to a very specific type of isolation. Although it's not socially acceptable to explicitly ostracize someone for being ill, serious illness often causes other people to become uncomfortable and not know how to act around the person associated with it. This discomfort results in the superficial niceness that both Jimmy and Anna experience. Although this niceness is of course preferable to outright cruelty, it is isolating in its own way. After all, when everyone is nice to you all the time solely because you're in a difficult situation rather than because of who you are as a person, it makes their niceness lose any real meaning. Thus, the anecdote about Jimmy represents the similar type of sugarcoated alienation that Anna has experienced all her life.

☞ [Kate] sprinted, and nearly had it, but then Jesse took a running leap and slammed her to the ground, crushing her underneath him.

In that moment everything stopped. Kate lay with her arms and legs splayed, unmoving. My father was there in a breath, shoving at Jesse. "What the hell is the matter with you!"

"I forgot!"

My mother: "Where does it hurt? Can you sit up?"

But when Kate rolled over, she was smiling. "It doesn't hurt. It feels great."

My parents looked at each other. Neither of them understood like I did, like Jesse did—that no matter who you are, there is some part of you that always wishes you were someone else—and when, for a millisecond, you get that wish, it's a miracle. "He forgot," Kate said to nobody, and she lay on her back, beaming up at the cold hawk-eye sun.

13. Wednesday: Anna Quotes

☞ There was this kid in my school, Jimmy Stredboe, who used to be a total loser. He got zits on top of his zits; he had a pet rat named Orphan Annie; and once in science class he puked into the fish tank. No one ever talked to him, in case dorkhood was contagious. But then one summer he was diagnosed with MS. After that, no one was mean to Jimmy anymore. If you passed him in the hall, you smiled. If he sat next to you at the lunch table, you nodded hello. It was as if being a walking tragedy canceled out ever having been a geek.

From the moment I was born, I have been the girl with the sick sister. All my life bank tellers have given me extra lollipops; principals have known me by name. No one is ever outright mean to me.

Related Characters: Andromeda "Anna" Fitzgerald (speaker), Jimmy Stredboe

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 131

Explanation and Analysis

Anna describes one of her former classmates, who was

Related Characters: Andromeda "Anna" Fitzgerald, Kate Fitzgerald, Sara Fitzgerald, Brian Fitzgerald, Jesse Fitzgerald (speaker)

Related Themes:     

Page Number: 137-138

Explanation and Analysis

During Thanksgiving, Brian and the kids are playing touch

football, despite Sara's worry that Kate will get injured from roughhousing. Just before Kate scores a touchdown, Jesse tackles her without thinking, causing everyone to panic. However, Kate is not only uninjured, but elated.

Kate's happiness in this moment is largely caused by Jesse's defense of himself: "I forgot." As someone who's been fighting cancer for almost her entire life, Kate is rarely treated like a normal kid. In contrast, the Fitzgeralds' panic at her being tackled shows how she is often treated as incredibly fragile—a reasonable fear, given Kate's precarious health, but one that is undoubtedly frustrating for the adolescent Kate. The fact that Jesse forgot about Kate's condition in the heat of the game, therefore, allows her a brief moment of normalcy where she is able to fleetingly be someone else who doesn't have to be handled like a piece of fine china. Her joy at being tackled—something that would likely anger another kid—emphasizes just how lonely and isolating her cancer has been for her.

14. Thursday: Brian Quotes

☝☝ I'm a coward. There are times when my shift is over that I'll stay and roll hose, or put on a fresh pot of coffee for the crew coming in, instead of heading straight to my house. I have often wondered why I get more rest in a place where, for the most part, I'm roused out of bed two or three times a night. I think because in a firehouse, I don't have to worry about emergencies happening—they're supposed to. The minute I walk through the door at home, I'm worrying about what might come next.

Related Characters: Brian Fitzgerald (speaker)

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 142

Explanation and Analysis

Brian admits that he often stays longer at work than he needs to in order to avoid going home, calling himself a "coward" as a result. This admission is especially striking given Brian's profession. Rather than a calm and quiet job that could provide some solace from his home life, Brian works as a firefighter, meaning that his work constantly throws him into incredibly high-stakes emergencies. In other words, one would expect him to be eager to leave his job and return to his peaceful home life—but instead, it's the opposite.

Brian's desire to stay at work and his admission that he

rests better there emphasizes just how intense the situation at the Fitzgerald household is. Although Brian deals with emergencies at work, as he points out, a firehouse is a place where emergencies are expected. Furthermore, as an experienced firefighter, Brian usually knows how to handle the emergencies he faces at work. In contrast, while the emergencies at home are often quieter, their personal and unpredictable nature makes them harder for Brian to face.

15. Thursday: Julia Quotes

☝☝ I could ask [Kate] if she has talked to the nephrologists about a kidney transplant, if she has any particular feelings about undergoing so many different, painful treatments. But this is exactly what Kate is expecting me to ask, which is probably why the question that comes out of my mouth is completely different. "What do you want to be when you grow up?"

"No one *ever* asks me that." She eyes me carefully. "What makes you think I'm going to grow up?"

"What makes you think you're not? Isn't that why you're doing all this?"

Just when I think she isn't going to answer me, she speaks. "I always wanted to be a ballerina." Her arm goes up, a weak arabesque. "You know what ballerinas have? [...] Absolute control. When it comes to their bodies, they know exactly what's going to happen, and when."

Related Characters: Kate Fitzgerald, Julia Romano (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 160-161

Explanation and Analysis

While interviewing Kate, Julia briefly considers asking Kate about her treatment but instead decides to ask her what she wants to be when she grows up. Kate is surprised and says that she wants to be a ballerina due to the control they have over their bodies.

Kate's surprise and suspicion at Julia's question hints at her frustration with how people usually treat her due to her cancer. The fact that nobody ever asks her what she wants to be when she grows up shows how her family is constantly concerned with her short-term future but never has time to consider her long-term future—with the implication being that, due to her prognosis, nobody truly expects Kate to reach adulthood. Therefore, Julia's question is, in its own way, an expression of faith that Kate will survive.

In addition, Kate's answer that she'd like to be a ballerina illustrates what she wishes she had in her life. As Kate points out, being a ballerina requires one to have extreme control over one's own body. This lifestyle is in direct contrast to Kate's experience, in which her body is constantly changing at unexpected moments. In other words, Kate's desire to be a ballerina shows that she wishes to be healthy and have a body that does not always betray her.

what an important grounding force she is in Sara's difficult life. As Sara's sister, she recognizes how Sara's self-pity is holding her back and is in a position to show Sara tough love about it. However, it's also notable that Suzanne's words aren't empty: in this scene, she's treated Sara to a hotel stay, and also regularly gives material support to the Fitzgeralds in order to lessen their burden. In this way, this exchange encapsulates how Sara and Suzanne's sisterly relationship is important for Sara's emotional wellbeing—even when Suzanne tells her something she doesn't want to hear.

16. 1996: Sara Quotes

☝☝ "You are allowed to take a break, you know. No one has to be a martyr twenty-four/seven."

But I hear her wrong. "I think once you sign on to be a mother, that's the only shift they offer."

"I said *martyr*," Zanne laughs. "Not *mother*."

I smile a little. "Is there a difference?"

"Did you want to get your crown of thorns out of the suitcase first? Listen to yourself, Sara, and stop being such a drama queen. Yes, you drew a bad lot of fate. Yes, it sucks to you."

Bright color rises on my cheeks. "You have no idea what my life is like."

"Neither do you," Zanne says. "You're not living, Sara. You're waiting for Kate to die."

Related Characters: Sara Fitzgerald, Suzanne "Zanne" Crofton (speaker), Kate Fitzgerald

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 174-175

Explanation and Analysis

Suzanne takes Sara out to a hotel to give her a break, but Sara struggles to relax. When she rejects Suzanne's suggestion to take it easy, Suzanne criticizes her for being overdramatic and accuses her of wasting her life on waiting for Kate's death.

Suzanne and Sara's interaction sums up the latter's major character flaw: her life revolves around Kate's illness, treatment, and eventual death. This is especially signified by Sara's mishearing of "martyr" and "mother," which shows how she's come to conflate the two. In other words, she struggles to conceive of her own identity as a mother outside of the immense sacrifices it's required her to make; she no longer gets real joy out of motherhood for the sake of motherhood.

Suzanne's criticism of Sara is harsh, but it also highlights

17. Thursday: Anna Quotes

☝☝ I decided one day to force myself into imagining what it would be like after Kate died. That way, [...] when it really happened, I'd be ready.

I kept at it for weeks. [...] There were entire days when I did nothing but cry; others where I felt like I'd swallowed a lead plate; some more where I worked really hard at going through the motions of getting dressed and making my bed and studying my vocab words because it was easier than doing anything else.

But then, there were times when I let the veil lift a little, and other ideas would pop up. Like what it would be like to study oceanography at the University of Hawaii. Or try skydiving. Or move to Prague. Or any of a million other pipe dreams. I'd try to stuff myself into one of these scenarios, but it was like wearing a size five sneaker when your foot is a seven—you can get by for a few steps, and then you sit down and pull off the shoe because it plain hurts too much. I am convinced that there is a censor sitting on my brain with a red stamp, reminding me what I am not supposed to even *think* about, no matter how seductive it might be.

Related Characters: Andromeda "Anna" Fitzgerald (speaker), Kate Fitzgerald

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 178-179

Explanation and Analysis

Anna recounts how she attempted to prepare herself for her grief by imagining what it would be like if Kate died. The experience is immensely painful for her, but also causes her to think about the freedom she would experience without her obligation to Kate.

Anna's intensely conflicting emotions during her thought experience encapsulate her struggle to reconcile her love for Kate with her desire for an independent life. The details

about her being incapacitated by grief and forcing herself into a daily routine to avoid her pain show just how terribly Kate's death would affect her. On the other hand, Anna's fantasies about going to college faraway or moving to a foreign country represent all the different directions her life could go if she wasn't forced into being Kate's donor. However, her simile about trying to fit into a too-small sneaker illustrates the mental block she has on entertaining these fantasies for too long. After all, Anna was born specifically to save Kate; given that her identity is so strongly tied to this responsibility, it's unsurprising that she struggles to conceive of herself doing anything else with her life.

23. 1997: Sara Quotes

☹☹ "I won't let your sister take care of Kate," Brian says. "I'm supposed to take care of Kate." The hose falls to the ground, dribbles and spits at our feet. "Sara, she's not going to live long enough to use that money for college."

The sun is bright; the sprinkler twitches on the grass, spraying rainbows. It is far too beautiful a day for words like these. I turn and run into the house I lock myself in the bathroom.

A moment later, Brian bangs on the door. "Sara? Sara, I'm sorry." I pretend I can't hear him. I pretend I haven't heard anything he's said.

Related Characters: Sara Fitzgerald, Brian Fitzgerald (speaker), Kate Fitzgerald, Suzanne "Zanne" Crofton

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 238

Explanation and Analysis

After discovering that Brian lied to her and took money from Kate's education fund to pay for her treatment, Sara confronts him about why he didn't accept Suzanne's previous offer to pay for it in full. Brian says that he wants to be the one to help Kate and tells Sara that Kate won't live to need a college fund, upsetting Sara and causing her to run away.

Brian's dishonesty and refusal to take Suzanne's offer shows his desire to provide for his family, even against all logic. Although allowing Suzanne to pay for the entire treatment would cause significantly less strain on the Fitzgerald household, accepting her offer would mean Brian would have to acknowledge that he can't fix everything for his family by himself. His decision to hide his payment plan from Sara is a further manifestation of this, where he wants to

retain the illusion of control not only around Suzanne, but around his own family.

Brian's comment about Kate not needing a college fund, while somewhat callous, is also likely accurate—but Sara's reaction shows that she is not ready to accept this truth. While Brian's attempt to reclaim control manifests as him taking the helm on the financial aspect of Kate's treatment, Sara's reaction illustrates her refusal to acknowledge Kate's impending death. Thus, although the two are at odds, both are struggling with the reality of Kate's worsening condition.

27. 2001: Sara Quotes

☹☹ The paper [Brian] has been scribbling on falls out of his hands and lands at my feet; before he can reach it I pick it up. It is full of tearstains, of cross-outs. *She loved the way it smelled in Spring*, I read. *She could beat anyone at gin rummy. She could dance even if there wasn't music playing.* There are notes on the side, too: *Favorite color: pink. Favorite time of day: twilight. Used to read Where the Wild Things Are, over and over, and still knows it by heart.*

All the hairs stand up on the back of my neck. "Is this...a eulogy?"

By now, Brian is crying, too, "If I don't do it now, I won't be able to when it's really time."

I shake my head. "It's not time."

Related Characters: Sara Fitzgerald, Brian Fitzgerald (speaker), Kate Fitzgerald

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 265

Explanation and Analysis

During Kate's hospital stay due to severe hemorrhaging, Brian attempts to prepare himself for her death by drafting her eulogy. Sara, however, rejects this, claiming that it isn't Kate's time yet.

Brian's decision to draft a eulogy shows how his preparation for Kate's death is no longer just an abstract possibility, but an imminent scenario that he feels the need to ready himself for in a very real, concrete way. Writing Kate's eulogy while she's still alive is a deeply morbid act, but the various specific details he writes down about her show how deeply he loves her. These details also provide a tragic parallel to Kate's current situation; as she's dying, Brian forces himself to think of the moments when she was most full of life.

Sara, however, flatly refuses to prepare for Kate's death. Although she and Brian have been told to say goodbye, she believes that Kate will survive, once again highlighting her steadfast belief that Kate will win against her cancer. While her stubborn faith in Kate often backfires, the fact that this quote takes place in a flashback—with Kate still alive in the present-day narrative—shows that, in this instance, Sara's belief in Kate's survival will be vindicated.

30. Monday: Campbell Quotes

☝ You might remember the recent case of the firefighters in Worcester, Massachusetts, who were killed in a blaze started by a homeless woman. She knew the fire had started and she left the building, but she never called 911 because she thought she might get into trouble. Six men died that night, and yet the State couldn't hold this woman responsible, because in America—even if the consequences are tragic—you are not responsible for someone else's safety. You aren't obligated to help anyone in distress. Not if you're the one who started the fire, not if you're a passerby to a car wreck, not if you're a perfectly matched donor.

Related Characters: Campbell Alexander (speaker), Andromeda "Anna" Fitzgerald

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 293-294

Explanation and Analysis

In his opening statement, Campbell tells a story about a woman who caused the death of six firefighters by causing a fire that she didn't report. In the end, she wasn't charged for the tragedy.

Campbell's reasoning for bringing this up in his opening statement is to implicitly compare the woman to Anna. Although Anna's desire to refuse her own sister a life-saving organ donation might be objectionable based on solely emotional grounds, Campbell's job is not necessarily to make Anna's decision emotionally or morally palatable. Instead, his opening statement focuses on the legality of Anna's decision to withhold her kidney. His anecdote highlights how, even if someone's decision leads to terrible outcomes, that does not necessarily mean it's criminal or needs to be legally barred. In other words, his argument gets to the crux of the major question that defines the novel's conflict: how much should someone be required to sacrifice on behalf of another person's life?

31. Monday: Anna Quotes

☝ *What if I was the one who was sick? What if Kate had been asked to do what I've done? What if one of these days, some marrow or blood or whatever actually worked, and that was the end? What if I could look back on all this one day and feel good about what I did, instead of feeling guilty? What if the judge doesn't think I'm right?*

What if he does?

I can't answer a single one of these, which is how I know that whether I'm ready or not, I'm growing up.

Related Characters: Andromeda "Anna" Fitzgerald (speaker), Kate Fitzgerald

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 300

Explanation and Analysis

As the hearing for Anna's petition ramps up, Anna contemplates the gravity of what she's doing and the potential consequences of whatever verdict Judge DeSalvo hands down.

Anna's various anxieties in this quote illustrate her various doubts around her decision. First, while Anna's petition for emancipation is all about having control over her own body and life, her putting herself in Kate's position serves as a reminder that Kate arguably has even less control over her body; any decision Anna makes will have profound ramifications for Kate's life. The gravity of this is also reflected in the possibility that one of Anna's future donations will actually save Kate once and for all.

As Anna points out, none of these questions are easy to answer and thus concisely depict the emotional and moral conflict at the crux of her lawsuit. Anna has a right to make decision over her own body, and it's unlikely that her continued donations will save Kate given that she's already long outlived her initial prognosis. However, the very possibility that Anna could truly be Kate's savior makes it impossible for her to fight for emancipation with a clean conscience. Her guilt is reflected in her fear that Judge DeSalvo will rule in her favor; although it is technically what she wants, it also means she will have the agency—and responsibility—to try to answer all of these unanswerable questions.

32. 2002: Sara Quotes

☝☝ “Taylor already thinks you’re beautiful.”

“Well I don’t!” Kate cries. “I don’t, Mom, and maybe I want to just once.”

[...]

“We’ll sew something,” I suggest. “You can design it.”

“You don’t know how to sew,” Kate sighs.

“I’ll learn.”

“In a day?” She shakes her head. “You can’t fix it every time, Mom. How come I know that, and you don’t?”

Related Characters: Kate Fitzgerald, Sara Fitzgerald (speaker), Taylor Ambrose

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 317

Explanation and Analysis

After many hours of unsuccessfully shopping for a flattering prom dress, Kate laments how ugly she feels due to the effects her treatments have had on her physical appearance. Although Sara attempts to reassure her and then offers to sew her a dress, Kate rebuffs her support.

While the novel spends a great deal of time discussing Kate’s precarious physical health, this scene depicts the impact her cancer has on her mental health and self-esteem. As a teenager, it’s normal for Kate to become increasingly concerned with her physical appearance, especially given that she’s just entered her first romantic relationship. However, even though Sara is likely correct that Taylor already finds Kate beautiful, Kate still struggles with the fact that she doesn’t like the look of her own body. Her frustration highlights how severe illness does not just affect someone’s health, but every aspect of their life.

Furthermore, Sara’s attempt to reassure Kate shows the limits of her desire to fix everything for Kate. Her offer to learn to sew an entire dress in a single day is patently impossible; thus, it’s not surprising that Kate rejects it despite the confident face that Sara puts on. In other words, Sara’s understandable desire to make everything right for her daughter is ineffective in situations like this, where there is no concrete solution other than simply providing Kate support and sympathy.

☝☝ I don’t tell Kate something else Jenna Ambrose said—that afterward, she went inside and stared at her son, who wasn’t her son anymore. That she sat for five whole hours, sure he was going to wake up. That even now she hears noise overhead and thinks Taylor is moving around his room, that the half-second she is gifted before she remembers the truth is the only reason she gets up each morning.

Related Characters: Sara Fitzgerald (speaker), Kate Fitzgerald, Taylor Ambrose, Jenna Ambrose

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 321

Explanation and Analysis

After finding out about Taylor’s death, Sara hides the truth from Kate for a month. When she finally tells Kate, she hides the conversation she had with Taylor’s mother Jenna, who still finds herself in denial of her son’s death.

Sara’s description of Jenna’s words, which she still remembers clearly a month later, show the profound impact Taylor’s death has had on her. Although she was of course not as close with Taylor as Kate was, the fact that Taylor had the same illness as Kate—and in fact had a better prognosis—has understandably rattled Sara, hence her fixating on Jenna’s description of her own grief. Sara’s unease implies that Taylor’s death is in one sense a “test run” for Sara; Taylor’s death is a reminder that Kate, too, will likely die in her adolescence. Jenna’s denial is also a dark parallel to Sara’s denial: while Sara struggles to accept Kate’s imminent death, Jenna struggles to accept that her son has already died.

36. Tuesday: Campbell Quotes

☝☝ Can you tell me what the right answer is here? [...] Because I don’t know where to look for it. I know what’s right. I know what’s fair. But neither of those apply here. I can sit, and I can think about it, and I can tell you what should be and what ought to be. I can even tell you there’s got to be a better solution. But it’s been thirteen years, Mr. Alexander, and I still haven’t found it.

Related Characters: Brian Fitzgerald (speaker), Andromeda “Anna” Fitzgerald, Kate Fitzgerald, Campbell Alexander

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 346

Explanation and Analysis

Brian takes the stand with the intention of testifying in support of Anna's emancipation but is ultimately unable to do so. Instead, he admits to Campbell that, after over a decade of Kate's illness, he still can't figure out what he and Sara should do about it.

Brian's breakdown on the stand and his questions to Campbell encapsulate the difficult position he and Sara have been in ever since Kate's diagnosis. Although the decision to conceive Anna and ultimately force her into multiple donations is cruel on its face, it is harder to judge given that said decision has extended Kate's life a decade past her initial prognosis. Brian loves both of his daughters equally, but it is exactly this love that puts him into an impossible position: he can't prioritize the health of one daughter without it bringing harm or suffering to the other. In essence, Brian's emotional testimony represents the moral conundrum of bodily autonomy and parenthood that have defined Sara and Brian's lives for 13 years.

42. Wednesday: Anna Quotes

☹☹ "I'm sick of waiting for something that's going to happen anyway. I think I've fucked up everyone's life long enough, don't you?"

"But everyone's worked so hard just to keep you alive. You can't kill yourself."

All of a sudden Kate started to cry. "I know. I can't."

It took me a few moments to realize this meant she'd already tried before.

Related Characters: Andromeda "Anna" Fitzgerald, Kate Fitzgerald (speaker)

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 388-389

Explanation and Analysis

After discovering Kate contemplating suicide, Anna tells her that she can't give up so easily after years of struggle to keep her alive. Kate's tearful agreement makes Anna realize that Kate has already attempted suicide.

This conversation's revelation that Kate is suicidal greatly complicates the question of bodily autonomy that has been present throughout the novel. While the conflict surrounding Anna's petition has largely revolved around Kate's right to live, this quote raises the question about

whether Kate has the right to die. In the same way that nobody ever asked Anna if she wanted to keep undergoing invasive procedures in order to be Kate's donor, nobody ever asked Kate if she wanted to continue her intense treatment regimen, even as her prognosis grew worse and worse and her body began to deteriorate. In fact, this conversation reveals that Anna and Kate's motivations are not at odds at all: both of them want more control over their bodies and fates.

56. 2010: Kate Quotes

☹☹ There might be a morning when I wake up and her face isn't the first thing I see. Or a lazy August afternoon when I can't quite recall anymore where the freckles were on her right shoulder. Maybe one of these days, I will not be able to listen to the sound of snow falling and hear her footsteps.

When I start to feel this way I go into the bathroom and I lift up my shirt and touch the white lines of my scar. I remember how, at first, I thought the stitches seemed to spell out her name. I think about her kidney working inside me and her blood running through my veins. I take her with me, whenever I go.

Related Characters: Kate Fitzgerald (speaker), Andromeda "Anna" Fitzgerald

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 423

Explanation and Analysis

Years after Anna's sudden death, Kate ruminates on her grief. She wonders if, one day, her grief will fade—a possibility that frightens her, since it might also entail forgetting certain traits of Anna's. Whenever she feels this fear, she consoles herself with the reminder that Anna's blood, marrow, and kidney reside in her body.

The ending of the novel ties everything back to Kate and Anna's relationship. Although Anna is long gone, parts of her literally live on in Kate, who would not be alive without Anna's donations. In this way, the two sisters have literally given each other life: Kate by harboring Anna's memory and parts of her body, and Anna by undergoing donations that prolonged Kate's life long enough for her to overcome her cancer and kidney failure. In this way, Anna's act of donation, which was the novel's source of conflict, goes from an ethically fraught matter to an act of eternal sisterly love.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

1. MONDAY: ANNA

Anna reflects on how, when she was young, she was more fascinated with *why* babies were made than *how*. For instance, she wondered why certain families had more children than others, and now that she's 13, she finds people's reasons for having children even more baffling, mostly since most pregnancies seem to be accidental. This question fascinates Anna because, unlike many children, her parents deliberately conceived her for a specific purpose. When she was young and went to her parents after her big brother Jesse told her where babies came from, her parents not only gave her the usual discussion but explained to her how she was conceived via in vitro fertilization to save her sister Kate. Anna muses that, if Kate never got sick, she likely never would have been born. Thus, she feels that if the reason for her conception disappears, she will disappear too.

Anna goes to a pawnshop, where she prepares to sell a sentimental item. She takes out a locket that her father gave her when she was six after she donated bone marrow to Kate, since her father felt that she deserved a major present for the present she gave her sister. The pawn shop owner offers her 20 dollars, which Anna balks at but ultimately accepts. When she struggles to let go of the locket, the owner softens and tells her to tell her family she lost it.

Anna describes herself as a "freak" due to her appearance: skinny and flat-chested, mousy brown hair, and freckles. She theorizes that her odd appearance fits with her odd household. Although her parents tried to make things normal, Anna never really got a childhood due to her sister Kate's diagnosis, which meant her entire family always had death on the mind. Kate was diagnosed with acute promyelocytic leukemia when she was two and is now 16. While she is currently in remission, her cancer is likely to come back at some point. Anna is her allogeneic donor, meaning that she is a perfect genetic match who donates whatever Kate needs for her treatment. Anna tells the reader that this background means that they should not trust anything they hear about her, especially whatever she tells them.

Anna introduces herself to the reader by focusing on the most important moment of her life: not her birth, but her conception. In explaining how she was conceived to save her sister Kate, she highlights how her life has never fully been her own, even before she was born. Anna's sense that she will disappear if the reason for her conception disappears reinforces this by suggesting that she does not understand who she is without her responsibility for saving Kate.



Anna's selling of her locket suggests that she is in some sort of difficult situation. After all, the locket was gifted to her by her father during a very significant moment in her life, meaning she would not sell it unless she really needed the money. The owner of the pawn shop also seems to sense this, hence his softening demeanor.



The reveal of Kate's specific illness—leukemia—further establishes the high expectations that Anna has lived with for her entire life. Anna does not just save Kate in an abstract sense but is quite literally Kate's lifeline due to her status as an allogeneic donor. This means that, not only was Anna robbed of her childhood simply by the virtue of having a seriously ill sister, but by being responsible for keeping Kate alive. Anna's advice to the reader suggests that this has biased Anna's narration in some way, although she does not specify how.



Anna comes up the stairs of her house and encounters her mother, Sara, who is wearing a ball gown. Anna describes her mother as someone who could have been beautiful in another life, with long dark hair and a slender frame, but her expression is always on edge due to Kate's condition. She spends her small amount of free time buying evening dresses off of Bluefly.com. The one she shows off now is the color of the sunset and made of swishy material, "totally not the dress code for a suburban house in Upper Darby, RI." When Sara asks Anna how she looks, the only word Anna can think of is "tired," although she does not say this out loud.

Sara freezes suddenly, claiming she's heard something from Kate and Anna's room. The two of them go there to find Kate sobbing, at which point Anna feels the world collapse again. She describes how her father Brian, an amateur astronomer, explained to her how black holes are so heavy that they absorb everything around them. Moments like this, Anna explains, are just like black holes; anyone around is sucked into them.

Sara frantically asks Kate what's wrong while Anna waits in the doorway in case she needs to call someone. Kate is sweaty and her breathing is tight as she cries, but as Sara frantically tries to figure out what's wrong, Kate begins to cry about "Preston leaving Serena for good," at which point Sara and Anna realize she's crying over a soap opera. She sits down at the edge of Kate's bed—she's taller than Kate, although she's only 13—and mentally recounts the various soap opera stars Kate has had crushes on over the summer.

Anna and Kate discuss all of the soap opera's various plots, including an entire story line that Anna followed because she taped the episodes during Kate's dialysis sessions. Eventually, Kate notices Sara's dress and asks her what she's wearing; Sara says that she's sending it back and stands so that Anna can undo the zipper. Anna states that, although Sara's behavior is compulsive, it's more of a "healthy break" by her standards, given the intensity of Kate's illness. She wonders if Sara buys the dresses because she enjoys pretending to be someone else, or if she just likes being able to send back clothes that don't fit her.

Sara's penchant for purchasing fancy ball gowns is her way of escaping from her difficult life of parenting a child with cancer. As Anna points out, she could have had a different life had Kate not gotten sick, and her hobby of dressing up allows her to briefly indulge in this different life. However, Anna's description of her as tired and on-edge suggests that this form of escapism is temporary and ultimately ineffective.



The sudden shift from ball gowns to a potential medical emergency demonstrates how quickly the atmosphere in the Fitzgerald household can change. Anna's metaphor of a black hole illustrates this by suggesting that flareups in Kate's illness subsume everything else in the house.



The tension in the household dissipates as quickly as it formed; although Kate is sick, she is also a normal teenager who gets upset over frivolous things. Notably, although Anna is not especially partial to soap operas, she knows all of Kate's soap opera crushes, suggesting that she knows her sister quite well. This moment highlights how moments of normal teenage adolescence and sisterhood can persist even in extraordinarily circumstances.



Anna continues to show her devotion to Kate by learning the plots of her soap opera and taping her shows for her when Kate cannot watch them live. She also shows significant insight into Sara, who seems to have recognized the futility of dressing up in a fancy ball gown. Anna's question about Sara's motivations behind buying the dresses hints at Sara's need to execute more control over her life.



Sara leaves, after which Kate wilts slightly in her bed; Anna feels that she is fading bit by bit and fears that one day she won't be able to see her at all. Kate tells Anna to stop blocking the TV, to which Anna retorts that it's only commercials for other shows; to this, Kate says, "[I]f I die tonight I want to know what I'm missing." They watch TV together—with Kate getting the more comfortable pillows—and tease each other about their crushes on the actors. Eventually, though, Kate stops talking and rubs her lower back. Although she says it's fine, Anna knows it's her kidneys. The two of them hold their hands out to each other in an attempt to touch in the space between their beds. Anna recounts a nightmare where she's cut into so many pieces that she can't be put back together.

Anna recounts when Brian told her that a **fire** will burn itself out without oxygen. She muses that this might be what she's doing, but that sometimes one has to break a wall to escape a fire, too. After Kate falls asleep, she takes a binder that she hides under her mattress—she knows Kate's been snooping in it, but nothing's missing—and takes it into the bathroom. She counts her money, which comes to \$136.87 with the 20 dollars from the pawnshop. It isn't enough, but she wonders if she can get a loan, although she doubts her parents will cosign it, given what she's planning on using it for (which remains unclear). After counting her money, she reads newspaper clippings about a man named Campbell Alexander, who she says has a good track record.

Anna goes to her brother Jesse's room, which is located in the attic over the garage. The stairs are blocked with various objects, which Anna speculates Jesse uses to keep people out. Inside, Jesse's room is a mess aside from a collection of car hood ornaments that Anna believes he stole. Anna explains that it's not that her parents don't care about Jesse's delinquency, but that they don't have time to deal with it. Anna spots a batch of moonshine Jesse is making in a Crock-Pot. He offers her some, but when she sips it, it's so strong that she falls back onto his couch.

Jesse asks Anna what she wants. When she challenges his assumption that she wants something, he claims that "no one comes up here on a social call," and he would already know if it was something about Kate. Anna responds that it is about Kate in a sense; with this, she hands him the newspaper clippings, which she believes will explain the situation better than any words. Jesse looks over the clippings, then looks at Anna and warns her not to step outside of her role in the family: "Kate plays the Martyr. I'm the Lost Cause. And you, you're the Peacekeeper." Anna looks at him and asks who decided these roles.

Although Sara and Anna were mistaken in thinking that Kate was having an acute medical emergency, the ending of the scene in her room serves as a reminder that her illness is serious and all-consuming. She's growing visibly sicker, and Anna notices that she's dealing with pain in her kidneys. Anna's nightmare about being cut into pieces suggests that Kate's worsening illness distresses her not only because she cares for her sister, but because Kate's illness means Anna will once again have to act as a savior.



Anna's sneaking about after Kate falls asleep ties the narrative back to her encounter at the pawnshop. While it is still not explicit what she is saving money for, the fact that she is saving money and doing research via newspaper clippings illustrates that she has been planning something major (and expensive). The metaphor of her escaping a fire, as well as her attempt to keep her plan secret, also suggests that whatever she is planning might be disruptive to her household in some way.



Jesse's introduction firmly establishes his role in the family as the delinquent son. Not only is his behavior transgressive—as shown by his Crock-Pot moonshine—but the location of his room physically isolates him from the rest of his family. That Sara and Brian have essentially given up on rehabilitating him shows just how strained the household has become due to Kate's illness.



Anna's plan is still shrouded in mystery, but Jesse's reaction to it provides more clues as to its nature. His warning to stay within her role as the "Peacekeeper" further suggests that whatever Anna's planning on doing will cause discord in the family. However, Anna's defiant response that these roles should not be immutable shows that she is determined to follow through on her plan despite the potential consequences.



Jesse drives Anna to Campbell Alexander, Esquire's office, agreeing to wait for her in the parking lot. Campbell's office is gaudy and luxurious, making Anna self-conscious about her casual appearance. When she enters, she finds the secretary on a heated phone call. The secretary eventually addresses Anna, who cites her four o'clock appointment with Campbell. The secretary responds by stating that she didn't realize how young Anna was and that the office does not try juvenile cases, but Anna interrupts and cites multiple juvenile cases that Campbell has tried in the past year. The secretary, impressed, allows Anna to wait in Campbell's office.

Campbell's office is full of books, and his desk is extremely neat. However, Anna is intrigued by an out-of-place mug of water on the floor and begins to come up with various theories as to its purpose, such as a swimming pool for ants or a humidifier. As she speculates, Campbell enters with a German shepherd who makes a beeline to the mug and drinks from it. Campbell is tall and dark-haired; he takes off his suit jacket and removes a file from his cabinet without looking at Anna. As he sits, he tells her that he doesn't want Girl Scout Cookies and pages his secretary to ask why Anna is here. Anna tells him that she wants to retain him. Campbell immediately refuses her, but she says he doesn't even know if she has a case.

Anna steps towards Campbell's dog and notices it's wearing a vest with a red cross on it. She reaches out to pet it, and Campbell immediately tells her not to because the dog, Judge, is a service dog. Anna points out that Campbell isn't blind; Campbell sarcastically thanks her for letting him know. Anna asks Campbell what's wrong with him, then immediately regrets it, recalling all the times Kate has received similarly invasive questions. Campbell tells her that he has an iron lung and that Judge keeps him from getting too close to magnets, then tells her to leave so that Kerri can get her a referral to another attorney.

Anna takes out her newspaper clippings and asks Campbell if he really sued God. Campbell explains that no, he didn't. He sued Providence's Diocese on behalf of a child in an orphanage, Dylan Jerome, who needed experimental treatment using fetal tissue, which the Church would not approve of. However, "suing God" made a better headline, and Campbell concedes that the boy wanted to sue God for not caring enough about him. Anna explains that Kate has leukemia, to which Campbell replies that she can't file a case on Kate's behalf. Anna doesn't know how to explain the years of painful donations she's undergone and the major decision her family is about to make without her, so she simply tells Campbell the simple version: she wants to sue her parents for the right to her own body.

Anna's arrival at Campbell's office reveals a key part of her mysterious plan: she has been saving up for a lawyer and has even scheduled an appointment. The unusual nature of this decision is illustrated by the juxtaposition of Campbell's fancy office and Anna's humble appearance. However, Anna ultimately proves herself by rebutting the secretary's claim that Campbell doesn't accept juvenile cases—a moment that establishes Anna as strong-willed and opinionated.



Although Anna has undertaken the mature decision to seek out a lawyer, her imaginative scenarios for the mug on Campbell's floor serve as a reminder that she is still young girl. However, this moment of childish whimsy is shattered by the mundane revelation that it is water for a dog—effectively bringing Anna back into the real, painfully adult world. The harshness of this world is further embodied by Campbell, who immediately refuses her despite not hearing her case. Despite this, Anna continues to exert her strong will and argue against him.



Campbell's introduction has painted him as a smarmy and egotistical lawyer—and while the revelation that Judge is a service dog doesn't necessarily reverse this impression, it does complicate it by suggesting that Campbell has his own health issues. However, he refuses to open up to Anna about these issues, instead choosing to tell her an obvious lie about Judge's purpose as a defense mechanism against her invasive question.



Campbell's case against the Diocese establishes him as a competent lawyer—but the fact that Anna stumbled on him by finding this sensationalist story in the paper serves as a reminder that she doesn't completely know what she's doing in this situation. Even so, the issue of the case itself, which involved issues of bodily autonomy and medical treatments, seems to be of interest to Anna. The reason for this comes at the end of the chapter, when Anna finally reveals the full extent of her plan: to escape her status as a donor by suing her parents.



2. MONDAY: CAMPBELL

Campbell reflects on how his father, the first Campbell Alexander, used to say that “when you only have a hammer, everything looks like a nail.” Campbell interprets this as the way that people who have been backed into a corner will do anything to claw their way out, which can either mean getting into a physical fight but can also mean filing a lawsuit. Campbell looks at the Post-its on his desk and sees a note from Kerri telling him that his mother called four times. Campbell throws the note away.

Anna waits patiently for Campbell’s response. Campbell, upon hearing that she wants to sue for bodily autonomy, immediately decides to reject the case. He asks for her name, then calls down the hall for Kerri to bring her the number for Planned Parenthood. Anna, shocked, stands up and protests. Campbell tells her that filing a lawsuit because her parents won’t allow her access to birth control or abortion is overkill and advises her to go to Planned Parenthood again. Anna, enraged, responds that Planned Parenthood can’t help with her situation: Kate is dying, and Sara wants her to donate a kidney to save her.

Kerri arrives with the Planned Parenthood phone number, but Campbell closes the door in her face—a move that, in retrospect, he views as having chosen one path in a forked road. He argues that no one can make Anna donate an organ against her consent, but she responds with a long list of times she donated: first her cord blood as a newborn, then lymphocytes—which took three drawings to get enough—then bone marrow, then granulocytes, then peripheral blood stem cells. Campbell muses that her medical vocabulary could put expert witnesses to shame.

Campbell states that she must have consented to these procedures, but Anna claims that nobody ever asked. When Campbell tells her that they might listen to her if she talks to them, she states that they don’t pay attention to her outside of using her as a donor, and that she wouldn’t be alive if not for Kate’s illness. She tells Campbell that, when she was conceived, her parents deliberately chose the embryo that was a perfect genetic match to Kate. Campbell muses about the hot debate over stem cell research, including issues such as the ethics of “spare-parts babies” and “designer babies.”

Campbell’s recollection of his father illustrates how his upbringing trained him to view things through the lens of conflict; his version of a fight is not a literal fistfight, but a lawsuit. However, his father’s harsh attitude, along with Campbell refusing to call his mother back, suggests that this dog-eat-dog attitude has left Campbell emotionally isolated from his family and others.



After hearing that Anna wants to sue for the rights to her own body, Campbell immediately writes her off as a pregnant teenager without hearing her full story. His quick disregard for her plight reflects the flippant attitude he’s developed towards other people during his time as a lawyer. Anna, however, continues to stand her ground, refusing to leave his office before she can explain what she’s been dealing with.



Campbell’s hard exterior cracks ever so slightly when he decides to hear Anna out, suggesting he is not always as icy as he presents himself to be. Anna is also fortunate that her situation is a legally complex one, and therefore piques Campbell’s interest as a lawyer. In other words, Anna’s strong will has begun to win Campbell over—although, so far, he still seems to view her more as an interesting case rather than a person.



While the backstory that Anna provides here is not completely new, the fact that she feels completely unheard by her parents contextualizes why she’s decided to do something as drastic as file a lawsuit. Furthermore, Campbell’s musings of the ethics of stem cell research highlights how Anna’s individual predicament is tied to broader debates over societal issues such as reproductive rights and eugenics.



He asks Anna what will happen if she doesn't donate her kidney, to which Anna answers that Kate will die. When Campbell asks her if she's okay with that and why she's choosing now of all times to file suit, Anna simply says that "it never stops." She takes out the \$136.87 she's saved and tells him she'll figure out a way to pay him more, but she's shocked when Campbell tells her that he charges \$200 per hour. He tells her that he'll work something out, jokingly telling her that she can polish his doorknobs. From there, he runs through the process of her case: he'll file a petition, there will be a hearing, and Anna will be appointed a guardian ad litem. He tells her to call if she has any questions, and she, in turn, gives him her number in case he has any questions.

After Anna leaves, Campbell walks out to the reception area, where Kerri tells him that his mother claims his father is shacking up with a teenager and that she is threatening to commit herself. Campbell largely disregards this and turns to Anna's case, telling Kerri that the office is representing her. Kerri balks at this, asking where Anna will live when her parents find out she's suing them. Campbell hasn't really thought about it, but before he can answer, Judge nudges his side. He tells Kerri to give him 15 minutes. When she pushes and tells him Anna can't take care of herself, he tells her that it's not his problem and leaves.

3. 1990: SARA

Jesse spots a bruise between Kate's shoulder blades during their bath, but it doesn't appear to hurt. While Sara bathes the children, Brian tells her about an insurance case involving a man who "burned" his cigars by smoking them. Jesse presses hard on Kate's bruise, causing her to scream in pain. Sara passes her to Brian and orders Jesse out of the bath, but he slips and hits his knee as he gets out. Sara picks him up and soothes him as she continues to talk to Brian about the case, which he spoke as an expert witness in; the defendant was sentenced to a count of arson for every cigar. Brian was called because he is a firefighter who knows how to locate the source of a **fire** even in a destroyed structure.

Sara used to be a civil attorney but changed her life path and became a stay-at-home mother when she realized how much she enjoyed parenthood. Her sister Suzanne, who works in finance, hates this for her, feeling it's a waste of her life, but Sara feels that she is a much better mother than she would have been a lawyer. She wonders if there are other women who found their true calling in life by "going nowhere" rather than pursuing a career. When Brian asks her if she misses the courtroom, Sara says that she misses it "like a root canal."

The previous chapter established that Anna is close to Kate and loves her dearly, which makes Anna's declaration that she will pursue her lawsuit despite Kate dying without a kidney all the more striking. The contrast between her love for Kate and her determination for autonomy emphasizes just how dire the lack of control in her life has become. Campbell, too, seems to recognize this to some degree, since, although he is an expensive lawyer, he agrees to take on her case pro bono.



Although Campbell has done Anna a great service by taking on her case free of charge, his lack of a good answer to Kerri's question shows that he hasn't truly thought through the potential interpersonal consequences for Anna if she pursues her case. His thoughtlessness once again reflects how he sees Anna as a client first and a person second and foreshadows the potential implosion that Anna's lawsuit will cause in her family.



The first scene of Sara's flashback chapters, Jesse and Kate's bath time provides a quaint picture of the hectic life of parenthood. Sara and Brian nonchalantly discuss their days while wrestling their crying children, showing how accustomed they are to the chaos of raising a family. At first glance, there's nothing unusual about their night—but given that the novel has already established Kate's leukemia, the bruise between her shoulder blades takes on a more ominous meaning for the reader.



Sara and Suzanne are the second pair of sisters introduced in the novel, but unlike Kate and Anna, the two adult sisters are somewhat estranged. The distance between them reflects the struggles of womanhood, with Sara feeling that she failed her sister for choosing a more "traditional" life as a stay-at-home mother. However, Sara's pride in her parenthood outweighs her guilt over abandoning the law.



The next morning, Brian is at work by the time Sara wakes up at nine o'clock. She rushes downstairs to find that Jesse has gotten milk and cereal all over the kitchen. When she asks him where Kate is, he tells her that she's still sleeping—this is unusual, and Sara wonders if she's coming down with a cold. She goes to wake Kate up, then pulls off her pajama top. A trail of blue bruises is running down Kate's spine.

At the pediatrician's office, Sara asks the doctor, Dr. Wayne, if it could be anemia. Dr. Wayne says it could be a virus and asks for a blood test. When Jesse hears this, he scares Kate by describing the needle she'll be stuck with. Kate looks to Sara for reassurance, and Sara tells her that it will only be a small shot. But when the nurse comes in with the needles, Kate begins to cry, and although she's briefly comforted by Sara's claim that it will only be a tiny pinch, she wails throughout the blood draw. However, by the third vial, she has gone completely limp. Sara doesn't know whether this or the screaming is worse.

After an hour of waiting, Dr. Wayne calls the family back in and informs them that Kate's white cell count is extremely low. He speculates that it could be an autoimmune disorder or even a lab error, but he refers them to a hematologist to redo the tests just to be safe. Sara is exasperated at having to repeat the ordeal, but pauses when she sees that the hematologist, Ileana Farquard, specializes in both hematology and oncology. Sara points this out, waiting for Dr. Wayne to reassure her that it's simply part of the doctor's title and has nothing to do with Kate's tests. Dr. Wayne, however, does not reassure her.

Sara calls Brian's work and discovers that he's on a call. Sara hesitates, looking down at Kate in the hospital waiting room. She reflects on how, in life, there are moments where one makes major, life-changing decisions without even realizing it. She cites her decision to summon Brian away from his call—even though she's trying to convince herself nothing significant is happening—as one of these decisions.

After three hours of waiting, the Fitzgeralds are seen by a resident, who asks them various questions about Kate's medical history. A phlebotomist comes in and asks for a coag panel, which would involve more needles. Sara asks for a finger stick, but the phlebotomist claims that this is the "easiest way," which causes Sara to get into an argument about how none of this is easy for her or Kate. The phlebotomist storms away and Brian tries to calm Sara down, but she tells him that she can't calm down when nobody is telling them what's going on. Brian hugs her and tells her it's going to be alright, and for the first time ever, she doesn't believe him.

As with the night before, Sara's day starts immersed in the chaos of parenthood, with Jesse's breakfast mishap providing a humorous interlude in the chapter. However, this idyllic family life is instantly shattered by the discovery of the bruises on Kate's spine—a clear sign that something is very wrong.



The description of Kate's protracted blood test is excruciating to read, emphasizing the difficulty of bringing such a young child into an intense medical setting—an experience Sara will tragically become accustomed to. That Kate eventually gives up resisting also signifies how she will ultimately become accustomed to invasive medical procedures as she grows older and sicker.



The results of Kate's blood tests are concerning, but Sara is initially still in denial about the gravity of it, as evidenced by how her first reaction to repeating the tests is exasperation at the inconvenience. However, much like the shift that came with discovering Kate's bruises, the revelation that Dr. Farquard is an oncologist further destroys the illusion that Sara will be able to continue parenting her children as she has so far.



Brian is a firefighter, meaning that at any given point during his shift, he could be saving someone's life. With this in mind, Sara's decision to call him away from work holds immense gravity. Although Sara is still acting as though everything is fine, her decision to do this reveals that, deep down, she knows that her family is about to undergo a major and traumatic change.



Picoult continues to focus on the pain and suffering Kate undergoes through her medical tests, which in turn signifies the suffering that the entire family is undergoing. Sara's argument against Kate's coag panel reflects her desire to enact control over the situation and protect Kate's bodily autonomy, but her anger is unable to change anything about the larger fact: that Kate is likely very sick and will have to continue suffering like this for a long time to come.



Dr. Farquard returns after being gone for several hours and tells Sara and Brian that Kate's white blood count is very low. This, in addition to some other aspects of her tests, leads Dr. Farquard to believe that Kate has leukemia—specifically, acute promyelocytic leukemia. Brian asks if Kate is going to die, to which Dr. Farquard explains that Kate would have a prognosis of nine months to three years with aggressive treatment. Sara thinks of the week before, when she and Brian talked about Kate's eventual wedding dress. Dr. Farquard reassures them that kids beat the odds every day while Sara looks down at Kate, feeling that this whole thing must be a mistake. She thinks that, although she's only known Kate two years, every memory they have together would reach forever if stretched end to end.

The doctors bring Kate in for a bone marrow extraction. She's taped down to the examination table, with one of the nurses stroking Kate's hand even after she's been knocked out from the anesthesia. When they turn her face to the side, the paper beneath her face is wet. Sara learns from Kate that you don't have to be awake to cry.

On the drive home from the hospital, Sara is struck with the feeling that the entire world is inflatable, that she could veer the car through a fence and it would simply bounce back into place. While she drives, she plays animal sounds with Kate, who is eating animal crackers. While they play, Sara thinks about what Kate's death will look like. Kate asks what giraffes say, to which Sara answers that giraffes don't say anything. When Kate asks why, Sara says that that's how they're born. After this answer, she can't bring herself to speak anymore.

Sara drops Jesse off with a neighbor in order to care for Kate, since her and Brian's only babysitters are in high school and both her and Brian's parents are dead. When she enters the kitchen, Brian is on the phone talking casually to a friend of his from the fire academy; when asked, he tells his friend that the kids are doing great. Sara stares silently at him after he hangs up the phone, and he admits that he couldn't bring himself to tell his friend the truth.

With Kate's formal diagnosis of APL, the normal life the Fitzgeralds have had up to this point has come to a devastating end. The brutal contrast between their now-past peaceful life and Kate's impending death is tragically illustrated by the memory of Sara and Brian discussing what Kate will be like on her wedding. This memory shows how easily Sara and Brian had assumed that Kate would make it into adulthood; the idea of her dying before the age of five was literally unthinkable until now.



In the previous scenes in which Kate was subjected to tests, she often screamed and put up a fight. Here, she is unable to do so due to the anesthesia, but her tears illustrate the constant suffering she's undergone. Worse still, she is losing her ability to fight back against the pain she's being subjected to.



Sara's imagining that the whole world is inflatable and fake reflects the way that the reality she's come to know has completely collapsed; it's difficult for her to imagine the world as a real place given what's happening to her daughter. This discrepancy is furthered by the fact that Kate is too young to understand what's happening to her and is proceeding as normal.



Although Sara and Brian have begun to realize how dramatically their life has changed, Brian is not yet at the point where he can talk about this to people outside his household. In this way, the Fitzgeralds are already becoming isolated from the world around them due to the extraordinary circumstances Kate's illness has thrown them into.



That night, Sara and Brian lie awake in bed next to each other, silent. Sara runs through various reasons that this is happening to them: she yelled at Jesse; she didn't buy Kate the M&Ms she wanted; she briefly thought what her life would have been like without kids. Next to her, Brian asks if she thinks they gave Kate the cancer through their genes. Sara doesn't answer, so he continues, claiming that the hospital doesn't know what they're doing—implying that they could be wrong about Kate's prognosis. Sara tells him that she won't let Kate die. Brian begins to cry into her shoulder; she repeats her promise, but she knows that it's a hollow one.

In trying to process Kate's illness, both Sara and Brian try to rationalize why it's happening. Sara leans more towards magical thinking, imagining that she's facing a sort of divine retribution for occasionally struggling with parenthood. Brian is more empirical by theorizing that their genetics passed the cancer to Kate. However, in both cases, Sara and Brian put the blame on themselves. Sara's vow to save Kate is also an attempt to enact order on the situation, since she and Brian both know there's only so much she can do.



4. MONDAY: BRIAN

Back in the present, Brian is watching sparks shoot out of an incinerator chimney at Brown University's medical school, whose dean is standing next to him. Nobody is inside the building except for the body that started the **fire**, which was disposed of after an anatomy class. Brian contemplates whether to bring a hose up, and the dean impatiently asks if he's going to do something. But Brian, knowing that bringing in a hose would spread biohazardous waste, is leaning more towards keeping the furnace closed and letting the fire burn out. He tells the dean that he's going to wait and see.

The dean's impatience is contrasted with Brian's slow deliberation, showing how the latter is a thoughtful person able to think through decisions before making them. The fact that he has learned this skill through firefighting is even more striking, since he's able to objectively assess a situation that most people instinctively want to rush into. In this case, Brian understands that it's better to "wait and see" if the fire burns out than rush in and potentially cause more destruction.



Brian goes home to eat his first of two dinners, which he spends with his family before the night shift. Sara prepares a pot roast, and Kate comes down looking worse due to her dialysis. Jesse, who is required to eat with the family, comes in smelling of marijuana, which Kate complains about. Sara asks them to stop arguing, and Kate asks where Anna is. Everyone realizes they haven't seen Anna since this morning. Kate shows off a shirt with a crab and the word Cancer on it. Sara, upset and holding back tears, tells her that she's a Leo.

The Fitzgeralds' dinner serves as the first scene where the family is gathering together in its entirety (sans Anna for now) and thus reveals the discord within the family. Jesse coming to the table stoned, Kate's dislike of it, and Sara's upset reaction at Kate's shirt all point to an unhappy situation. Brian, notably, does not partake in any of these tense interactions.



Anna comes in and sits down. She avoids Kate's question about where she's been and does not serve herself. This strikes Brian as unusual, since Anna is usually talkative and vivacious; her lack of energy throws off the feeling of the entire dinner. He asks Anna if she's okay, but Anna, thinking the question is for Kate, looks over at her. When she realizes Brian is talking to her, she deflects his questions and hurriedly serves herself food. Brian reminisces about when he would sing to the kids in the car when they were little.

Anna's surprise at being acknowledged by Brian drives home just how neglected she tends to be by the rest of the family. Well-accustomed to Kate being the center of attention, it does not even occur to her that Brian might be checking in with her. Even so, Brian immediately notices that something is off, suggesting that he is in-tune with Anna's emotions even if his job often keeps him away.



Kate notices that Anna's locket is missing and asks if she lost it. Anna responds by saying that she's just not in the mood to wear it, which again strikes Brian as strange, since she's never taken it off as far as he knows. Sara tells Kate to change her shirt, but Kate says that it's no more offensive than Jesse's metal band shirts. Sara cuts into the roast and is dismayed to find that it's overcooked, but Brian is able to cheer her up by making a joke about cooking it even more with a blowtorch. Just then, Brian realizes that Anna has left the table—and, more than that, nobody even noticed.

Brian returns to the station and has dinner with his coworkers: Red, who's cooking; Paulie, who's reading a newspaper; and Caesar, who's writing a love letter to his newest dalliance. The guys tease Caesar about his affair and ask Brian to give him advice, since he's the only one in a successful marriage. Brian compares a woman to a **fire**: they're beautiful and can bring you light and warmth when contained, but they require an offensive approach when they get out of control. Paulie jokes that Caesar needs to keep his date away from crosswinds.

The men sit down for dinner—Brian's second of the evening. They reminisce about the last time they had to deal with a stuck dead body, where an overweight man who died of heart failure was too heavy for the funeral home to transport. They also discuss who will have to clean up the body at Brown, but Brian suspects that the fire was so hot that there will be nothing left to clean. Paulie states that at least this one isn't arson, since the town has had a rash of intentional fires in the past month. Caesar jokes that maybe the man in the furnace was a "suicide arsonist," and Paulie adds that maybe he burned himself to lose weight. Brian, offended by their callousness, leaves the table and goes up to the roof.

On the roof, Brian looks at the **stars**. If he weren't a fireman, he would be an astronomer due to his love for the heavens, which remind him that the world is much bigger than him. Anna's real name is Andromeda, which is a reference to the Greek myth of a princess who was captured as a sacrifice to a sea monster but ultimately freed from her chains. He hopes that his children will have a similarly happy ending, but he knows that it likely won't be so for Kate; he's gone from dreaming about her wedding to having no expectations of her survival at all. Although she's defied the odds, he knows she's going to die; her kidneys have begun to break down from the strain of her treatment. He looks through his telescope and muses about how stars are just fires that burn for millennia. When they run out of fuel, they explode into supernovas, whose deaths are tremendously bright and visible to everyone.

The absence of Anna's sentimental locket is another alarm bell, but Sara quickly turns the focus back to Kate's shirt—illustrating how Kate's illness is always a higher priority than Anna's emotions, at least for Sara. This fact is painfully driven home by the revelation that Anna has managed to leave the table without anyone noticing; she is invisible to most of the family unless she is actively working as Kate's savior.



Brian's advice about women is somewhat tongue-in-cheek, but also hints at how his relationship with Sara has changed since Kate's diagnosis. Although the two clearly still care for each other, Sara's high emotions at Brian's first dinner suggest that her strong-willed demeanor can be both a boon and a source of tension in the family—much like the double-edged sword of fire that Brian describes here.



The other firefighters have an easy time making light of death, but Brian has a strong negative reaction to their callousness. The discrepancy between their reactions highlights how Brian's situation, in which death is always close by, has made it difficult for him to partake in dark humor. As a result, he is not only emotionally disconnected from the humorous conversation but also has to physically isolate himself from his colleagues.



Brian's love of stars and mythology reveals his sentimental and imaginative nature, which he draws upon when reflecting on his two daughters. For Anna, he dreams of giving her a happy ending, but her namesake was first sacrificed for another—a nod to how Anna is often sacrificed for Kate, even if she still has the potential to grow up. Brian's conception of Kate is much darker: he knows that she's going to die and thus associates her more closely with a dying star. Even so, he conceives of Kate's death as a supernova, something as beautiful as it is universe-altering.



Earlier, after his first dinner, Brian asks Sara if she thinks something's wrong with Anna, but Sara brushes him off, saying that Anna's doing fine "compared to Kate's kidneys and Jesse's sociopathy." Brian is at a loss as to what it could be, so Sara posits that perhaps Anna is just being a teenager. Brian tries to think back to when Kate was 13, but all he can remember are her treatments, not the ordinary parts of her life. Sara asks Brian how Kate looked to him, and though he noticed her jaundiced skin and tired posture, he lies to Sara and says that Kate looks great. Sara tells him to tell the kids goodnight and goes to sort Kate's medication.

Back at the station, things are quiet. The hatch to the roof opens; Anna has come to see Brian. He's initially worried something has happened, but Anna simply wants to visit, having been dropped off by Sara. She looks through his telescope, and Brian takes the opportunity to look at her, noticing that she's starting to enter womanhood. He asks her if she has anything she wants to talk about, but she counters by asking him to talk to her. He tells her about the **constellation** Vega, which is a part of Orpheus's lyre, then tells her the story of Orpheus himself and his lover Eurydice, whom Orpheus wouldn't let be taken by Death. Anna asks to stay the night with him, then asks if Orpheus's attempt to save Eurydice worked. Brian says no, and Anna is unsurprised and resigned.

5. TUESDAY: ANNA

Anna recounts how she used to pretend that she was simply passing through her family, which felt plausible to her due to her lack of resemblance to her parents or siblings. She used to sit in the hospital cafeteria and look at nearby families, wondering which one of them would reunite with her and whisk her away to a more glamorous life in another country. Even so, Anna admits that the first person she would want to call and tell about this turn of fate would be Kate.

Anna accompanies Kate to her dialysis session, where Anna's donated blood cycles through her body via a catheter in her chest. The procedure isn't painful, but it is boring, so Kate sometimes plays games with Anna to pass the time. Today, she reads a magazine. Sara is reading a pamphlet about kidney transplants and tells Kate that they won't take out her old kidney, just transplant in the new one. Kate is creeped out by this, imagining a coroner cutting into her and seeing three kidneys. Sara points out that the point of the transplant is so that no coroner will cut into her any time soon. Anna thinks about how the new kidney they're discussing is hers. Although kidney donation is considered safe, there is a 1 in 3,000 chance of death and potential long-term complications.

Sara brushes off Anna's odd mood by comparing her to Jesse and Kate, which parallels Jesse's earlier comment to Anna that all three children have "roles" in the family: since Kate and Jesse both have tragic roles, Sara automatically views Anna as the most stable figure of the three. Reading Anna's moods is even more difficult since, due to Kate's illness, Brian and Sara have no sense of "normal" adolescent mood swings; it's impossible to tell if Anna is going through normal moodiness or not, but it's easier for Sara and Brian to assume that she is doing well in order to minimize the issues they have to deal with in their family.



Anna continues to be cagey around Brian, but her desire to come visit him at work—even as she initiates a lawsuit against him—suggests that she still views him as an emotional support pillar in her life. Brian's story of Orpheus and Eurydice, a classic tragedy, reflects the eternal struggle of humans to escape death. Anna's lack of surprise that Orpheus failed suggests that, like Brian, she feels that saving Kate from her fate is impossible.



Anna's fantasies of escaping her family illustrate her conflicted feelings towards them. The fact that she doesn't even look like her family members exacerbates her sense of isolation from them, understandably driving her to wish she was in another family. However, her desire to stay close to Kate prevents her from fully emotionally divesting from her family.



In talking about Kate's transplant, Sara inadvertently dehumanizes Anna by talking about her kidney as though it's a standalone object rather than an organ that will have to be extracted from Anna's body. More unsettling for Anna is Sara's assumption that the transplant will absolutely happen, even though nobody has asked Anna if she wants it. This nonchalant assumption is juxtaposed with the small but real risk of death associated with kidney donation, highlighting how Sara has not even entertained potential arguments against forcing Anna to donate her kidney.



Vern Stackhouse, the sheriff, enters the room. He's quite close with the Fitzgeralds, having gotten Jesse out of trouble a few times. Sara receives him warmly, but the atmosphere in the room changes when Vern reveals that he's come to serve her papers. Apologetically, he quickly hands over the papers and leaves. The document is Anna's petition for medical emancipation. Sara moves to confront Anna, but Kate is suddenly overwhelmed with pain and cries for a nurse. Anna takes the opportunity to run out of the room.

Anna hides in the maternity ward. There, she watches a new father talk happily on the phone about his new daughter's measurements. Anna wonders if her parents did this when she came along, or if they only cared about her cord blood. Anna congratulates the new father, but what she really wants to tell him is to hold his baby tight so that she'll never do what Anna has done to her parents. She calls Jesse to pick her up and, at the entrance, is met by Vern, who tells her that her mother's worried about her. Anna tells him to tell her that she's alright and then leaves with Jesse, who tells her that Sara paged Brian away from work. According to Jesse, the last time Sara did this was when Kate was diagnosed.

Later, Sara, Brian, and Kate arrive home. Kate is sent upstairs, and Sara demands that Anna call her lawyer and retract her lawsuit. Brian comes between them, insisting they give Anna a chance to explain. Anna says that she doesn't want to do it anymore, to which Sara says that none of them want to, but they don't have a choice. Anna, however, knows that she does have a choice. Brian asks her if the three of them can talk without a lawyer having to be involved. Anna, who can smell smoke on him and knows he's come from a **fire** for this, is ashamed. She tells him that she can't and says she's invisible. Sara slaps her.

Anna recounts a flashback from when Kate was eight and she was five in which the two had a fight. Because the two girls share a room, they divide it in half, with Kate letting Anna pick a side. Anna picks the side with the Barbies and art supplies, which she thinks is a smart move until lunchtime, when Kate—with her side including the door—is able to leave and Anna is not. Anna stubbornly stays in the room until Sara comes up some time later. Anna protests at being picked up and carried out of the room, so Sara leaves and comes back with various towels and pillows, which she uses to make "lily pads." Using this, Anna is able to jump onto the items and leave the room, following her mother out.

The Fitzgeralds' situation escalates quickly as soon as Vern enters the room. Just moments after Sara verbalizes her assumption that Anna will donate her kidney, this assumption is shattered by Anna's petition. This disruption to Sara's hope is underscored by Kate's agony, which hints that her prospects of survival are growing even narrower.



The new father's excitement over his daughter is a direct contrast to Anna's situation. Unlike Anna's unconventional conception and birth, this father has had the "normal" experience of having a baby, where he's full of pure joy over his daughter's new life, rather than relief over useful cord blood. Anna envies this normalcy but knows that it is well beyond her grasp after what she's done. Later, Jesse's revelation that Sara has paged Brian underscores the gravity of Anna's petition being served.



Sara and Brian's confrontation with Anna serves as an illustration of the two's differing attitudes towards Anna. Brian, who is closer to Anna, has more compassion for her, while Sara keeps a harder line. In this way, Anna's lawsuit causes a rift not only between herself and her parents but between Brian and Sara as they already start to disagree about their response to the lawsuit.



That this flashback comes immediately after Sara's slapping Anna is significant, since it shows that their relationship was not always this strained. Although Sara often prioritizes Kate, in this fight between Kate and Anna, Sara stands up for the latter. Her compassion for Anna complicates her as a character, showing that she is capable of tenderness towards her younger daughter—even if she isn't currently acting on it in the present day.



In the present, while Anna is taking a shower, Kate comes in to talk to her. She says that Anna still has the opportunity to change her mind, and Anna says that she knows this. After some silence, Kate tearfully says that Anna is the only friend that she has. Although Anna denies it, she knows that it's true; Kate hasn't been able to keep a consistent friend group due to her time out of school and her struggle to relate to her healthy peers. Anna retorts that she's not Kate's friend, but her sister—to which Kate responds that she can bear to lose Anna as a sister, but not as a friend. Kate leaves, and Anna admits to herself that she can't bear to lose Kate either.

When Kate falls asleep that night, Anna gets up and places her palm under Kate's nose, thinking about how easily she could suffocate her and how it wouldn't be much different from what she's doing now. When she hears footsteps, she dives into bed and pretends to be asleep, eavesdropping on her parents. Sara says that Anna is just doing this for attention, but Brian suggests that maybe Anna has a point. When Anna hears the door close, she assumes her parents have gone, but Sara is by her bedside when she rolls over. When Anna says Sara must hate her, Sara denies it and hugs her, telling her they can talk to the judge and fix everything.

This interaction is the first time Anna and Kate talk after the petition is served and illustrates the complicated emotions between the two. Unlike Sara, who is furious, Kate seems more worried about losing her bond with Anna. This is especially significant since, after all, Kate's life is on the line, but she doesn't seem especially concerned about dying. In other words, Kate seems to prioritize her sisterhood and friendship with Anna over her survival.



Anna's thought of killing Kate illustrates the depth of her guilt. She loves Kate and doesn't want to kill her, but what she's doing doesn't feel much different to her than suffocating her in her sleep. It is in this moment of intense guilt that Anna finds herself confronted by Sara, who tries to convince Anna to drop the lawsuit. With this in mind, it isn't surprising that Anna is vulnerable to Sara's manipulation.



6. 1990: SARA

Sara and Brian take Kate to see Dr. Harrison Chance, Kate's new oncologist. Sara feels a sense of comfort and inclusion in the oncology ward, "a sense that I am a member of the club," but she is impatient with Dr. Chance's lateness and dislikes the dying plant in his office. She blows up a rubber glove to entertain Kate; the two are playing when Dr. Chance arrives. He sternly looks at the balloon and says that "there's already a problem"—but then he takes the balloon and draws a face on the glove, handing it back to Kate with a smile.

Sara reflects on her relative lack of contact with her sister Suzanne, whom she only sees once or twice a year despite living close to her. Suzanne, who is 10 years older than Sara, became a parental figure to Sara after their father died and their mother never recovered from her grief. Sara envies her confidence and competence but laments that Suzanne views her as a failure due to marrying someone without a college degree and having children. Even so, Sara decides to call Suzanne, managing to get her on the line despite her being in a meeting. As soon as the two talk, Sara remembers all of her fond sisterly memories of Suzanne and realizes that Suzanne is her "built-in best friend." On the phone, she asks Suzanne how she is.

Although Kate's cancer has begun to isolate the Fitzgeralds from their peers at large, they are at least able to find community within the actual hospital, where others understand what they're going through. At first, it seems that Dr. Chance will be a cold presence in Kate's treatment, but his playful kindness towards Kate subverts this and confirms that he'll be an important support figure for the Fitzgeralds.



In her moment of intense adversity, Sara is able to remember the importance of her bond with Suzanne. Although adulthood has strained their relationship, thinking back to their childhood, when Suzanne was her primary caretaker, once again endears her to their relationship. Notably, Sara's description of Suzanne as her "built-in best friend" parallels Kate's discussion with Anna in the previous chapter, where Kate tells Anna that she values Anna's friendship more than her sisterhood.



During the process of Kate's diagnosis, Sara and Brian meet with a team of specialists to have their questions answered. Sara quickly learns that the nurses, rather than the doctors, provide them the vital information. One nurse explains the aggressive nature of acute promyelocytic leukemia and warns that there are "no guarantees," while another outlines the side effects of chemotherapy, such as nausea, immune suppression that will likely give her an infection, and hair loss. This last side effect, though minor in comparison to the others, upsets Sara since it will mark Kate as visibly ill. She thinks of Kate's first haircut just six months earlier.

Dr. Chance explains that, after chemo, they will have to watch Kate closely for relapse. Unless she goes into remission, they will have to rely on a bone marrow donor. The best-case scenario is that Jesse is a match for a transplant, but if not, Kate will be placed on a registry for an unrelated donor. However, Dr. Chance warns, this is a riskier procedure. Sara asks what it will look like if Kate dies. Dr. Chance tells her it will depend on what she succumbs to. Sara asks if Kate will know what's happening, to which Dr. Chance says that out of the 20 children in the ward, 10 will be dead in a few years, and he has no way of knowing which group Kate will be in.

Kate begins chemotherapy, which requires a central line to be placed beneath her collarbone; it makes Sara think of a sci-fi movie. She has undergone multiple tests to ensure that she can withstand the chemo, and the nurse reassures Sara that Kate won't feel anything. As the chemicals course through Kate's body, Sara imagines an army battling inside her. Kate begins to vomit within two hours, and while the nurses are able to briefly stop by to administer anti-emetics, it's largely up to Sara and Brian to take care of her. Brian wipes Kate's face while Sara empties the emesis basin over and over. She tells the reader that "if you focus on sandbagging the beachhead, you can ignore the tsunami that's approaching."

Brian brings Jesse to the hospital so that he can receive a blood test. It's only a finger stick, but Jesse is so terrified that it requires Brian and two residents to hold him down. Sara watches with her arms crossed, thinking of how Kate stopped crying over her procedures two days ago. All six of the proteins in Jesse's blood must match Kate's for him to be a potential donor; Sara muses that the odds for this are just as slim as getting leukemia in the first place. When Jesse is done, he goes to Sara for comfort. She gives it to him, but she finds it difficult to feel sorry for him.

The Fitzgeralds' definition of normal continues to change as they proceed further into Kate's treatment. While all the effects of chemotherapy are terrifying, the one that disturbs Sara the most is the prospect of Kate losing her hair. On an objective level, this isn't nearly as bad as something like immune suppression, but such a visible symptom makes it feel real for Sara, who until now has been able to revel in normal parenthood milestones such as a first haircut.



Dr. Chance introduces a variety of unknowns into Kate's future: namely, whether she goes into remission, and what to do for her treatment in the (more likely) event that she doesn't. Rather than entertaining all of these complex possibilities, Sara attempts to prepare herself by asking about Kate's death. However, Dr. Chance's response about the percentage of children in the ward who will survive serves as a reminder that the future is uncertain; Kate could die, but she could survive, too.



While much of Kate's treatment has been a terrifying theoretical up until this point, the beginning of her chemotherapy makes it real. Poignantly, although the side effects are as terrible as they were warned, Sara and Brian's impulse to care for Kate in the immediate moment allows them to forget the long-term implications of her illness. In this way, Sara and Brian are able to enact some control over their situation by doing what they can in the short-term, even as the future is still uncertain.



Sara's difficulty in relating to her healthy children, which has worsened significantly in the present day, is hinted at in this flashback. Although Jesse's reaction is entirely understandable given his young age, seeing the horror of Kate's treatment has completely desensitized Sara to his suffering. Thus, this moment marks the beginning of Sara prioritizing Kate's suffering over that of Jesse and Anna.



Dr. Chance tells Sara and Brian that Jesse is unfortunately not a match. Sara stares at his dying plant, wishing someone would replace it with flowers. Dr. Chance continues that they'll have to look for a donor on the registry, but if not, they'll simply have to hope that cancer research progresses quickly enough to save her. Sara, upset by this, picks up the plant and leaves the office to throw it away. Dr. Chance follows her out to check on her, and she says she's fine; after all, *she's* going to live a long, healthy life. She hands him the planter and apologizes. Dr. Chance reassures her that survival rates have increased, and even though Jesse wasn't a match, another sibling might be. Sara realizes he's talking about a sibling that isn't born yet.

One evening, Kate leaves the dinner table despite barely having eaten. Jesse tries to leave as well, but Brian won't let him. Jesse complains that it's not fair that Kate gets to be finished but he doesn't, causing Brian to lose his temper. He tells Jesse that if he wants things to be fair, he can get every painful procedure that Kate gets. Sara, shocked, cuts him off. Brian, suddenly aware of his own behavior, apologizes to the cowed Jesse and leaves the room. Jesse asks if Brian is sick too, and Sara reassures him that they're all going to be fine.

A week after Kate returns, a crash comes from her room. Sara and Brian find her convulsing from a fever. Neither of them is willing to leave her to watch Jesse, so they wake him up and take him along to the ER. Kate undergoes a variety of tests, including a spinal tap and a chest X-ray, to determine the root of her infection. When they view the chest X-ray, Sara is horrified to see a large blot, which she immediately assumes is a tumor from the cancer metastasizing. The doctor places a hand on her shoulder and tells her that the blot is Kate's heart.

Kate has pancytopenia, meaning that she has nothing protecting her from infection—a sign that the chemo has worked. As a result, she has contracted nadir sepsis, a post-chemo infection. She is given Tylenol and antibiotics, and it takes six hours before she stops shaking. Eventually, Kate's temperature drops to a safe level and she falls asleep. Sara thinks she looks like a corpse, which, horribly, is preferable to watching her suffer. Brian takes Jesse downstairs to get lunch, but Sara opts to stay with Kate, who wakes up. Sara tells her that when she grows up, she wants to be just like Kate. Kate shakes her head and tells Sara that, if she grew up to be like Kate, she'd be sick.

Upon receiving bad news from Dr. Chance, Sara once again tries to obtain control over the present moment—but, since she can't take care of Kate, her desire for control redirects to something as small and insignificant as Dr. Chance's dead plant. However, Dr. Chance gives Sara another thing to enact control over: the possibility of conceiving another child besides Jesse. This moment, then, first plants the seed of conceiving Anna in Sara's mind.



In a parallel to Sara's lack of empathy for Jesse during his blood drawing, Brian's lashing out at Jesse is a manifestation of his despair at Kate's suffering. While understandable, both Sara and Brian's increasing struggle to relate to Jesse serves to alienate him, since he is not yet old enough to understand why he and Kate are now being treated differently.



Kate once again has to undergo a variety of invasive exams, including a spinal tap, to diagnose her fever—but these exams are now getting less description in the narrative, reflecting how the Fitzgeralds are becoming accustomed to this. In fact, Sara mistaking Kate's heart for a tumor shows how she's become hypersensitized to expecting catastrophe for Kate.



Kate's current infection is an instance of cruel irony: her infection, though terrible on its own, is a sign that her chemotherapy is working. In other words, all paths lead to suffering for her. Heartbreakingly, Kate seems to understand this even at her young age, as shown by her response to Sara's praising of her. Even at two years old, Kate has begun to internalize being sick as a core part of who she is.



Sara has two dreams following Kate's treatment. In the first, IV fluid is flowing too quickly into Kate's central line, inflating her like a balloon. Sara attempts to pull it out, but she's too late, and Kate's face balloons until it's a smooth white oval. In the second dream, Sara is giving birth. The nurse tells her it's a girl and hands her the baby, at which point Sara realizes that it isn't Kate. She tells the nurse that the baby isn't Kate, and the nurse agrees but tells Sara, "[S]he's still yours."

Sara's two dreams reflect two major parts of her life: the largest problem facing her (Kate's illness) and the potential solution (a new baby). In particular, the second dream foreshadows Sara's eventual attitude towards Anna—namely, that she isn't Kate.



Suzanne arrives at Kate's hospital room. Sara immediately starts crying. Suzanne tells her she was never going to listen to Sara's request for her not to come, and that she'll be able to work remotely. She offers to watch Jesse, and both Sara and Brian realize they hadn't even considered who would do this during Kate's treatments. Immediately, Suzanne sets to work getting things done: playing with Jesse, convincing a restaurant to deliver to the hospital. Sara is able to relax a little, letting herself pretend that Suzanne can fix the problems that she can't.

In an instant, the tension between Sara and Suzanne dissipates as they work together to help Kate. Suzanne's headstrong attitude, which has spurred Sara's resentment towards her, quickly becomes indispensable as she solves issues that Sara does not have the energy to address. Suzanne's competence also allows Sara to momentarily indulge in a fantasy of control.



After Suzanne leaves with Jesse, Sara and Brian stay alone with Kate. Sara tells Brian that she's been thinking about having another baby. Brian is disgusted, but Sara tells him that it's not what he thinks. He tells her that they can't simply replace Kate if she dies. Sara, forcing herself to think of Kate alive at age four, 12, 20, tells him that that's why they have to make sure she survives.

In declaring her intent to have another baby, Sara returns to her promise to keep Kate alive. However, while her initial promise was abstract and aimless, she now has a specific route to saving Kate's life. In this way, she now has a very real sense of control over Kate's fate—although, as the present narrative shows, this sense might be somewhat misguided.



7. WEDNESDAY: CAMPBELL

While on the phone, Campbell thinks about how everyone is beholden to their parents, but the question is how much. His mother vents to him about his father's latest affair, and he wishes he had siblings so that he would not have to deal with her calls as often. He lies to her about having to go to court and takes Judge to Rosie's, a coffee shop full of eccentric patrons. A server comes to his table and tells him that animals aren't allowed; when Campbell says that Judge is a service dog, the server attempts to give him a Braille menu. Campbell declines it, and when the server asks what Judge is for, Campbell says he has SARS and Judge tallies the people he infects. The server, unsure if he's serious, slowly backs away.

As usual, Campbell keeps a wide berth between himself and others—whether it's a stranger at a coffee shop or his own parents. The detail about Campbell being an only child also puts him in contrast to characters like Anna and Sara, who can at least depend on the bonds of siblinghood during their struggles. Campbell's closest ally continues to be Judge, but even Judge's purpose at Campbell's side continues to be a secret due to Campbell's evasiveness.



Campbell can see the street through the window, so he people-watches while waiting for his order. As he watches, a black-haired woman drops coffee on her skirt. Campbell freezes. He thinks he knows who this woman is, but he can't see her face to confirm it. He watches her, but a bus passes by and his cell phone rings—his mother again. When he looks back up, the woman is gone.

For the first time in the novel, Campbell seems to have a connection to another person—but the connection is fleeting and uncertain, with the woman disappearing as soon as she appears. A moment later, Campbell is left with a call from his mother, one of the bonds that does not fulfill him at all.



Campbell arrives at the office, immediately barking orders to Kerri. Anna is already there, polishing his doorknob—when Campbell asks what she's doing, she tells him she's doing what he told her to. One of Campbell's phone line rings: it's Sara, calling to tell him that she's spoken to Anna and they're going to drop the case. Campbell responds that he'll have to hear this directly from his client and asks Sara if she knows where Anna is; she thinks Anna is out running. After hanging up, Campbell asks Anna if she's really committed to the lawsuit or if she's wasting his time. Anna answers that as long as he's willing to represent her, she's committed.

Campbell recalls the first time he sailed in a yacht club race with his father. His father didn't want to sail with him since, for him, "if you weren't perfect, you simply weren't," and Campbell wasn't a talented enough sailor. When the two finally sail together, a storm comes in and makes Campbell seasick, making him essentially useless throughout the race. His father wins the race singlehandedly and goes ahead to drink at the yacht club to celebrate. When Campbell catches up, his father toasts to the victory and slams down the victory cup he won, breaking it. One of the sailors says it's a shame; Campbell's father, looking at Campbell, agrees.

Campbell describes the bumper stickers around town that memorialize the victims of drunk drivers, which he believes people put on their cars out of "secret joy that this tragedy did not happen to you." One of these victims is Dena DeSalvo, someone Campbell knew: she was the 12-year-old daughter of Judge DeSalvo, who has now been assigned to Anna's case. Campbell worries that a judge who has suffered such a loss will not be able to objectively judge a case involving a girl causing her sister's death.

Campbell arrives at the courthouse and—after deflecting a bailiff's curiosity about Judge—finds Sara, Brian, and Anna. Sara is arguing with a clerk, who refuses to let her into the chambers since she is not an attorney. However, it turns out that Sara is an attorney who is representing herself. Campbell irritably asks Anna why she didn't mention this; Anna says that he never asked. Sara is given an Entry of Appearance form and meets with Sheriff Vern. Campbell is dismayed to see that the two are on good terms, feeling that Sara "has all the public servants in the palm of her hand."

The discrepancy between Sara's claim that Anna is dropping the case and Anna's assertion that she is committed to her lawsuit illustrates the conflicting interests among the Fitzgerald family. Anna's lie to Sara suggests that she is rejecting Sara's offer to make the case go away, but the guilt she felt the night after Vern served the papers suggests that she might be more conflicted than she's letting on to Campbell.



In his flashback, Campbell is much less polished and more vulnerable than he appears in the present. Rather than the suave lawyer he's become, he's an awkward teenager vying for his father's approval to no avail. His father's coldness and cruelty, hinted at earlier in the novel, is made explicit here and provides some more context as to why Campbell struggles to be vulnerable around other people.



Campbell's cynicism regarding the drunk driver stickers is harsh, but it expands on the novel's idea that those who have suffered tragedy are often subtly alienated from those who have not had similar experiences. Ironically, however, Campbell himself imposes this on Judge DeSalvo by doubting his ability to be objective due to his daughter's death.



Campbell's first day at the courthouse, along with Judge DeSalvo being assigned to the case, bodes poorly for his odds of victory. Sara has more influence over the court officials than Campbell does, affecting his ability to control the outcome of certain decisions. More significantly, however, is the communication breakdown between Campbell and Anna, continuing the trend of the two of them not being on the same page.



Campbell enters Judge DeSalvo's chambers. The judge briefly asks about Judge, but Campbell quickly moves past it after stating that he's a service dog. Judge DeSalvo is surprised to see Sara practicing law again, and she explains it's because the complainant is her daughter. Campbell briefly explains the nature of the case, but Sara interrupts and reassures the judge that Anna doesn't actually want to go through with her case. She tells the judge that she just had a bad day and says, "you know how thirteen-year-olds can be." The room goes very quiet—Judge DeSalvo's daughter died when she was 12. Sara, mortified, quickly apologizes, but the judge rebuffs her.

Judge DeSalvo asks Campbell when he last spoke with his client. When Campbell answers that she was in his office when Sara called to claim the case was a misunderstanding, Sara is shocked. Campbell attempts to use this as evidence that Sara is negligent, but Judge DeSalvo isn't buying it; instead, he wishes to speak directly to Anna to clear the air. The three of them go out to the hall where Anna is sitting with Brian. Campbell wants to coach Anna before she speaks privately with Judge DeSalvo, since, as his client, she is supposed to follow his counsel. But when he calls her name at the same time as Sara, she turns to look at Sara, not him.

8. WEDNESDAY: ANNA

Anna doesn't think that many people would come to her funeral: her parents, Suzanne, and then maybe her social studies teacher. She imagines the cemetery her grandmother was buried in, with its green lawn and statues. She imagines her parents crying and holding onto each other, and Kate and Jesse regretting all the times they were mean to her. She also imagines some of her friends from her hockey team attending. Her obituary would be on page 24 of the paper, and her crush, Kyle McFee, would mourn that he never got to date her. Kate's funeral, on the other hand, would have everyone: nurses, other cancer patients, and townspeople. She imagines them having to turn away mourners and running a story about Kate's life, which will be on the front page.

Anna meets with Judge DeSalvo in his office. He gives her a Coke and tells her a fun fact about the soda being able to dissolve a baby tooth, which makes Anna imagine her insides dissolving. The judge asks her about her intentions, since Campbell and Sara are both saying different things about what she wants. Anna asks him if there has to be a trial, and the judge tells her that there doesn't have to be if her parents agree to medical emancipation—but Anna knows this won't ever happen. Otherwise, since Anna has filed a petition, her parents will have to respond or the judge will rule in Anna's favor by default.

Although Sara got off to a strong start in the courthouse, she struggles to conduct herself in Judge DeSalvo's chambers. Although she is practicing law, her manner of arguing—and specifically the fact that she's claiming Anna's lawsuit is merely teenage rebellion—is that of a mother. This doesn't go over well for her, particularly due to her maternal rhetoric clashing with Judge DeSalvo's own tragedy as a parent. In other words, Sara's primary identity as a parent does not always benefit her in a legal setting.



The end of this chapter, where Anna looks at Sara when she and Campbell say Anna's name at the same time, encapsulates Anna's emotional conflict. Sara represents Anna's desire to stay close with her family without causing discord; Campbell represents her desire for agency and independence. That Anna looks at Sara suggests that her love for her family is shaking her willpower when it comes to continuing her lawsuit.



That Anna, at age 13, is thinking of her funeral, is indicative of how normalized death has become in her life. Furthermore, her sense that few people would come to her funeral highlights just how neglected she feels by the people around her; she feels that there's so little consideration for her as a person that not many people would care if she died. In contrast, her imagining of Kate's funeral as enormous reflects how Anna is accustomed to Kate being the center of attention over her.



Running through the legal process of the petition makes Anna's situation more real for her. Once again, she is conflicted: she wants to attain emancipation, but her question about whether there has to be a trial suggests that she wants to achieve this goal with minimal conflict. Unfortunately, Anna knows deep down that this is impossible, since her parents will never grant her emancipation without a fight.



Anna tries to hold it together, but the sight of Judge DeSalvo drinking apple juice brings up a memory of Kate in the hospital. A snotty nurse asked Kate for a urine sample, so Kate got Anna to go get a bottle of apple juice, which she poured into the specimen cup and then drank in front of the nurse as a prank. The two of them laughed themselves into cramps for the rest of the day. When the judge puts the apple juice down, Anna bursts into tears and tells him that she just can't donate a kidney to her sister.

Judge DeSalvo tells Anna that no hospital will take her organ without her consent, but Anna argues that her parents will be the ones to sign off on the operation, not her. She states that it's become the status quo for everyone to ignore her complaints and tells the judge that it's just today that they'll want her kidney—tomorrow, they'll want something else from her. Judge DeSalvo asks her if Sara lied when she told him that Anna wanted to drop her lawsuit, and Anna says no—she lied to Sara because she loves her. Judge DeSalvo decides to appoint someone to help advocate for Anna, then calls everyone back into his chambers.

Judge DeSalvo tells Campbell and Sara that he'll be appointing a guardian ad litem to spend two weeks with Anna in order to figure out what she actually wants, at which point there will be a hearing. When Sara protests about the timing given Kate's illness, the judge reschedules the hearing to Monday instead. Anna marvels at how different Sara acts as a lawyer. Campbell interjects, pointing out that Anna could be influenced since she lives with opposing counsel. Judge DeSalvo refuses to take Anna out of her home, but he warns Sara not to talk about the case with her daughter. With that, he leaves. Campbell attempts to speak to Anna, but Sara immediately pulls her away.

Sara, Anna, and Brian have a tense drive home. Sara storms into the house and begins to prepare food while Jesse watches TV. Kate asks what happened, and Sara tells her to ask Anna, who doesn't respond. Sara mocks her for being quiet now that a judge isn't listening. Jesse interjects with surprise that they spoke to a judge, but quickly storms out after Sara tells him to leave. Brian says that everyone needs to calm down, to which Sara says that she can't do that when Anna has just "signed her sister's death sentence." A moment later, she realizes what she's said and attempts to apologize, but the damage has been done: Kate runs off to her room. Sara goes after her, and Anna runs out of the house.

Once again, Anna's love for Kate puts her in a state of profound emotional conflict. Her memory of Kate's wittiness and humor overwhelms her as she thinks about what it means to refuse giving Kate her kidney. Even so, Anna sticks to fighting for her bodily autonomy; even as she cries over Kate's imminent death, she refuses to back down.



Anna's conversation with Judge DeSalvo continues to illustrate her internal conflict. Although Anna is clearly bitter about how her body continues to be harvested without her consent, she was not able to bring herself to tell Sara that she intends on continuing her lawsuit. Once again, Anna's true desires are in conflict with her desire for peace within her family—hence why Judge DeSalvo decides that she needs help determining what she really wants.



Campbell's argument that Anna should be taken out of her home is harsh and continues to show how he doesn't understand the interpersonal and familial dimensions to Anna's predicament. At the same time, however, Judge DeSalvo's warning to Sara suggests that Campbell's concerns are not unfounded, particularly since Sara has already attempted to pressure Anna into dropping her case. Campbell's concerns are further validated by Sara immediately pulling Anna away from her own lawyer.



The family's return home from court serves as an emotional breaking point. Many of the family members are at their worst: Sara is cruel and impulsive, Brian is unable to calm her down, and Anna struggles to stand up for herself. The tension boils over with Sara's remark about Kate's death sentence, which points to her largest flaw: the specter of Kate's death affects every facet of her behavior. In this moment, this flaw ultimately harms even Kate herself.



Anna takes solace in a Laundromat. She reminisces about how, when she was little, Sara would dump hot clothes from the dryer on top of Anna and she would burrow beneath them. At the Laundromat, Anna people-watches, taking solace in the fact that everyone there looks as lonely as her. She tries to match people to the clothes in the dryers, then imagines what it would be like to be the person whose clothes are spinning in front of her. Although she daydreams about being a roofer or going to Harvard, she finds it difficult to imagine herself in these roles; all she knows is being Kate's donor. A Laundromat employee asks her if she needs change, and Anna is "afraid to hear [her] own answer."

Similar to her fantasies about being swept away by a family other than her own, Anna's daydreams about becoming someone else reveals how much pain her current life causes her. However, just like when she could not imagine being in a family without Kate, she cannot imagine her own identity outside being Kate's donor. Once again, then, Anna's desire for independence is in conflict with her understanding of herself, which is inextricable from Kate.



9. WEDNESDAY: JESSE

Jesse describes how he played with matches as a child. He would steal them from above the refrigerator and start fires with his parents' bath solution; the fire would burn blue. One day, Anna came into the bathroom while he was doing it. Jesse wrote her initials in the solution and lit a fire, expecting her to run away to tell on him. Instead, Anna squirted more solution onto the floor and told him to do it again. Jesse cites this as evidence that, although he and Anna seem to be polar opposites at first glance, they're both misunderstood by everyone around them.

The introduction of Jesse's point-of-view highlights a crucial part of the Fitzgerald family: although Anna is seen by her parents as a point of stability and Jesse as a wild card, both of them crave a disruption to their unhappy lives. In other words, although they seem to be very different, both have been deeply wounded by Kate's illness and how it has minimized their own emotional pain in their family.



Jesse speeds recklessly down the freeway, angering drivers around him. He thinks about how many problems would be solved if he crashed; after all, he's an organ donor, and he feels he's worth much more dead than alive. However, he arrives safely at his destination, which is an underpass. There lives a homeless man named Duracell Dan, who earned his nickname by collecting batteries. Jesse brings Dan a McDonald's meal, which is payment for Dan watching his stuff: barrels full of flammable liquids. Jesse takes a pillowcase of sawdust he'd stashed there. Dan tells Jesse that "they" gave him a message: "Think twice," or maybe "drink twice." Jesse jokingly says he might follow the latter advice, then leaves.

If Anna's identity has been formed by her ability to save Kate, Jesse's identity has been formed by his inability to do so. This fact is clearly illustrated by Jesse's lack of regard for his own life, to the point that he feels he would be worth more as an organ donor who could help other sick people like Kate. As a result of his low self-worth, Jesse has turned away from his family to the fringes of society, hence his relationship with Duracell Dan.



Jesse goes to an abandoned storage facility and goes inside, bringing the pillowcase of sawdust with him. He picks the lock of the facility, then writes his initials, JBF, in sawdust and dribbles acid over it. He smokes a Merit cigarette, then, when it's almost done, tosses it into the dust to start a **fire**. He runs quickly out of the building, knowing that any evidence he's left behind will be destroyed alongside the building. From his car, he watches through binoculars as the firetrucks arrive. As he does, he thinks of the first time he saw Sara cry. He'd asked her what she was doing and misheard her answer as "morning" rather than "mourning." The sky now is thick with smoke, and Jesse spots Brian arriving among the firefighters.

The revelation that Jesse is the town arsonist positions him as the foil to Brian, his firefighter father. However, the fact that Jesse thinks of Sara crying after he sets his fire implies that his motive for setting fires is connected to Kate's illness and other related issues in the Fitzgerald family. In this way, Jesse's motive for setting fires isn't that different from Brian's motive for putting them out: both of them are attempting to reclaim a sense of control in their chaotic and painful lives.



Jesse gets home to find Sara in a panic; Kate has begun vomiting blood. Jesse picks her up and carries her to the car, while Sara explains that she had to break in the room's door because Kate wouldn't let her in. As Jesse drives to the hospital, he thinks of earlier that day when he wouldn't let Kate watch her show, wishing now that he had. Although this moment has come many times, the feeling of "Is this it?" never lessens for him. As soon as they arrive at the hospital, Sara grabs the nearest nurse and demands platelets for Kate. They take Kate out of Jesse's arms, leaving him emptyhanded and aimless.

Once Kate is through intake, Dr. Chance confirms that Kate is suffering the symptoms of end-stage kidney failure. Sara asks if they can still do a transplant, not acknowledging Anna's lawsuit. Dr. Chance responds that he's not sure Kate could survive the surgery, but Sara asks if he'd do it if there was a donor. Jesse pipes up to volunteer, but he isn't a match. After Dr. Chance leaves, he explains to a surprised Sara that he just wanted to make sure—but internally, he's embarrassed that he ever thought he could be worth something to his family. Kate wakes up and mouths to Jesse: *Tell Anna*. When Brian bursts in, smelling of smoke, Jesse slips out of the room and lights a cigarette. He doesn't know what he's supposed to tell Anna.

Although Jesse thinks little of himself since he is not a donor match for Kate, his ability to react quickly in a moment of crisis shows that he is clearly an important part of his family despite what he—and everyone else—seems to think. His regret over being unkind to Kate also shows that he cares for her. However, Jesse's helplessness when Kate is taken away from him implies that his contributions to his family are invisible to others.



Jesse attempts to find some way of being useful to his family by offering his kidney, but in a twist of cruel irony, the sibling that actually wants to donate his kidney isn't a match. Once again, Jesse struggles with this reality and feels worthless since he cannot give anything from his body to help Kate. His lack of self-worth is exacerbated by Sara, who seems to judge him for attempting to volunteer his kidney at all. But despite Jesse's supposed uselessness, he's the one Kate reaches out to when she wakes up.



10. 1990-1991: SARA

At the hair salon, Sara discovers that the other two customers are pregnant like her. They discuss different aspects of their pregnancy, such as what names they're thinking of and what number pregnancy each of them is on. When one of the women asks Sara if she knows the sex of her baby, Sara thinks about how she knows everything there is to know about her baby. Since her baby, a girl, is a perfect match for Kate, she feels that she's having a miracle. However, when the woman asks if she's picked out a name, Sara realizes she hasn't thought about it; she's only thought of what the baby can do for Kate. She tells the woman that she and Brian are waiting—which it feels like she's always doing.

A year before her encounter at the hair salon, Sara enjoys a period where Kate is in remission and life returns to a relative normal. However, Sara knows that they're on borrowed time, and as a result she decided to conceive an embryo that's a perfect match to Kate just in case. Sure enough, they discover during a bone marrow aspiration that Kate is in relapse, although she has not shown any symptoms yet. On the drive home from the hospital, Jesse asks Sara a variety of innocent questions. The last one he asks is when they pass a cemetery: he points at it and asks if that's where Kate is going to go. Sara pulls the car over and looks back at him, telling him Kate is staying with them.

During her pregnancy with Anna, Sara feels empowered to enact control over her family's fate. While the other women have other aspects of uncertainty to their pregnancy, Sara knows everything about her baby and feels confident that she is giving birth to a miracle. However, there is one notable thing Sara doesn't know: her baby's name, which she hasn't even thought about. This fact highlights how Sara is emotionally detached from Anna due to viewing her as a tool to save Kate.



Even when the Fitzgeralds enjoy a period of normalcy after Kate's remission, it is not the same normalcy as before Kate's diagnosis; after all, Sara knows it will eventually end. When it does, Sara struggles once again with the lack of control that she has over the situation. This is illustrated by her response to Jesse's question, which parallels Sara's previous declaration to Brian that she's not going to let Kate die. Although Sara cannot guarantee Kate's survival, she refuses to entertain another possibility.



Sara and Brian go on a national news channel for an interview about their decision to conceive a donor for Kate. Sara explains their situation pragmatically, stating that in vitro fertilization was more time-efficient than having babies over and over until one of them was a match for Kate. The interviewer, Nadya, reveals that the Fitzgeralds have received hate mail and asks if they think they've made a "designer baby." Brian denies this, stating that they don't want a "superbaby," just one that can save Kate. Nadya asks Sara what she wants to tell her baby when she grows up; Sara answers that, hopefully, she can tell her to stop bugging her sister.

Sara and Brian's interview highlights the larger ethical issues of conceiving a child for a specific purpose. Although the two of them insist that their conceiving of Anna is different from people who conceive "designer babies" with ideal characteristics, Nadya's challenges raise the question of how different their conception of Anna really is. After all, in both cases, they have conceived a child for a specific purpose—and in the Fitzgeralds' case, Anna likely wouldn't even exist without Kate's illness.



Sara goes into labor on New Year's Eve. The nurse tells her that her daughter is a Capricorn, which is good since Capricorns "get the job done." Although another woman, Emelda, tries to make it to the new year, Sara doesn't; she gives birth to Anna just before the clock strikes midnight. As soon as the baby is born, Sara frantically checks on the umbilical cord, which the doctor carefully removes for preservation so that the cord blood can be donated to Kate.

Sara's response to Anna's birth is striking and unsettling. Rather than having an emotional response to Anna herself, Sara fixates on Anna's cord blood, which is her first concern immediately after giving birth. This encapsulates how, from the very beginning, Sara has viewed Anna as a source of medical treatment for Kate.



The day after Anna is born, Kate begins her preparation for transplant: radiation therapy. Kate is given sedation that makes her stumble about. Sara thinks about how she might look like this when she gets drunk for the first time, then reminds herself that Kate might never reach adolescence. Kate is then brought into the suite for therapy, where the therapist places thick pieces of lead over her chest. Sara watches her through the protective glass wall, thinking of how it's the things you can't see coming that kill you: "gamma rays, leukemia, parenthood."

Kate's radiation treatment leads Sara to think of the nature of parenthood. Her thought comparing parenthood to invisible killers such as gamma rays and leukemia illustrates the brutal vulnerability of being a parent, especially the parent of a severely sick childhood. Thus, though Sara's attitude towards Anna can be coldly pragmatic, this scene returns to the core of why she makes the choices that she does.



Kate suffers severe side effects from her bout of radiation therapy: she has constant diarrhea, and her throat is constantly full of mucus. She becomes severely immunocompromised to the point that she has to be placed in extreme isolation and cannot even read picture books without wearing gloves. Outside of her room, Sara practices giving subcutaneous injections to an orange, since Kate will need shots after her transplant. Brian tries to eat another orange, but Sara stops him, paranoid that someone else has been injecting things into it. Eventually, Dr. Chance shows up and they begin the transplant, which does not even wake Kate up. Everyone watches the cord blood enter Kate's body, hoping it will work.

Picoult once again spends a great deal of time describing the serious suffering that Kate undergoes through the course of her treatment. These descriptions also serve to make Sara a more sympathetic figure as she attempts to rescue Kate from this suffering—but, at the same time, it highlights how continuing to push for Kate's survival causes pain not only for Anna, but Kate herself. Even so, Anna's cord blood provides a glimmer of hope for Dr. Chance and the Fitzgeralds, once again raising the possibility that Sara's efforts are worth it.



11. WEDNESDAY: JULIA

Julia has just let her sister Isobel move in and is exasperated by her presence. Isobel, or Izzy, has taken to organizing Julia's fridge and criticizing Julia's penchant for naming her kitchen appliances. Julia, frustrated, tells Izzy that she can see why her girlfriend Janet broke up with her, causing Izzy to run off in tears. Julia states that, although Izzy is three minutes older, she is Izzy's "nuclear bomb" in that she destroys anything that upsets Izzy. Ironically, growing up, Julia was troublemaker and Izzy was the good daughter; now, though, Julia holds a boring 9-5 job while Izzy dates women and makes jewelry. Julia goes into the bathroom to apologize. Izzy quickly accepts and asks Julia what the toilet's name is. Julia says she was thinking of "Janet."

Julia gets a call from Judge DeSalvo, who asks her if she's available to act as a guardian ad litem. Julia became a GAL a year ago after leaving nonprofit work, and she feels gratitude to Judge DeSalvo for helping her break into the field. Judge DeSalvo gives Julia the background information, emphasizing that it's an urgent matter. Julia is struck and upset by the name of Anna's attorney, but she agrees to go see Anna in an hour. On her way out, Julia tells Izzy that there's "a girl who needs help"—in this, she is referring to herself.

When Julia arrives at the Fitzgerald house, she initially thinks that nobody is home since no one answers the doorbell. She's also impressed by how well-kept the house is despite the family being in crisis. When she turns around, she runs into Anna, who is initially extremely suspicious and asks for proof of Julia's identity when she claims to be a guardian ad litem. Julia notes that, if Anna is putting this much thought into talking to Julia, she's likely put a great deal of thought into suing her family. Anna, handing back Julia's papers, asks where her family is, expressing concern for Kate. She agrees to go with Julia to talk.

Anna and Julia go to the zoo, the place where Julia commonly takes her clients to talk. However, Anna is older than most of her clients, and she soon realizes that the girl is not especially entertained. The two of them make clipped conversation for a while. Julia learns that Anna used to play hockey but gave it up when Kate's treatments interfered with her attendance at games. Anna also says that she doesn't have friends since other kids are uncomfortable around her; instead, if she needs to talk to someone, she goes to Kate.

Julia and Izzy are the third pair of sisters introduced in the novel. Much like Sara and Suzanne, the two of them are quite different from each other and have quite a bit of tension—especially now that they're living together. However, also like Sara and Suzanne, the two sisters are able to get past their squabbling and support each other during dark times, such as Izzy's difficult breakup. In this way, the adult sisters in the novels serve as a parallel to the younger Anna and Kate, who also struggle between their sisterly bond and the difficult circumstances they find themselves in.



The call from Judge DeSalvo reveals Julia's role in the novel: she is to be Anna's guardian ad litem. However, Julia clearly has issues of her own. Namely, her reaction to Campbell's name suggests that the two have a history. Julia feels that she doesn't have much control over her life, as evidenced by her feeling that she needs as much help as Anna does.



Anna's suspicious response to Julia reinforces the fact that she is a clever girl who thinks through her decisions before making them. Understandably, this is encouraging to Julia, who is not yet privy to the inconsistencies and miscommunications in Anna's lawsuit. Tragically, Anna's concern for Kate reveals that she has not yet been informed of Kate's medical emergency—she has once again been left out of the loop by her family.



Anna's conversation with Julia provides more insight into how lonely she is due to her family's circumstances. Any child in Anna's position would likely feel some alienation from other children, but Anna's status as a donor especially keeps her from having a normal life, especially when it comes to her love for hockey. This also provides context as to why Anna is so emotionally dependent on Kate: she doesn't really have anyone else her age to depend on.



Anna asks to borrow Julia's cell phone and uses it to call the hospital in order to see if Kate's been admitted. Although Kate hasn't been registered, Anna explains to Julia that this doesn't necessarily mean that she hasn't been admitted—just that the operator might not have the paperwork yet. Julia points out that Anna seems very concerned about her sister and asks her if she's prepared for the consequences of refusing to donate her kidney. Anna responds that while she knows full well what will happen, that doesn't mean she'll *like* it. Julia thinks about what she would do if Izzy needed one of her organs and knows that she would immediately donate it—but she also knows that, in that case, it would be her choice.

Julia asks Anna if her parents ever asked if she wanted to be a donor for her sister. Anna responds that they did, but with the assumption that the answer was already “yes.” Julia also asks if Anna ever expressed discomfort with their choices. Anna says yes, but that they're Kate's parents, too. Julia considers how Sara and Brian may have become blinded by their care for Kate, but she wonders if Anna actually cares about medical emancipation or if she just wants her parents to hear her. Together, the two of them look at the polar bears. Anna is happy to see that one of the bears has been able to keep her cub, since the last one was sent away. She asks Julia if she thinks the other cub ever wonders what it did to be sent away. Then, she asks to go home.

When the two reach the Fitzgerald house, Anna asks Julia to walk her in; she's afraid of Sara's anger since she left today without telling anyone where she was going. Julia asks if she does this a lot, but Anna says she usually does what she's told. When they enter, Sara is indeed furious, but Julia quickly intervenes in an attempt to sit down and talk with her. Sara stiffly declines, explaining that Kate's just been readmitted to the hospital. She tells Julia that the whole thing is a misunderstanding and that Judge DeSalvo will be saying the same thing soon. Julia, seeing Anna's reluctance to speak up, realizes how easy it is for Anna to be influenced by Sara since they live together. She tells Anna she'll call tomorrow and leaves.

Julia goes to Campbell's law firm and barges past Kerri into his office. He doesn't look up at first, thinking that she's Kerri, then freezes when he realizes it's Julia. Julia explains that she's Anna's guardian ad litem. Campbell says that he'd expected to run into her by now and smiles, which reignites Julia's feelings for him, which she developed when she was 17. She coldly tells him that it's easy to avoid someone when you want to: he should know.

Once again, Anna struggles with the conflict between her love for Kate and her desire for agency. Her comment that she doesn't like what she's doing suggests that her lawsuit is not just a shallow ploy for attention like Sara thinks it is; instead, it is a heavy burden that she feels obligated to bear. Julia's musing about donating an organ to Izzy reinforces this, since she recognizes that it's not so much about not wanting to help one's sister, but about wanting to have a choice in the matter.



Julia is hearing Anna's story for the first time, which allows her to introduce fresh impressions of the Fitzgeralds into the novel. Most notably, Julia's concern that Anna cares more about being heard than being emancipated adds another layer of complexity to Anna's ambiguous motivations. Julia's theory is subtly supported by Anna's reaction to the polar bears, in which she becomes deeply sad at the thought of one of the cubs being sent away. Anna clearly fears being that cub, who is ostracized from her family for her “betrayal.”



Julia's experience with Sara at the Fitzgerald household mirrors Campbell's frustrating encounter with her at the courthouse. In both instances, Sara acts as a wall between Anna and her legal counselors, insisting that the entire case will be dismissed soon and pressuring Anna into staying silent. In this way, a pattern is emerging where Sara attempts to enact control over her household—and especially Anna—by denying that the lawsuit is even real.



At the end of this chapter, the nature of Julia and Campbell's relationship is revealed: the two of them had a relationship when they were younger. Although the full extent of this relationship is yet to be seen, Julia's icy response to him suggests that their history will be a significant source of conflict during Anna's case.



12. WEDNESDAY: CAMPBELL

Campbell gets in an argument over the phone with the principal of a local high school over a politically incorrect basketball team name. Tense from his encounter with Julia, he loses his temper but seems to talk the principal out of litigation. He looks down at Judge, asleep, and thinks back to a moment when he and Julia watched a puppy together. Just as he's thinking this, he's shocked to see Julia enter. The two of them have the conversation that concluded Julia's chapter, but it continues on, with Julia apologizing for her cold remark. Campbell observes that Julia's hair isn't pink anymore, which she says is because it takes away from her authority in the courtroom. Campbell asks her when she started caring what other people think. Julia doesn't take well to this and suggests they focus on Anna.

Julia asks about Judge and attempts to pet him before Campbell tells her that he's a service dog. Before she can ask for details, he turns the topic to Anna. Julia expresses her concern that Anna is being influenced by her mother. Campbell agrees and proposes getting Sara removed from the house, an idea that Julia balks at due to the trauma it would inflict on Anna and her family. Campbell argues that it's necessary due to Sara's influence on his client. Julia counters that his client has a name and asks him if he's even gotten to know her. She accuses him of using Anna to bolster his own reputation. Campbell says she knows nothing about him, and she suggests that's his fault. Campbell abruptly takes an agitated Judge and leaves the room.

In a flashback, Campbell describes his high school: The Wheeler School, a private academy largely full of rich kids, with a few exceptions, such as scholarship kids. Campbell is an upperclassman when Julia enters the school. She's rebellious and literate, wearing punk clothes and an eyebrow piercing, and she has plenty of rumors circulating about her. Eventually, she dyes her hair pink. In the cafeteria one day, a girl asks her if it hurt to fall into the cotton candy machine. Julia responds by saying that she can't afford to get her hair done at "Wash, Cut, and Blow Jobs 'R' Us." Campbell laughs at her along with the other kids, but secretly, he's intrigued by how she doesn't care what anyone thinks of her.

Campbell's suave demeanor is disrupted by Julia's entrance into his office. This is a more dramatic parallel to Campbell losing his composure upon seeing a woman outside the coffee shop he was in—a woman that it seems was likely Julia. In this way, Julia's presence in Campbell's life appears to serve as a way to disrupt the carefully controlled persona he's constructed and reveal the deeper emotions he's hidden in his endeavor to become a successful lawyer.



The conflict between Campbell and Julia regarding Anna's case quickly begins to unfold. Julia, as Anna's guardian ad litem, is most concerned with Anna as the person and child that she is. Campbell, on the other hand, takes a much more pragmatic approach and views Anna as his client before he views her as a 13-year-old girl. As Julia points out, this is sure to cause trouble down the line, especially given Anna's well-established conflict between her case and her family.



Given that Campbell's adolescence has been established as stifling and emotionally abusive, it is understandable that he's drawn to the independent and unique Julia. His draw towards her in his youth provides a new dimension to his character: rather than a dull, conformist rich boy like everyone else in his school, Campbell craves a connection with someone who is unashamedly carving their own path through the world.



One day, Campbell skips sailing practice and follows Julia to a cemetery. She quickly senses his presence and tells him to come out, then asks him what he wants. Not wanting to admit he followed her, he tells her he wants tutoring. He takes out their English assignment, which asks if one has an ethical obligation to stop and help at a terrible four-car accident. He argues that you shouldn't stop, since hurting someone in an attempt to help them could get you sued. When Julia refuses to tutor him, he asks her if she would stop at the car accident. She says yes, since even if it's not legally required, it's the right thing to do. Campbell asks her how, if she really believes that, she can walk away from him.

In the present, Campbell comes out to the reception area. Kerri informs Campbell that Julia has left a harshly-worded message asking for all the medical records he has. Campbell takes the address Julia left for the records to be delivered. In a brief flashback, he recalls being with Julia in the cemetery a week after first encountering her. He undresses her and kisses her for the first time on the collarbone.

Campbell goes to the Fitzgerald house. He tries to tell himself his decision to do so has nothing to do with Julia's criticism of him, but he knows she's right deep down. When he arrives, Anna is the only one home. He tells her that Julia is worried Sara is talking to her about the case, and Anna says there's not much else to talk about besides Kate. The two sit in awkward silence for a minute until Anna asks Campbell if he has kids. He laughs and says no, which Anna says is probably a good thing, since he doesn't really look like a parent. Campbell asks her what a parent looks like. She says it's like a tightrope walker trying to fake confidence. Campbell admits that getting to know a client is new to him, and Anna responds it's new for her to hope.

Campbell goes to visit Julia. She opens the door a crack and appears to have been crying. He attempts to apologize to her, and she asks him who he is. He initially thinks this is a slight against him, until the door opens fully and he's faced with two Julias: the first is actually Izzy. Julia introduces the two of them, and Izzy clearly recognizes Campbell's name—and not in a good way. After Campbell hands over the medical files, Izzy tries to get him to leave, but Julia chastises her, leading to an argument between the two sisters. Izzy storms off, telling Julia she'll regret talking to Campbell again.

Campbell and Julia's first rocky interaction reflects their respective personalities. Julia is distrustful of someone like Campbell who appears to conform to the societal standards that seek to stifle her; Campbell, on the other hand, is analytical, argumentative, and surprisingly concerned with ethics. As a result, the latter gains the upper hand by using a legal argument to suggest that Julia is going against her own morals by refusing to give him a chance.



The cold interactions between Campbell and Julia in the present contrast starkly with Campbell's flashback, where the two are becoming intimate with each other. Although their full history is still shrouded in mystery, it is clear something heartbreaking transpired between the two.



Although relations between Campbell and Julia are strained, a positive consequence of their reunion is that the latter is already becoming a moral compass for the former, leading him to seek out Anna. For the first time, at the Fitzgerald household, Campbell and Anna are able to meet as people, rather than as a lawyer and client. As with previous scenes of this chapter, this serves to complicate the image of Campbell, suggesting that his capacity for empathy is greater than it initially seemed. Even so, his conversation with Anna is a bit awkward, suggesting there is still room for their relationship to grow.



Campbell becomes yet another point of tension between Julia and Izzy. As soon as Campbell and Izzy meet, it becomes clear that the latter knows of the former and dislikes him greatly—once again providing a hint to the nature of the falling-out between Campbell and Julia. Although Izzy and Julia argue in this chapter, it's clear that Izzy's anger is born out of concern for Julia's feelings.



Campbell tries to make amends with Julia, but she's still furious with him for abruptly leaving. When he claims he left due to an "emergency," she asks again what Judge is for; he doesn't answer. Instead, he comes inside and tells her that he visited Anna. He admits that she was right and that he needed to visit her before making any decisions about her living situation. When Julia asks him his thoughts, he tells her that the two of them are on the same page. She doesn't respond to this.

The two of them have some wine. Julia explains to Campbell that he never met Izzy because their parents could only afford to send one of them to private school. The two of them catch up about their current situations; both are single (although Campbell jokes about having six wives). Julia asks him how he knows where she went to law school, and he lies that Judge DeSalvo told him. He says that he never expected her to become a guardian ad litem and admits that he imagined her as a married mom with a husband—which he still hopes would be him. Julia tells him that he made it clear that he never wanted that, which Campbell thinks to himself is untrue. She tells him she remembers everything, and he is full of regret that he hurt her.

13. WEDNESDAY: ANNA

Anna looks through the family photos in the living room, which depict time passing over the years. She picks up a picture of Jesse at about age two in a cowboy costume and thinks about how different it is from him now. There are tons of photos of Kate and a decent amount of Jesse, but not quite as many of Anna. She goes "from infant to about ten years old in one fell swoop." She wonders if her parents got tired of cataloging life, or if they just forgot. Although she doesn't blame them, it saddens her that there were so few moments where her parents stopped what they were doing to capture her.

Brian calls the house to see if Anna wants to be picked up to sleep at the station, since Sara is staying at the hospital. Anna declines and asks how Kate's doing; Brian responds that she's on a lot of drugs and out of it. He begins to say something, but the station bell rings behind him, forcing him to hang up. Anna envisions him putting on his uniform and rushing out to the fire engine. She thinks about how "every time he goes to work, he has to put out **fires**," which motivates her to head to Jesse's room.

Although Campbell attempts to win Julia over, his own insistence on secrecy sabotages him; telling Julia Judge's purpose would have helped her trust and understand him, but he's unable to bring himself. Even so, he is able to admit that he was wrong and Julia was right, revealing his capacity for growth and humility.



Campbell and Julia's catching-up provides more hints as to what happened between them. Campbell's emotional investment in Julia is clear, given that he's been following her career and still daydreams about becoming her husband and the father of his children. Julia's response, however, suggests that Campbell has not adequately acted on the affection he has for her—something Campbell is aware of, considering his regret. In this way, Campbell's penchant to close his emotions off has clearly damaged both his life as well as Julia's.



Anna's alienation within her family is visually represented by their family photos. In fact, the photos illustrate the hierarchy of attention among the three siblings. Kate, who is constantly the center of attention, has plenty of photos; Jesse, who was able to have some childhood before Kate's diagnosis, has a reasonable amount; but Anna, who is the youngest and was born into the chaos of Kate's treatment, gets little focus.



Anna is closest to her father out of everyone in her family, especially now given his lack of judgement over her lawsuit. As a result, Brian's work of putting out fires seems to inspire her in some way. Although her next action isn't yet clear, it's implied that she seems to view it as putting out some fires of her own.



Anna thinks back to a classmate of hers, Jimmy Stredboe, who was a social outcast among all the kids until he was diagnosed with multiple sclerosis; after that, everyone was kind to him. Anna, for her part, has always been “the girl with the sick sister,” and thus has been treated similarly kindly by everyone around her. She wonders if maybe she’s actually a terrible person and everyone is just nice to her because they assume her situation made her this way. She also wonders if what she’s about to do is just part of her true, ugly personality.

Jesse drives Anna in his car. He lights up a cigarette, which prompts Anna to ask for one. She is afraid to light the cigarette herself, but Jesse insists that she smoke properly and do it all herself. She takes one drag and breaks out into a coughing fit. Jesse takes it from her and tosses it out the window, then asks her why she wanted to do it. Anna says she might as well. He tells her that she’s not doing the wrong thing, and she responds that she’s not doing the right thing, either. They pull into the hospital parking lot, and Jesse warns her that Sara will be sleeping next to Kate. He also tells her that seeing Kate won’t make her feel better, although he agrees to help her get into the hospital.

In a flashback from two years ago, Anna and Kate train to break the world record for longest simultaneous headstands. As they talk about their future fame, Kate brings up a kid that got on the *Today* show for playing the piano with his feet, which reminds her of an acquaintance of Sara’s who was killed by a falling piano. She then asks Anna what she thinks is the best way to die, which Anna refuses to answer. Kate considers what it would be like to die in a plane crash as well as dying in her sleep. When Anna protests, Kate insists that everyone thinks about dying—to which Anna retorts that everyone thinks about Kate dying. There’s an uncomfortable silence, then Kate says that at least Anna is being honest.

Anna and Jesse go up to the eighth floor, where Jesse tucks Anna into a linen closet and tells her to wait for a cue from him. He then pours whiskey all over himself and puts on a show of being drunk in the hallway. Anna, impressed by his performance, muses that perhaps all the other times she saw him drunk were an act, too. Mortified, Sara comes out of Kate’s room and takes Jesse down to the cafeteria. As the nurses talk among themselves about how hard it must be for Sara to be Jesse’s mom, Anna sneaks into Kate’s room.

Anna’s recounting of Jimmy Stredboe’s ordeal reflects the double-edged sword of being associated with sickness. Although Jimmy Stredboe was treated more kindly after his diagnosis, it was born out of pity rather than genuine affection. Similarly, Anna gets perfunctory kindness from other people, which makes it difficult for her to know when people actually like her or when they’re just hiding their disdain.



Anna’s decision to smoke one of Jesse’s cigarettes provides a clue as to how her lawsuit is affecting her view of herself. She says that she might as well smoke, suggesting that she views it as just the newest transgression in a greater pattern of wrongdoing and rebellion she’s begun. Jesse, however, rejects the idea that Anna is doing something wrong. On the other hand, Anna’s retort that she’s not doing something right reflects how there are no right answers in her situation.



In Anna’s flashback, the normal childish whimsy of trying to break a world record is a stark contrast to the specter of death that hangs over both girls. Given her illness and prognosis, it is unsurprising that Kate has a different relationship to death than someone like Anna, who is healthy. However, Anna’s argument that everyone only thinks of Kate’s death suggests that her relationship to death isn’t entirely normal, either.



While the novel puts a great deal of focus on Anna and Kate’s relationship, this moment serves as an indicator that Jesse, too, is an important ally of Anna’s. Though he views himself as a burnout, he is able to use his delinquent reputation to create a distraction, allowing Anna to see Kate without having to interact with Sara.



Anna thinks back to one of the few normal Thanksgivings the Fitzgeralds have had. She recalls fighting for the wishbone with Kate. Right before they pull, Sara leans down and tells Anna that she knows what to wish for. Anna thinks of Kate as she pulls and is spitefully satisfied when she loses. Later, Brian and the kids play touch football outside, which makes Sara anxious due to the possibility of Kate getting injured. At one point, Jesse slams Kate to the ground, infuriating Brian. Jesse, apologetic, admits that he forgot to be gentle with her. Sara frantically checks to see where Kate's hurt, but Kate smiles and says she feels great. She beams up at the sun and says: "He forgot."

Anna sneaks into Kate's dark hospital room. She observes that, though she's seen Kate in a bed like this countless times, she always looks smaller than Anna remembers. She sits down gently, but Kate wakes up anyway. Anna wonders whether, if your sister dies, you stop saying you have one or whether you're always a sister no matter what. Anna crawls into Kate's bed and hugs her. Jesse is wrong, she thinks; she didn't come here to make herself feel better, but because she doesn't know who she is without Kate.

14. THURSDAY: BRIAN

At work, Brian responds to a call in the middle of the night. He and his coworkers arrive at a house completely engulfed in **fire**. A woman runs over to him in tears, explaining in Spanish that her three-year-old daughter is trapped on the second floor. Brian gives instructions to his men, then tells them that he's going to try and retrieve the girl. But he can't guarantee it; he has to prioritize his own safety as a rescuer over that of the victim, so if the structure is too dangerous to enter, he'll have to let her go.

Brian admits to being a coward due to his tendency to stay longer than necessary at the station. Although it's a hectic place, he takes comfort in the fact that it's *supposed* to be a place for emergencies, unlike his home. The morning after the house **fire**, he's making breakfast when Julia comes to speak with him. She introduces herself and helps him make breakfast: pancakes and eggs. As they cook together, he thinks of the times when he's had to back out of a burning structure to save himself and considers how nowadays he's fighting fires on every side of his family between Kate's illness, Anna's lawsuit, Jesse's delinquency, and Sara's anxiety. Lost in thought, he accidentally burns the pancakes and doesn't notice until Julia gets his attention.

Even a "normal" Thanksgiving for the Fitzgeralds is shadowed by Kate's illness, as evidenced in this flashback. Not only does Sara refuse to let Anna make her own wish on the wishbone, but the game of touch football becomes tense when Jesse knocks Kate to the ground. However, Kate's joy at being knocked down shows how badly she craves her own "normal"; she is overjoyed that, for a moment, Jesse forgot about her fragility and just treated her like a normal kid.



Anna's visit to Kate is another example of her needing to tie her identity to her sister. In thinking of Kate's death, Anna struggles with the idea of no longer being a sister—something that's always been an important part of who she is, since she was literally born to be Kate's sister. Once again, she does not know how to conceive of herself without Kate.



Brian's moral dilemma of keeping himself safe versus rescuing a fire victim reflects the broader question in the story: to what extent should someone have to risk their own body to save someone else? In Brian's case, he has no obligation to put himself at high risk, providing a potential insight into Anna's dilemma about what she owes Kate.



As a firefighter who regularly rushes into dangerous situations, Brian seems like the last person to describe himself a coward. However, although Brian is brave when it comes to physical danger, he is much more avoidant of the life-or-death situations in his personal life. In other words, his firefighting is an unusual form of escapism: at work, he's faced with emergencies he knows how to handle, but at home, there are multiple emergencies that do not have an easy or clear solution. It is these emergencies that Brian struggles to face.



Back at the burning house, Brian enters the house while the other firefighters hose it. He follows the mother's directions to the girl's room, but he doesn't find her anywhere. He tries to think of where a little girl might go in a **fire** and theorizes that she might have gone to her mother's room for comfort. The master bedroom is already overwhelmed with smoke and fire, but Brian enters anyway. He calls for the little girl, Luisa, and eventually finds the closet and knocks against it. Faintly, he hears a knock back.

In the present, Brian tells Julia that he and Sara are lucky because they have Suzanne to watch the kids and Jesse and Anna are old enough to look after themselves. As soon as he says this, he worries that it makes him look negligent. Julia asks him if he thinks Anna's okay; he responds that she wouldn't have filed her lawsuit if she was, but that Sara just thinks she wants attention. Julia asks him if he agrees with this, but he avoids the question and asks her if she has siblings, to which she answers that she has six brothers and a twin sister, but none of them fell through the cracks. Brian asks her if she feels her parents ever played favorites, suggesting that he has a favorite child of his own. He then asks if she has time for him to introduce her to someone.

Brian recalls a time last winter when the station got a call for a man in a rural area who slipped the night before and froze to the gravel, staying there the entire night. The man had been outside for over eight hours and had no pulse. They brought him into the ambulance and warmed him up, and by the time they had the hospital paperwork ready, the man was sitting up and talking. Brian tells the reader that he mentions this to show that miracles can indeed happen.

Back in the fire, Brian emerges from the house with Luisa in his arms and brings her to the EMT. When he sees the girl's mother collapse to her knees with joy, he takes solace in that he's done his job well. He congratulates his men on a job well done; his own rescue would have been better if Luisa had been in her room, but kids are unpredictable. He muses that parenting is just a matter of trying to track your children's next moves. Luisa's mother comes up to him and takes Brian's hand, raising his knuckles to her lips in thanks. On the way back to the station, they go the long way so that they can pass his house. He thinks to himself that he became a firefighter to save people.

Although Brian views himself as a better firefighter than parent, his parental instincts are what allow him to find Luisa. Firefighter protocol leads him to Luisa's room, but it's his knowledge of children and their relationship to their parents that leads him to where she actually is.



Brian continues to doubt his own skills as a parent, as seen by his concern that Julia will see him as negligent for leaving Jesse and Anna alone at home. Furthermore, Brian's reluctance to answer Julia's question about Anna's emotional state suggests that he has not completely made up his mind on the matter—but given that Brian was the first to notice that Anna's mood was off and that he now hints that Anna is his favorite child, it is unlikely that he is entirely on the same page as Sara.



Although Brian's job is difficult and often involves tragedies, this flashback also shows why he's drawn to it: he has the chance to witness miracles that are not as common with Kate's situation. The implication is that he hopes another miracle will happen for his daughters.



Similar to the call with the frozen man, Brian's rescue of Luisa is a moment of triumph that serves as a sort of respite from Brian's home life. However, in this case, Luisa's decision to go to her mother's room rather than stay put parallels Anna's decision to find her own path out of her situation rather than accepting her situation. That Brian was able to track Luisa hints that he might be able to follow Anna's path, as well.



15. THURSDAY: JULIA

Julia is in Brian's car, which is full of **star** charts. She asks him about his sky atlas, and he explains that he's a hobby astronomer. He tells her that Anna is named after a galaxy, and he also tells her that 90 percent of the universe is full of things humans can't see. She asks how he knows it's there, and he tells her that dark matter has a strong gravitational pull; you can see other things being pulled in its direction.

The previous night, after Campbell's departure, Izzy comes out to the living room and criticizes Julia for being drawn back to him. She warns Julia that mosquitos avoid the zapper light after their first encounter with it and tells her to request a case transfer, which Julia refuses to do. Izzy responds that Julia has a history of falling for men who hurt her, and she doesn't want to sit around watching Julia pretend to not have feelings for Campbell when Julia has been trying to get over him for 15 years. Julia leaves the apartment.

Julia goes to Shakespeare's Cat, a bar, with the intention of hooking up with someone, but she quickly realizes she's at a gay bar. She ends up striking up a conversation with the bartender, Seven, who renamed himself the year before. She stays at the bar for three hours, eventually breaking down in tears after confessing that Campbell used to call her Jewel. She tells Seven that she used to have pink hair, and he says that he used to have a real job. When she asks what happened, he says that he dyed his hair pink. Julia says she lets hers grow out. Seven says that people never want what they already have.

Back with Brian, Julia arrives with him to the Fitzgerald house, where Anna is eating breakfast. Brian tells her that he's planning on bringing Julia to the hospital and asks her if she wants to come along; Anna is hesitant. Sara then calls, letting Brian and Anna know that Kate's woken up. Anna lets Julia know this but doesn't seem especially thrilled by it; Kate asked where she was. Julia asks her if she's talked to Kate about the lawsuit, but Anna is more concerned with the cereal, which is stale. As she tries to put it away, she spills it all over the floor and frantically tries to scoop it up. Julia tells Anna that they can always buy Kate more cereal. Anna asks Julia what if Kate hates her, and Julia asks: "What if she doesn't?"

Brian's description of black matter to Julia can be seen as a metaphor for Anna. As the novel has clearly established, Anna is often invisible in her family—but as Kate's donor, her decisions and emotions can pull the rest of her family into an entirely new direction.



Once again, Izzy serves as the warning call against Julia's attraction to Campbell. The sisters' argument serves two purposes: first, it emphasizes just how deeply Campbell has wounded Julia, and second, it further illustrates Izzy's deep care for Julia. However, since this care currently manifests as scolding Julia, it leads to conflict rather than any sort of resolution.



Julia's conversation with Seven about how both their lives has changed highlights how people's fates are unpredictable. Julia and Seven's respective paths are ironic, since they've essentially switched places: Julia went from being a rebel to having a "real job," while Seven left his job to become a bartender. Seven's comment that nobody wants what they already have is a subtle argument that most people are unhappy with their lives.



Anna's emotional state in this scene is ambiguous and conflicted. Although Kate's awakening is obviously good news, the fact that she's asking for Anna causes Anna deep emotional conflict. Anna, unable to face these emotions head-on, blows up over the small issue of spilling cereal on the floor. Julia's comment that they can always buy Kate more cereal correctly clocks the source of Anna's tantrum: her guilt over what she's doing to Kate has manifested into her guilt over spilling Kate's cereal, a mistake that she can easily fix.



At the bar, Seven tells Julia that people never fall for who they're supposed to, citing Romeo and Juliet as an example of what happens when a couple "bucks the system." He talks about his own past flame, Linden (who Julia tricks him into admitting is a woman, "outing" him as straight at the gay bar). Seven tells Julia that, although his relationship with Linden was nearly perfect, something was missing; when they broke up, he felt nothing. Julia tells him that she had the opposite problem: she felt everything for her relationship but had no room to grow it.

Julia reflects on her relationship with Campbell, which confused everyone around them. Although most people thought it was because she was promiscuous, the two of them weren't having sex. She recalls spending time with him in the cemetery, doing things like reading poetry to each other and pretending to be clairvoyant. One night, she suggests that the two of them have sex. When she asks him if he's a virgin and he smiles, she takes it as a yes and wonders why he doesn't want to sleep with her. He tells her that he doesn't want her to think he's only with her for sex, and he confesses that he loves her. The two of them have sex, during which Campbell realizes that Julia is a virgin—he'd assumed she wasn't. The encounter ends awkwardly.

Julia blames Campbell for the fact that she has had bad luck with men ever since being with him. She tells Seven that she has only had sex with three and a half other men since Campbell: a rebound, a married man, and a very handsome man with an extremely small penis. Seven assumes that this is the "half," but Julia corrects him—she was raped by an unknown man while she was drunk. Seven calls her "a train wreck of sexual history," but internally, Julia refutes this: a train wreck happens by accident, but she thinks she runs into disaster on purpose.

Brian, Anna, and Julia visit Kate in the hospital. Sara holds out her hand to Anna, leading her to climb onto Kate's bed. Sara asks Brian why Julia is here. Julia says she wishes to talk to Kate. She expects protest from Sara, but surprisingly, it's Anna who protests, since Kate is still sick. Julia notes that Anna is trying to keep her from turning against Kate. Sara asks Julia outside, where she tells her that while it's good that she's sticking up for Anna, it's Sara's job to take care of her daughters, and neither of them are doing well. She asks Julia not to tell Kate that Anna hasn't withdrawn her lawsuit. Julia agrees. Before going back into Kate's room, Sara tells Julia that she loves *both* her daughters.

Once again, Seven and Julia have found themselves in similarly unhappy situations, but their life paths are somewhat opposite. They've both dealt with heartbreak—but where Seven's relationship ended due to a deficiency of love, Julia's heart is broken due to her love being too much for her relationship with Campbell. In this way, the major theme of their conversations is the irony of fate in one's life.



Julia's flashbacks to Campbell once again provide more insight to the latter's character, showing that he was not always the cold man that he is now. As young lovers, both Julia and Campbell are simultaneously intensely romantic and awkward as many teenage relationships are. Their first time having sex hints at some of the disconnect between them. Specifically, although Campbell cares for Julia, his assumption that she isn't a virgin reveals broader assumptions he has about her romantic and sexual history due to her being a social outcast.



The novel's theme of bodily autonomy has up to this point dealt with the issue in a medical context, but Julia's experience highlights another aspect of it: the right to control one's body in sexual circumstances. Tragically, Julia does not seem to recognize what happened to her as an act of rape, but rather another one of her mistakes—showing how compromised her self-worth is.



Anna's protest against Julia talking to Kate once again reflects her conflicting emotions and allegiances in her lawsuit. As Julia points out, Anna's sisterly love makes her protective of Kate, even though she's suing to be free of her responsibility to Kate. In this, she is aligned with Sara, who asks Julia to protect Kate by hiding the truth about Anna's lawsuit. In other words, while Anna's allegiances are constantly shifting, she is currently closer to her mother than Campbell and Julia.



At the bar, Julia tells Seven that “true love is felonious.” She cites how, when you love someone, you “take” their breath away, “rob” them of their ability to speak, and “steal.” Seven responds that any judge would throw out that sort of case, but Julia disagrees. Seven suggests that perhaps love is a misdemeanor instead—but Julia counters that, once you’re in love, you’re in for life.

Julia’s metaphor—while drunken—serves as a fusing of two forces that are often in conflict throughout the novel: the emotional and the legal. By putting love in a legal context, Julia suggests that, like the law, love is merciless and long-lasting.



Brian, Sara, and Anna go down to the cafeteria, leaving Julia alone with Kate, who is curious about who Julia is. Julia tells her that she’s helping the Fitzgeralds make decisions about Kate’s healthcare. She asks Kate how she’s doing, to which Kate gives her a long explanation full of medical jargon, which essentially boils down to her kidneys failing as a result of other treatments. As she puts it, “something is always falling apart in me.” Julia then asks Kate what she wants to be when she grows up, which shocks Kate—nobody ever asks her this. Kate states that she wants to be a ballerina because they have absolute control over their bodies.

Julia’s conversation with Kate is the first instance in the novel where Kate herself gets a chance to speak on her own relationship with her body. Her shock at Julia’s question about her dreams reflects the truth of Anna’s previous statement: that everyone is always just thinking of Kate dying. Furthermore, Kate’s desire to be a ballerina due to their control over their bodies shows how she mourns feeling no control over her own body due to her illness.



Julia asks Kate about Jesse. Kate tells her that Jesse has gotten into “bad stuff,” namely drugs and alcohol. She speculates that he does it to get attention, comparing him to a squirrel living in an elephant exhibit at the zoo. When Julia asks about Anna, Kate recounts a year when she was in the hospital for every single holiday, and six-year-old Anna had a tantrum because she couldn’t have sparklers for the Fourth of July. She empathizes with Anna’s desire to be normal. Julia then asks Kate if the two of them get along, and Kate says that they have a typical relationship: sometimes they’re inseparable, and sometimes Kate wishes she’d never been born. Julia jokes that she has times where she can imagine life without Izzy, but Kate says Anna’s the one who has to imagine life without Kate.

This scene also allows for Kate to elaborate on her relationship with her two siblings. Her discussion of both shows her to be an empathetic person who understands the emotional impact her illness has had on them. For instance, she recognizes that Jesse’s delinquent behavior is him trying to get attention, and that Anna craves normalcy in her life. Even so, Kate is still a teenager with normal feelings and flaws, as shown by her fairly typical sisterly relationship with Kate. In other words, Kate’s relationship with Anna is often a grounding force for her.



16. 1996: SARA

Kate is eight years old and trying to decide on an outfit for her birthday party. As she once again changes her dress, Sara notices a bruise on her thigh and asks about it, but Kate brushes it off as from a bump. She has been in remission for five years, a fact that Sara still finds difficult to believe; she frequently still feels anxiety around Kate’s health. Kate puts on a sundress and heads downstairs. At her party, she opens her presents, including a goldfish that Sara and Brian got her. Kate has always wanted a pet, but the Fitzgeralds couldn’t handle a dog or cat, so they got her this instead. Kate, overjoyed, names the fish Hercules.

As with many other eras of Kate’s life, the seeming normalcy that the Fitzgeralds are enjoying is undercut with the knowledge that it will come to an end. In particular, the bruise on Kate’s thigh parallels the bruise on her shoulder blades before her diagnosis, foreshadowing a return of her illness. However, Kate’s new fish Hercules also signifies a new life, providing juxtaposition with the shadow of illness still looming over the family.



During a routine bone marrow aspiration, the Fitzgeralds discover that Kate is in molecular remission, meaning that, although she is not symptomatic, her cancer will return sooner or later. Dr. Chance recommends putting her on ALL-TRANS Retinoic Acid (ATRA), a medication that might put Kate into remission—but might also cause her to develop a resistance to it. When Sara gets home, Jesse reminds her that she promised to take him to get new cleats after the orthodontist. Sara cancels both, and in response to Jesse's anger and disappointment, lectures him about being self-centered. Jesse tells her that her world revolves around Kate and runs to his room. When Sara goes to apologize, she finds that he's pulled off his braces so that Sara never has to take him anywhere again.

Two weeks after Kate starts ATRA, Jesse talks to her and Anna about the lifespan of different animals. He tells them that a giant tortoise can live to be 177 and an Arctic clam can live to 220. Kate asks him how long a goldfish can live, and Jesse answers that they can live up to seven years with good care. He watches her take her medication and tells her that, if she was Hercules, she'd already be dead.

Sara and Brian go to an appointment with Dr. Chance. The photos in his office have been the same since Kate's diagnosis, making Sara feel like nothing has changed since she first came here. He tells them that the ATRA worked for a month, but then Kate's relapse continued. Sara asks about a bone marrow transmission, but Dr. Chance suggests starting with a donation of white blood cells. He warns them that this will not stop Kate's relapse, but it will buy them some time. Sara asks how long it will take to get the lymphocytes to the hospital. Dr. Chance answers that it depends on how soon they can get Anna there.

In the hospital elevator, Sara says that she can bring Anna in tomorrow, but Brian confesses that he doesn't think that they should have Anna donate blood. Sara protests that they had Anna so that she could be a donor for Kate, but Brian points out it was only supposed to be her cord blood, which Anna was too young to remember donating. Sara responds that both she and Brian would give up anything for Kate, and there's no reason to think Anna would feel any differently. Brian reluctantly agrees with her.

The heartbreak of Kate's relapse causes Sara to lash out at Jesse, which has been common behavior from both Sara and Brian since Kate's diagnosis. However, in the earlier examples of this, Jesse was still quite young and therefore didn't retaliate. Here, he is old enough to understand the injustice of Sara's behavior and lashes out accordingly. In this way, this scene shows how Jesse changed from a fairly upbeat young boy to the angry, isolated teenager he is in the present.



Although the Fitzgeralds often focus on how Kate will die young, Jesse reframes Kate's lifespan by comparing it to a goldfish and pointing out that, by that metric, Kate is long-lived. In this scene, then, Jesse's optimistic streak comes through momentarily despite his growing anger.



This consultation with Dr. Chance is significant in that it marks the first time he raises the idea of once again using Anna as a donor; initially, they intended to only use Anna's cord blood, which was not an invasive procedure. Also of concern is the way Dr. Chance talks about Anna; in answering Sara's question about how long it will take to get lymphocytes, he essentially equates Anna to these lymphocytes, thus dehumanizing her.



Sara and Brian's argument makes explicit the discord that's been suggested between them before this point: while Sara is fully on-board with using Anna as a donor, Brian has more reservations. However, in this moment, Brian quickly folds against Sara's protests—leading the Fitzgeralds to the situation they're in in the present, where Anna has been forced into donations over and over again.



The next day, Sara and Brian bring an oblivious Anna into the hospital. Sara has told her that Kate isn't feeling well, so the doctors need to take something from Anna for her to feel better. But Sara has given Anna no more information about the procedure. While waiting for the hematologist, Anna cheerfully talks to Brian about dinosaurs. However, as soon as the hematologist comes in and takes out a syringe, Anna begins to panic. Brian, unable to hold her down, yells at Sara for not telling her what to expect. The hematologist comes back with nurses, who work together to soothe Anna. Sara recalls the day that Kate was diagnosed and thinks of how Anna is just like her sister.

One day, while vacuuming the girls' room, Sara accidentally knocks over Hercules's bowl. Although it doesn't break, Hercules lands under Kate's desk. Sara frantically refills his bowl and puts him back in, but he floats to the top of the water. Sara sits at the edge of the bed, dejected, when Anna comes in and asks why Hercules isn't moving. Just as Sara is about to confess, Hercules begins to swim again. Sara reassures Anna that the fish is fine.

Kate ends up needing more lymphocytes, meaning that Anna must donate more. Her second appointment falls in the middle of a birthday party for Anna's friend from gymnastics, so Sara only lets her go to the first part of the party before coming to pick her up. The girl's mother comes up to Sara and expresses her envy that Anna gets to go "somewhere no one else ever gets to go," prompting confusion from Sara. Eventually, through the course of the conversation, Sara realizes that Anna has told this woman that she is going to space. When Sara angrily asks Anna why she lied, Anna asks why she had to leave the party. Sara tells her to stop acting like a five-year-old, then remembers that Anna is indeed five years old.

On another day, Brian is telling Sara about a particularly terrible **fire** he fought while she reads an advice column, in which a woman complains about her mother-in-law cleaning out her refrigerator. Sara feels disdain about this being the woman's biggest problem and expresses her frustration about it to Brian. At first, the two of them laugh about it, but they suddenly stop finding the humor in it. Sara says it's not fair, and Brian agrees. A month later, they bring Anna back in for a third lymphocyte donation. Smiling up at Sara, she tells her: "In case I forget to tell you after, it wasn't as bad as I thought it was going to be."

Sara's neglect in warning Anna about the procedure she's going to undergo reflects her broader disregard for Anna's bodily autonomy and the trauma it might cause her to undergo many invasive medical procedures. Furthermore, as Sara herself points out, Anna's reaction parallels Kate's panic when she had to get her blood drawn, suggesting that the suffering Anna undergoes as a donor is not entirely different from what Kate undergoes as a cancer patient.



Hercules's near-death experience signifies Sara's attempt to maintain an illusion of control around her children. Although Hercules nearly dies and Sara is on the verge of confessing her mistake, she is able to save face when he swims again. Thus, she puts on a façade of control, even though she had no control over Hercules's survival.



This scene shows how Anna's role as a donor isolates her from her peers in a very real way. Due to her donation, she misses a meaningful social event with her peers—an event that the narrative in the present has established is a common pattern. However, this scene also serves as the first signs that Anna does not want the procedures imposed on her, with her small rebellion manifesting as her outlandish lies to her friend's mother.



The frivolous nature of the woman's complaint in the advice column once again serves to distance the Fitzgeralds from the more mundane, normal lives of others, where a mother-in-law's nagging can feel like a serious problem. The frivolity of the complaint is further emphasized when juxtaposed with the difficulty of bringing Anna, a young child, in for a third lymphocyte donation, only to discover that she has become accustomed to the pain.



One day, Suzanne shows up and whisks Sara away to the Ritz Carlton so that she can relax. They hang out in the room and drink. Sara wants to call home, but Suzanne tells her that she doesn't have to be a martyr all the time. Sara mishears her, saying that she always has to be a mother; when Suzanne corrects her, Sara asks if there's really a difference. Suzanne tells Sara to stop being such a drama queen and accuses her of living just to wait for Kate's death. Sara tries to protest but begins to cry instead. Suzanne comforts her and reminds her that relaxing every once in a while isn't going to make Kate die any faster. She turns on Jerry Springer, and the two of them laugh together. Sara thinks back to how, when they were kids, she always walked behind Suzanne, wanting to follow her.

After three days of heavy rain, the Fitzgerald kids are playing outside. While doing laundry, Sara discovers that Hercules is lethargic and gasping in his bowl. She calls Petco asking for advice, then three vets. None of them have any advice. Finally, she rings the oceanography department at URI and gets in touch with a Dr. Orestes, who suggests that the rain might have brought runoff into the house tap water and that using bottled water could help. Sara follows his advice, and Hercules quickly perks up. Kate comes in and admires Hercules, none the wiser. Sara touches her hair and worries that she's just used up her miracle.

17. THURSDAY: ANNA

Anna recalls an instance in which she forced herself to imagine what life would be like if Kate was dead. She keeps at it for weeks, avoiding talking to Kate as much as possible and pretending she's a ghost when she does. She has days where she can do nothing but cry, and others where she forces herself to go through the motions of life to avoid her grief. Eventually, though, she starts thinking of what it would be like to have the freedom to follow whatever dream she wants. She compares this to trying to wear too-small shoes, where you can make it for a few steps before taking it off. She can't bring herself to deeply entertain a future without Kate.

Anna sits with her parents in the hospital cafeteria. Sara admits that she and Brian might need to listen to Anna a little more, but that they don't need a judge for that. When Anna asks if this means they can stop, Sara agrees, filling Anna with relief. She offers to tell Kate that she won't be a donor anymore, at which point Sara clarifies that she only meant stopping the lawsuit. Anna refuses this, angering Sara. As Anna shouts that they aren't listening to her, Sheriff Vern arrives to serve a temporary restraining order to Sara. Anna insists that she never asked for this, but Sara doesn't believe her and tells her that if she doesn't know what's going on, she shouldn't make decisions for herself. With that, she leaves.

Suzanne once again serves as an important source of support for Sara, but this time, she serves as emotional support by pulling Sara's responsibilities. In chastising Sara, she puts words to many of Sara's major character flaws: mainly, that she has come to form her entire identity over staving off Kate's death. Suzanne is able to pull Sara away from this flaw, if only for a night, by essentially forcing her to relax. This act of generosity emphasizes how important Suzanne is as Sara's older sister and caretaker.



Sara's determination to save Hercules is a clear example of her not wanting Kate to lose her pet, but it also represents her greater quest to keep death out of her household. Many of the people she calls are baffled that she wants to save a goldfish, but her determination allows her to find a solution that, while unlikely, actually manages to be correct. As a result, it is understandable that Sara worries she's wasted her chance for such a low-probability cure to an illness.



Anna's flashback here encapsulates her two conflicting desires: her desire to keep her sister alive and her desire to be free of being a donor. Imagining Kate dead devastates her, but it also leads her to fantasize about a future where she actually has control over her own destiny. Even so, because Anna's identity is so intertwined with Kate, she has a mental block on entertaining these fantasies too deeply.



Sara's conversation with Anna reveals her continued penchant for attempting to manipulate her daughter. She attempts to keep the terms of her agreement with Anna vague by promising that they can stop without initially specifying that she only means stopping the lawsuit, an attempt to get Anna to drop her lawsuit without actually obtaining her agency. As a result, when Vern serves the restraining order Campbell evidently decided to file, it feels somewhat karmic—but it also shows that Anna and Campbell are still not on the same page, given that Anna is shocked.



Anna thinks back to a time three months ago when she stole makeup from Kate in order to impress her crush Kyle during her movie date with him. When she gets home, Kate is initially furious at Anna, but then teases Anna, asking who she was wearing the makeup for. She tickles Anna, leading to the two of them roughhousing on the floor. Kate gives up first, telling Anna to stop by saying “you’re killing me.” They both stop playing immediately, lying next to each other in a heavy silence.

This flashback is another example of how the normal moments of adolescence and sisterhood are often overshadowed by the threat of Kate’s death. A date with a boy and arguments over makeup are typical sister behavior, but this light mood ends immediately upon Kate’s inadvertent reminder to Anna that she is dying.



During the drive to the courthouse, Sara and Brian argue about whether to hire another lawyer for their case, with Sara insisting that she can advocate for Kate better than anyone. At the courthouse, there are reporters in the front of the building. One of them calls Anna a “designer baby,” infuriating Sara. Anna, however, has known about her conception for six years and has never been especially bothered by it. After all, if her parents really wanted an ideal baby, they would have conceived a more obedient and grateful child.

Sara and Brian are once again not on the same page. Brian recognizes that Sara representing herself is causing a conflict of interest, but Sara refuses to let go of any control she has over Kate’s treatment. The reporters calling Anna a designer baby heightens tension, but interestingly, Anna doesn’t have as much issue as her parents do with this term, since she does not feel that she is an ideal child.



Inside the courthouse, Sara and Campbell argue while Anna and Brian sit in silence on a bench. Julia arrives and asks if Anna wants Sara out of the house. Anna, tearing up, says no and tells Julia that she doesn’t want to do any of this anymore. Julia goes to talk to Judge DeSalvo. Brian asks Anna if she meant it, but Anna doesn’t answer. He continues, telling her that if she’s still not sure, she can stay with him at the station to think about it in a safe space. Anna accepts, and the two of them leave the courthouse together.

The stress inflicted by the potential disruption to the Fitzgerald household causes Anna’s conflicting desires to come to a boil, resulting in her apparently abandoning her lawsuit. However, Brian recognizes that this is not actually due to Anna not wanting independence—rather, it’s the result of her feeling overwhelmed. His offer for her to stay at the station reflects his concern for her and his desire for her to figure out what she truly wants.



18. THURSDAY: CAMPBELL

Campbell talks to the reporters outside the courthouse, then heads to Judge DeSalvo’s chambers, where the judge asks him to explain the restraining order. Campbell explains that Julia witnessed Sara influencing Anna about the case, which he believes warrants a separation during the case’s duration. Julia arrives and, although she acknowledges that Anna is confused, she does not think it’s a good idea to separate her from her mother. Judge DeSalvo decides not to grant the restraining order but warns Sara that he will if she talks to Anna again, and he advises Sara to hire independent counsel. The meeting adjourns. Campbell, Sara, and Julia learn from Vern that Anna and Brian left.

The meeting with Judge DeSalvo ends with neither Campbell nor Sara looking particularly good. Campbell has filed his restraining order without consulting Anna, essentially robbing her of agency even more. Even so, Sara’s behavior of manipulating and pressuring Anna means that his decision is not entirely reasonable. During the meeting, Julia serves as a middle ground and moral compass, which allows Judge DeSalvo to push back against Sara’s behavior without splitting her household.



Julia tells Campbell she wants to talk to him, but she helps Sara leave the building out the back first. Judge nudges Campbell, who attempts to leave, but Julia confronts him about filing the restraining order. Campbell claims that he explained the alternatives to Anna, and Julia retorts that he can't treat a 13-year-old girl like an adult client. She tells him that Anna told her she wants to give up on the petition, which Campbell wasn't aware of, and explains that Anna doesn't understand the gravity of a restraining order; she just wants the stress of the lawsuit to go away. Judge begins to whine. Campbell abruptly leaves and locks himself in a conference room, ignoring Julia as she bangs on the door.

Once again, Julia and Campbell butt heads over Anna, thus representing her different interests. Campbell feels that Sara's influence is compromising his case, while Julia reminds him that Anna is more than a case to be won. Julia also indicts Campbell's lack of communication with Anna by informing him that Anna has stated her intent to give up on her lawsuit. In this way, Julia highlights how, in attempting to coldly exert control over Campbell's case, Campbell is actually losing control over it.



19. THURSDAY: JESSE

Jesse arrives home to find Julia, whom he immediately develops a crush on. She explains that she's Anna's guardian ad litem and asks if he knows where Anna is, but he doesn't know. He invites her up to his room and unsuccessfully flirts with her for a while. Eventually, Julia asks him what it was like growing up in his family. He tells her how, one Christmas Eve when Kate was in the hospital, he went out to cut down a spruce from a neighbor's yard and set it up. When his parents got home, they gave him a gift from the hospital gift shop and didn't say anything about the tree. Julia asks if Anna was similarly neglected; Jesse says no, since she's useful. She then asks how their parents decide when to use Anna for medical purposes, and Jesse suggests that it isn't a choice.

Jesse's initial flirtation with Julia is an emotional shield for him. Rather than genuinely engaging with her and talking about his difficult situation, he falls back on juvenile pickup lines, following the pattern of him using delinquency as a defense mechanism. Thus, it is to Julia's credit that she is able to get through to him. Jesse's anecdote about Christmas illustrates the stark discrepancy between how much Jesse tried to impress his parents and how little attention they gave him in return. With this in mind, it is unsurprising that Jesse has given up trying to win their approval.



In a flashback to when he was seven, Jesse decides to try to dig a hole all the way to China. Every night for four weeks, he goes out to work on it until he's dug a tunnel so deep that he gets lost in it, since he's unable to light his own way through it. Stuck in the ground, he cries out for help until Brian comes and pulls him out, chastising him for endangering himself in a hole that could've collapsed on him. Jesse looks down and realizes that the hole isn't deep at all; Brian can stand in it and it only comes up to his chest. Jesse ponders how "darkness [...] is relative."

Jesse's flashback and his subsequent musing about how darkness is relative is a nod to how difficult it can be to ascertain one's own circumstances when they're in the middle of it. In Jesse's case, his situation was both better and worse than he realized; he didn't consider that the hole could have collapsed on him, but it also wasn't as deep as it felt. In this, his experience serves as a metaphor for enduring trauma.



20. THURSDAY: BRIAN

Brian moves Anna into the fire station, explaining the situation to his colleagues. When Caesar asks if she's going to ride with them, Brian thinks about it and says that she might. After dinner, he struggles to spend time with her, asking if she wants to play Go Fish and responding awkwardly when she asks to keep her tampons in the bathroom. Brian admits that he's not sure how to handle things yet, and Anna says she feels the same. She then tells him that "no one plays Go Fish after they're potty-trained." As she hugs him, Brian thinks back to the last time he carried Anna, when they went through a field together and he noticed for the first time how long her legs had gotten. He wishes he could have kept her smaller for longer.

Earlier the same day, Brian goes to the hospital to visit Kate. He and Sara exchange updates about their daughters, and Brian confesses that he took Anna to the station for a few days to have some time to herself. Sara accuses him of "buying into Anna's tantrum," to which Brian retorts that he's worried about Anna. Sara says she differs from him in that she's worried about *both* their daughters. Brian looks at Sara and, for a moment, sees the woman he married. He kisses her on the forehead and tells her that she knows where to find him and Anna.

In the middle of Anna's first night at the station, the bell rings. Anna decides to go along. They reach a nursing home, where an old woman, Eldie Briggs, has fallen down in her room. Anna helps Brian take care of her. As he takes care of Eldie on the way to the hospital, Brian notices that Anna is holding her hand. When they get her to the hospital and wheel her in, Anna asks Brian if Eldie is going to die. Brian tells her that he thinks she had a stroke, but that she'll be okay. Anna says it would be great if all calls were like this, even though Brian considers it a terrible call. Brian realizes it's because the thing that's wrong with Eldie can be fixed.

Brian finishes up the paperwork for his call, which takes about 10 minutes. When he's done, he searches for Anna but can't find her. He immediately realizes where she's gone and goes up to the hospital's eighth floor, where he finds Anna in Kate's room. Anna is sitting in Sara's lap. Both she and Kate are asleep. Brian gently wakes Anna and tells her it's time to go home. Anna responds that the fire station isn't home, but she follows him nonetheless.

Brian and Anna's first night at the station together is awkward, suggesting that Brian is somewhat out-of-touch with Anna now that she's a teenager—hence his wish that he could've kept her young for longer, when it was easier to connect with her. However, the fact that Anna teases him about Go Fish and hugs him shows that, although they've gotten off to a bit of a rocky start, her time at the station is allowing her to relax much more than she would have been able to at home.



Sara and Brian continue to disagree sharply on how to handle Anna's lawsuit. Sara still refuses to take Anna's decisions seriously, while Brian sees them as an indicator that Anna is not okay. Ironically, although Sara accuses Brian of only caring for one of their daughters, her disregard for Anna's lawsuit suggests that she is still prioritizing Kate's wellbeing.



Anna's encounter with Eldie is upsetting, but it's also a moment that brings out the best in her. She provides Eldie with a great deal of comfort throughout her ordeal and clearly has great concern for the old woman when she asks Brian if she's going to die. Anna's happiness that Eldie's problem can be fixed suggests that she sees Kate in Eldie; although a stroke is a terrible thing to suffer, Anna wishes that Kate's cancer had a short-term solution like Eldie's condition.



Even though Anna is benefiting psychologically from being at the station, this moment shows that she's clearly homesick. Her draw to return to Kate and Sara despite her conflict with the latter reflects her struggle to pursue her own independence from the household, even when she has the chance to get away.



After midnight, Brian wakes up Anna to bring her to the roof. Together, they watch a meteor shower. Anna asks if it's always like this when they're asleep, and Brian marvels at the core of her question: "Do all the wonderful things happen when we are not aware of them?" However, this shower is potentially once in a lifetime. Anna imagines picking up a **star** and keeping it in a fishbowl and asks if Kate can see this from her window. Brian says he doesn't know and looks carefully at her. Anna says that she knows he wants to know why she's doing this, and Brian tells her that she doesn't have to say anything she doesn't want to. Anna doesn't respond—just rests her head on Brian's shoulder.

The meteor shower is a moment of pure beauty, serving as an escape from all of the stress where Brian and Anna can simply be father and daughter. Anna's question also underscores how young she still is and how she still has a childish wonder at the world. This beautiful instance is slightly undercut by Anna bringing up her lawsuit, but Brian's promise that she doesn't have to tell him anything affirms that he is someone Anna can trust to be there for her without judgement.



21. FRIDAY: CAMPBELL

Campbell goes to the hospital to talk to the psychiatrist Dr. Peter Bergen, who serves as the chairman of the hospital's medical board of ethics. Though he has not been able to get in contact with Anna or Julia, he is working under the assumption that he still has a case. He comes into Bergen's office to find him doing tai chi. Campbell asks for Anna's medical records, but Bergen tells him that he only has medical records for Kate since the ethics committee never convened about Anna. He explains that, when everyone agrees on what's good for the patient, there's no need to meet, and he tells Campbell that the hospital staff "don't go looking for problems."

Campbell's discussion with Dr. Bergen illustrates just how severely Anna has been neglected not only by her family, but by the medical establishment at large. It's striking that, although Anna has been subject to multiple invasive procedures that have not been medically necessary for her wellbeing, the hospital has not seen an issue with this. This revelation illustrates how, as the person who is not actually sick, Anna is not subject to as many ethics protections.



In a flashback to high school, Julia and Campbell are in the locker room arguing about the Virgin Mary. Campbell suggests that Mary just came up with immaculate conception to avoid getting in trouble for having sex, which Julia balks at. When Campbell opens his locker, he's shocked to find hundreds of condoms spill out. His team members appear, laughing, and tell him that they thought he could use a new supply. Campbell, not knowing what else to do, laughs, which infuriates Julia and prompts her to leave. Campbell follows her. She asks him what he tells his teammates; he says he tells them nothing. Then, she asks what he tells his parents about her; to them, too, Campbell has said nothing. Julia tells him "fuck you" and runs away.

This conflict between Julia and Campbell during their relationship highlights the primary tension between them: Campbell's respectability in their school versus Julia's status as a rebel and her reputation as promiscuous. Campbell, who feels much more pressured to conform than Julia, only knows to laugh at the joke at Julia's expense rather than defend her. Julia is understandably angry and suggests that this attitude moves beyond their peers, with Campbell too afraid to introduce Julia to his parents.



Back in the present, Campbell runs into Julia in the elevator on his way back from Bergen's office. Julia is there to meet with Dr. Chance, but when Campbell asks her about the state of the lawsuit, she admits she hasn't been able to contact the Fitzgeralds (aside from Jesse's unwanted flirtation). Campbell insists that they sit down to discuss the case to figure out what's going on. Julia initially refuses, but Campbell points out that this is about Anna, not them. Julia insults him but ultimately concedes that he's correct and invites him to a diner. As they walk there, Julia tells him that Dr. Chance does not think Kate can survive a kidney transplant, but Sara is fighting for the transplant against Anna's will anyway.

Although the state of the lawsuit is an ambiguous mess, Campbell insists on moving forward under the assumption that it's still going—and, for once, is able to convince Julia to act in Anna's best interest, rather than the other way around. Julia's statement that Sara is attempting to force Anna into a transplant that likely won't even save Kate also shows just how intense Sara's desire for control over Kate's treatment is, to the point that she wants to try a procedure that will likely just cause both of her daughters to suffer.



At the restaurant, Campbell briefly thinks back to when his mother tried to guess the identity of his girlfriend; of course, she never guessed Julia. In the present, Julia says that she feels Anna is justified in filing her petition, but she worries about Anna's commitment given that she keeps backing away from her suit whenever she's challenged on it. Campbell expresses confidence that Anna will be able to make her decision by the time of the hearing. Julia mutters that she remembers Campbell's confidence from when they were close.

In a flashback, Campbell takes Julia to his house to meet his parents. He hasn't told her anything about his house, and as they drive in, he pulls into the driveway of a massive mansion, which alarms Julia. Campbell then tells her he's joking and leaves, going two houses down to his actual house: still a large and ornate house, but not quite as imposing as the mansion. Julia says that his parents are going to hate her, but Campbell tells her that they'll love her. This is the first time he's lied to her, but not the last.

Julia asks Campbell about Judge; Campbell tells her that he translates for Campbell's Spanish-speaking clients. Julia expresses irritation at his evasiveness, a trait she says he has in common with Anna. She asks him why he took her case since it's not one of his "usual cases"—inadvertently revealing that she's been following his career, just as he's been following hers. After an uncomfortable beat of silence, Campbell wipes some sauce off of Julia's face, his hand lingering on her cheek. Julia begs him not to "push [her] off the same cliff twice." Campbell's phone rings; it's Anna, telling him that she's at the Upper Darby Police Station.

Julia and Campbell drive to the station together. Anna is there. She begs Campbell to help Jesse, who has been arrested for stealing a car. When Anna describes the car, a yellow Humvee, Campbell realizes that it belongs to a Judge Newbell. Exasperated, Campbell goes to talk to the desk sergeant, who agrees to talk to the Attorney General on the condition that Jesse pleads out. Campbell returns to Anna and tells her that he's fixed it but that he's never doing this again. He goes to Jesse, explaining that he's his lawyer, and tells him that he'll have to give up his license. With that, Jesse is allowed out. Julia takes Anna to get something to eat, while Campbell takes Jesse to court.

Julia's concerns give voice to the emotional conflict that has often plagued Anna's ability to advocate for herself, where she struggles to stand her ground whenever Sara pressures or grows angry at her. Campbell's confidence in Anna bodes well for his ability to advocate for her, but the fact that he has struggled to maintain a line of communication with her suggests that his confidence might be misplaced.



In this flashback, Campbell attempts to rectify his previous transgression against Julia by introducing him to her parents in an attempt to show that he's not ashamed of her. However, the revelation that Campbell knows his parents will hate her suggests that his good intentions might only cause her more pain when they reject her and cause more discord in their relationship.



The romantic tension between Julia and Campbell is gradually increasing as the novel progresses, but Campbell's refusal to tell her the truth about Judge continues to serve as a symbol for his emotional distance. Furthermore, Julia's request for him to not hurt her again shows that she is not ready to trust him again, even as her feelings for him return.



Jesse stealing a car is a significant escalation in his delinquent behavior, likely a response to Kate's worsening condition and everyone's stress over Anna's lawsuit. However, it's notable that it is Anna, rather than Sara or Brian, who is with Jesse at the police station—meaning that Jesse's attempt to capture the attention of his parents continues to be futile.



In a flashback, Campbell recalls how his graduation day was overrun with a horde of locusts. The ceremony is outside, resulting in constant interruption from bugs. Campbell is there against his will, with his parents having forced him to go. Julia finds him and hugs him, asking where he went. She tries to kiss him, but Campbell pushes her away and tells her: “Just don’t.” Later, in his graduation photos, he smiles despite his despair.

Campbell muses on how lawyers have to perform immoral acts in order to act ethically for their clients, a practice that he undertakes to get Jesse off the hook. He bargains with the prosecutor, Bruce, promising that Jesse will never get near Judge Newbell or his car again if his traffic misdemeanors are erased. Bruce, who is currently working on a double murder case, agrees to these terms. Half an hour later, Jesse is free and on probation. The two of them walk out of the courthouse. Jesse offers Campbell a cigarette, which Campbell accepts despite not having smoked in years. Jesse thanks Campbell for helping Anna.

In a flashback to two weeks after graduation, Campbell finds a note from Julia under his windshield. The two meet in the cemetery. Julia tells Campbell that she wanted him to be different. When Campbell responds that it’s not about her, she doesn’t believe him, telling him that she was never going to be rich and he shouldn’t have dated her if he wasn’t okay with that. Campbell claims that he doesn’t care about money, but Julia accuses him of wanting to “go slumming” with a poorer girl. She tells him that she never needed him, and he shouts back that he needed her. He kisses her, then pushes her away and leaves the cemetery.

Campbell drives Anna home. He lectures her on the events of the day, telling her that she has to learn to fix messes on her own if she wants the right to make her own decisions. He tells her that nobody ever asks her for her opinion because she changes her mind too often; after all, he doesn’t even know if they still have a case, given that people keep telling him that she doesn’t want to go through with it. Anna tells him that she wants to be dropped off at the station, which frustrates Campbell, given that his petition was denied since Anna supposedly wanted to stay with her mother. Anna blows up, saying she’s sick of being a guinea pig and never having her opinion listened to. As she gets out of the car, Campbell worries that she is too immature to testify.

Campbell’s graduation day, between the locusts and pushing away Julia, is objectively a terrible time, but he grins through it anyway. This suggests that, without Julia, he’s once again learning to conform and put on a façade of control in order to make it through his life.



Campbell’s helping Jesse out, as he points out, highlights the ethical conundrum of being a lawyer: every single person deserves fair representation, but this means that lawyers sometimes have to do unethical things for their clients that are guilty, like Jesse. In this case, the consequences are fairly minor, but this dilemma subtly raises questions about the ethics of representing Anna for the right to refuse Kate her kidney.



During Campbell and Julia’s breakup, the tensions that have been building between them boil over. Since Campbell refuses to divulge his reasoning for ending things, Julia naturally thinks back to the slights she’s endured as his poorer girlfriend and assumes that this is the reason. However, Campbell’s unusual response about needing Julia suggests that his reasons for breaking up with her are much deeper than getting tired of “slumming” with a poor girl.



Campbell’s criticism of Anna is incisive in that it points to her most major shortcoming: she is unable to commit to the decisions she claims to want to make. This, of course, makes Campbell’s job harder, not only because of Anna’s lack of communication, but because Anna’s entire case hinges on her being able to make tough decisions—a task she has previously struggled to rise to. Furthermore, Anna saying she’s tired of never being listened to supports Julia’s earlier concern: that she doesn’t actually want emancipation but just wants to be heard.



22. FRIDAY: BRIAN

Brian muses about how **fire** and hope are connected. In Greek mythology, Epimetheus made the animals and Prometheus made the humans, whose only good features were walking upright and using fire. Zeus took fire away from humans in anger, but Prometheus gave it back to them with the sun. Zeus chained Prometheus and had an eagle feed on his liver as punishment, then made the first woman, Pandora, to punish humanity. Pandora was given a box she was forbidden to open, but her curiosity got the best of her. Everything terrible escaped the box but hope, which is humanity's only weapon against everything else.

Campbell arrives at the station with Anna, and Brian welcomes him upstairs for coffee. Campbell asks Brian about Anna's living situation and points out that Sara is Anna's opposing counsel, which Brian takes as a warning that he shouldn't talk to Campbell. Campbell says that it's only an issue if Sara is still representing Brian, but Brian responds that Sara has never represented him—which Campbell suspects Sara does not understand. Brian explains that, although this lawsuit is important, it's difficult to prioritize alongside Kate's ordeal. He then tells Campbell that he'd like the two of them to speak without Sara around. Then, he confesses that he thinks Anna is right. Campbell asks if he's willing to say this at the hearing, and Brian responds that he thinks he has to.

Earlier in the morning, Paulie and Brian respond to a call in which a teenage boy is trying to revive his girlfriend, who has overdosed on something. The boy initially denies that they were using, but Brian tells him that they need to know what drug she overdosed on to correctly treat her. Eventually, they figure out that the girl needs Narcan, which Paulie begins to administer. The boy asks Brian if they're going to call the cops, which enrages Brian; he pins the boy up against the wall and screams at him that he won't get a second chance at life. Paulie gets him to step down, and he walks away to cool his temper. Paulie suggests that Brian take time off, but Brian says that when he's not at work, he has to deal with his family.

Back with Campbell, Brian offers him a second cup of coffee, which Campbell declines. Brian tells Campbell not to worry about Anna, as Brian will make sure she's taken care of. Campbell advises him to check in on matters at home, as well, since he just had to get Jesse released for stealing a judge's car. Campbell then leaves without elaborating, forcing Brian to mull over this revelation.

Brian's recounting of the myth of Prometheus illustrates the importance of hope in a terrible situation. Notably, the quality of hope is not a sense of certainty that things are going to work out, but the ability to hold onto the possibility that things will work out. In this way, the myth is in opposition to the desire to completely control everything: it acknowledges that when things are difficult, all you can do is hope for the best.



Brian's offer to testify on Anna's behalf is a major turning point in the novel, but not an unexpected one. Given Brian's closeness to Anna and his many disagreements with Sara about Anna's donations, his decision to switch to Anna is the natural culmination of his moral conflict as he tries to balance his concern for Kate and his concern for Anna. Even so, as Brian points out about having to prioritize Kate's treatment, choosing to support Anna's fight for bodily autonomy is not an easy decision, since it essentially means that Brian is dooming his other daughter.



Brian's uncharacteristic rage at the boyfriend of the overdosed girl illustrates the intense emotional pressure he's under. Given that Kate's likely in her final days, it's understandable that he would become irate at an individual he views as throwing their life away. However, considering that work is usually where Brian is able to maintain control over his life, his loss of temper suggests that his ability to escape his home life by staying at work is fraying away.



Although Brian attempts to convince Campbell that he has a handle on his family, Campbell being the one to inform Brian about Jesse's arrest shatters this illusion. The fact that Brian doesn't know anything this shows just how severely the lines of communication among the Fitzgeralds have broken down.



23. 1997: SARA

Brian rushes Anna, who has blood running down her face, into the emergency room. She has injured herself going over the handlebars of her bike. When a resident comes to check on her, Sara succinctly describes the situation and Anna's injury—a scalp laceration with no signs of concussion—using medical terminology. The doctor asks her if she's a doctor or a nurse, and Sara responds that she's just used to this. Anna gets 82 stitches and pediatric Tylenol. When they walk back out to the rest of the family, Kate looks at her bandaged head and says that she likes it better when she gets to sit out in the waiting room.

Some time after this incident, Sara hears Kate scream from the bathroom and enters to discover her legs and underwear covered in blood; she has begun bleeding rectally, a clear sign that her APL has returned. Sara calmly helps her clean up and helps her put a sanitary pad in her underwear. She thinks about how this moment should have been for Kate's first period, and she wonders if Kate will live long enough to have one. Sara and Brian take Kate to Dr. Chance, who tells them that Kate is in clinical relapse and recommends a bone marrow transplant. When Brian points out that Dr. Chance previously called such a procedure dangerous, Dr. Chance agrees, but says that Kate will die without it.

A week later, Sara is on the phone with their health insurance company, having been on hold for 20 minutes. She is trying to get a straight answer as to whether Kate's bone marrow transplant has been approved for coverage. The transplant will cost over \$100,000, but just because Dr. Chance has deemed it necessary doesn't mean the insurance company will cover it. Sara explains to the first representative she gets that she first called a week ago but hasn't heard back yet, which gets her put on hold again, then hung up on. She swears loudly (prompting a scolding from Anna), then redials. This time, the representative informs her that the insurance company has decided the procedure is not in Kate's best interests. Sara asks them if dying is.

In order to prepare for the bone marrow extraction, Anna has to receive growth factor shots twice a day. Anna has been told about the reasoning behind this, but as a six-year-old, all she really understands is that she's being subjected to a painful shot. Although Sara uses a topical anesthetic, Anna still screams out in pain. Sara wonders if the shot hurts as much as having your young daughter tell you that she hates you.

Bringing Anna into the emergency room is, strangely, a welcome change for the Fitzgeralds. Although her injury is serious, it has a much simpler treatment than something as protracted as Kate's cancer and Sara is easily able to handle the situation. Most notably, it's a welcome change for Kate—who, for once in her life, gets to be the healthy kid waiting for her sister to leave the hospital, rather than the other way around.



Kate's condition continues to worsen despite the treatments she's undergone. The parallel between her rectal bleeding and the period she has not gotten yet highlights just how young she is; Kate has not yet reached one of the major milestones for growing up. Furthermore, as the conversation with Dr. Chance shows, the worse Kate's condition gets, the riskier procedures the Fitzgeralds try in order to save her—with most of these including Anna acting as a donor.



Sara's phone call with their insurance illustrates another difficult aspect to having a child with cancer: the financial burden of it. The company's decision that Kate does not need her bone marrow transplant, even though her own doctor has decided that she does, is an example of how dehumanizing it is to be a cancer patient in a system where companies that don't know you can essentially decide your fate. The callousness of this interaction casts Sara in a sympathetic light by showing the multiple types of battles she has to fight for Kate.



Although Sara has learned to inform Anna about what's going to happen to her, she has still come to dread and resent the painful procedures she must undergo on behalf of Kate. The growth factor shots are one more example of her having to suffer on Kate's behalf.



Some time later, Sara is once again on the phone with the insurance company, attempting to get them to change their mind about their ruling. The representative tells her that the company understands where Sara's coming from, which Sara says she finds hard to believe. The representative informs her that they will cover 90 percent for a donor lymphocyte infusion, but only 10 percent of a bone marrow transplant. Sara says that the review board clearly doesn't have an APL specialist, since one would know that a donor lymphocyte infusion is useless, meaning that the insurance is choosing to cover a procedure that won't help Kate and refusing the one that would. The representative responds formulaically that the company will cover the Fitzgeralds if they follow insurance protocol. Sara tells them that such protocol will kill Kate and calls the representative inhuman, which gets her hung up on.

Suzanne comes over to watch Jesse the night before the Fitzgeralds leave for the hospital for Kate's transplant. Sara gives her instructions for babysitting and housekeeping, with Suzanne paying close attention. When she's done, Brian asks if there's anything else, and Suzanne says yes: she takes out a check for \$100,000. Sara, stunned, declines, but Suzanne insists. Brian also declines, but for a different reason: his colleagues ran a nationwide fundraiser for Kate and managed to raise the money, something he just found out about today. Sara hugs Suzanne, thanking her for even offering. Suzanne tells them the money is still there if they need it. Sara feels relief that she and Brian can take care of Kate themselves.

The next morning, Sara calls for Kate, who is running late and has not yet come downstairs. Eventually, Sara grows frustrated and goes up to get her. She finds Kate making her bed; her entire room has been cleaned, with all of her things neatly organized. Sara is shocked, since she hasn't even asked Kate to clean up. Kate explains that she's cleaned her room in case she doesn't come back.

Sara reminisces about how, when she first became a parent, she used to lie awake at night and think of every possible terrible situation that could harm her children, from poisonous berries to diving into a shallow pool. As her children got older, these fears changed with them into things like drugs and playing with matches. Now that she's been faced with a lethal situation, she feels that a parent in such a situation will either collapse or "take the blow" of their child's illness. She does this for Kate at the hospital, who has vomited over 30 times and has debilitating mucositis. Sara uses the suction tube to clear out her throat, promising to do this while Kate rests. In this way, she comes to "breathe for [Kate]."

The contrast between Sara's intense concern for Kate and the insurance company's penchant to treat her as just another case number once again illustrates just how much heartlessness Sara has to endure in fighting for Kate. These experiences are important in understanding why Sara is so protective of Kate: she's seen that Kate is not only suffering from her cancer but is victimized by the medical and insurance systems. With this in mind, Anna's legal battle in the present might not feel terribly different from an insurance company using technicalities to deny Kate the care that she needs.



Suzanne's generous offer to the Fitzgeralds once again emphasizes how important she is to Sara and the family at large as a source of support. However, the revelation that Brian was able to raise the money for Kate's treatment allows both he and Sara to take pride in their ability to take care of their own children, highlighting how both of them value their ability to retain agency and control over Kate's fate.



Kate's decision to leave her bedroom neat in case she doesn't return suggests that, unlike Sara, she has come to terms with the fact that she might die soon. Rather than her death being an abstract fear of hers, it is something she feels the need to prepare for in a very material way.



In a parallel to Sara repeatedly disposing of Kate's vomit during her first chemotherapy, she continues to care for her in preparation of her bone marrow transplant. Unlike most mothers, who have the luxury of entertaining abstract fears of their children coming to harm, Sara's fears have come true—and, once again, the only real way for her to face it is to do her best to make the situation better from moment to moment, since there is only so much control she has over the long term.



Sara compares the oncology ward to a battlefield: the patients are the soldiers, the doctors are the strategic heroes, but the nurses are the seasoned sergeants who know the patients well. In turn, Sara has gotten to know many of the nurses well, including one named Donna. One night at the hospital, Sara turns on the TV and watches a show featuring the ornate house of a wealthy person. She thinks about how she could never imagine such a life for herself, then realizes she once never imagined this life for herself. This makes her start to cry. Donna comes in and finds her like this. She takes Sara to the break room and brews her some coffee. Sara vents to her for an hour, then realizes how long it's been and apologizes, since Donna surely has somewhere else she wants to be. Donna hugs her and responds: "Don't we all?"

The day of Anna's bone marrow extraction, Anna expresses second thoughts, asking Sara what happens if she changes her mind. Sara tells her that she doesn't have to do this if she doesn't want to, but that she, Brian, and Kate are all counting on her. Anna relents. The nurses guide Anna onto the exam table, doing their best to make it comfortable for her. Anna holds onto Sara's hand until the anesthesiologist puts her under, at which point her grip slackens. Sara gives her a kiss and thanks her, then leaves the room, where she watches through a window as the doctors begin to prepare a massive needle. Then, she goes upstairs to be with Kate.

Some time after Anna's procedure is complete, Sara is in Kate's room helping to catch her vomit when Brian comes in to tell her that Anna is asking for her. Sara initially refuses, but Brian simply repeats that Anna is asking for her. Sara goes to Anna's room to find her crying in pain. She asks Sara if she'll stay with her, but Sara tells her she'll have to go back to Kate, which upsets Anna. Sara learns from Brian that Anna's been given very little pain medication, so she goes to find a nurse, who tells her that Anna has already had Tylenol. Sara argues with her that this isn't enough, eventually obtaining a pediatric dose of Roxicet. When she returns, she finds Brian giving Anna a locket as a thank-you gift for her donation. Anna happily shows her locket to Sara, who holds out the medication, "a poor second-best."

Donna's support of Sara is another example of how, even though having a child with cancer can alienate one from the rest of the world, those within the world of cancer are often important sources of support for each other, since they understand what it's like and do not shy away from the worst parts of cancer treatment. As Sara points out, the nurses are especially important to this support; unlike distant medical systems like ethics boards or insurance companies, they are the boots on the ground that witness the most emotional moments of battling cancer.



The day of Anna's bone marrow donation is significant in that it is the first instance in which Anna explicitly expresses reluctance to donate to Kate. While previous procedures have clearly caused her pain, she has never before raised the possibility of backing out. Just as importantly, although Sara technically affirms Anna's right to choose, the pressure she puts on Anna essentially coerces her into consenting to the procedure.



Sara's response to Anna's struggle clearly illustrates that Kate is her first priority. Initially, she is reluctant to even visit Anna despite the fact that Anna is asking for her, viewing Kate's support as more treatment. Once she actually sees Anna, she refuses to stay with her in favor of Kate. Even so, Sara is the one who is able to get Anna the pain relief she needs by arguing with a nurse—but the fact that she feels this is a "poor second-best" to Brian's locket gift suggests that, although Sara is good at getting things done, she has lost the ability to emotionally connect with and support Anna.



Three weeks after Kate's bone marrow transplant, an increase in white blood cell count shows it was a success. Brian takes Sara out to dinner to celebrate. Brian orders wine and toasts to their family. They talk briefly about the menu before Sara attempts to talk about Kate's illness; Brian responds by saying he'd hoped they could get away from all of that. Sara agrees, but the two of them struggle to think of topics they have in common besides Kate. Sara looks around and notices that most of the couples talking are young, while the older couples are quieter. She wonders if this is because they're comfortable with each other or if they have nothing to say. When the waiter comes, both Sara and Brian are relieved to have someone break the uncomfortable silence.

After her transplant succeeds, Kate is discharged from the hospital. She moves cautiously and has lost a significant amount of weight since her intake, to the point that Sara has to fashion a makeshift belt for her. Kate's head is completely bare, and now that she's leaving the hospital, she has to wear a mask and gloves to protect her compromised immune system. The nurses come up to say goodbye, with one, Willie, jokingly telling her not to come back and see them. When it's time to leave, Kate is too nervous to step out of the hospital. Sara takes her hand and promises that they'll do it together.

At home, Sara rifles through hospital bills. She happens to open a letter from their mutual fund, which she doesn't usually do, and finds a notification that the total balance from Kate's educational fund, \$8,369.56, has been withdrawn and the account has been closed. Sara brings it to Brian, assuming that the bank has made a major error—but it isn't. Brian admits that, although his colleagues did raise money, it was only \$10,000. That, plus the money from Kate's fund, was enough for the hospital to work out a payment plan. Sara reminds him that Suzanne offered to cover the full balance, but Brian insists that he takes care of Kate. He then tells Sara that Kate won't live long enough for college, anyway, prompting Sara to run away and lock herself in the bathroom.

During Kate's recovery, everyone wears masks so that Kate doesn't have to. She receives growth factor shots twice a day and cannot yet go back to school. She rarely leaves the house, and when she does, she refuses to leave the car. One morning, Sara asks her if she wants to go to the mall, but she refuses. Sara tells her it'll be good to get out of the house, but Kate responds that she doesn't want everyone looking at her in public and calls herself a freak. In response, Sara goes into the bathroom, where Kate and Anna follow her, and shaves her head. Kate smiles. Anna volunteers next, and the three of them go to the mall together, bareheaded.

The Fitzgeralds struggle with isolation not only from the outside world but also isolation from one another—a fact clearly illustrated by Brian and Sara's uncomfortable date. Kate's illness and treatment has consumed so much of their life that they can no longer remember what they had in common at the beginning of their marriage. The implicit comparison between them and the silent elderly couples suggests that their ordeal has metaphorically aged them and affected their relationship in turn.



Although the road to Kate's transplant has been a difficult one, Kate's discharge from the hospital serves as a reminder of what all of the struggle was for. Even so, the fact that Kate is still incredibly fragile underscores the fact that she is still on borrowed time, implicitly raising the question of how much more the Fitzgeralds will risk in order to keep her alive. Still, Sara reassuring Kate reaffirms her commitment to fighting for Kate.



The illusion of control that Sara has over Kate's treatment and the Fitzgeralds' finances collapses when she discovers that Brian has lied to her. On the surface, his deception is completely illogical; after all, as Sara points out, Suzanne offered to cover Kate's treatment in full, meaning Brian has needlessly tightened the family's finances. However, Brian, too, wishes to retain control over Kate's treatment—but, unlike Sara, he feels a responsibility to oversee her inevitable death, rather than her unlikely survival.



Sara's decision to shave her head, as well as Anna's decision to follow her lead, highlights a rare moment where Sara is on the same page as both of her daughters. Both she and Anna are moved by their love to Kate to make her feel less alone, even though it means going bald themselves. In other words, this scene shows what Sara and Anna have in common despite their differences: they both truly want Kate to be happy.



24. THE WEEKEND: JESSE

Jesse, who has been truckjacking for years, steals a dump truck on I-195, since Brian took away his car after he was arrested. He struggles to drive the massive vehicle, but manages to reach Dan, who covers behind his drums until he realizes it's Jesse. Jesse loads up the truck with the fire supplies he needs, then impulsively asks Dan if he'd like to come—so long as Dan is able to keep quiet about what he sees. Dan promises, and the two head off to an old shed. Jesse tells himself he brought someone along to add to the thrill, but deep down he knows he did so to feel less alone.

In a flashback to when Jesse was 11, he receives a skateboard, which he describes as a “guilt gift” from his parents, who often buy Kate and Anna presents as consolation for their medical procedures. Jesse loves his skateboard and convinces Brian to take him and his sisters out to the school on Friday so that he can skate. Jesse, excited for the outing, greases his board's wheels and polishes it. However, the day of, Kate has a terrible nosebleed that both Sara and Brian attend to. Jesse doesn't see the nosebleed as a big deal since Kate has had them before, so he asks Brian when they're going to go to the school. Brian looks through Jesse “like [he] was made of smoke.”

Back in the present, Jesse and Dan stare at the shed that Jesse's just begun to burn. Dan makes a small sound that Jesse thinks is respect, but when he turns to look, he sees that Dan is crying. Jesse tries to reassure him, but Dan cries that the shed is “where the rat lives.” Jesse tells him that any animals would have instinctively fled the fire, but Dan says that “the rat” has newspapers all the way back to the Kennedy assassination. With horror, Jesse realizes that Dan is talking about a person. He asks if someone lives in the shed, and Dan tearfully responds, “Not anymore.”

Back in the flashback, Jesse sneaks out of his house and makes it to downtown Providence, which takes him a few hours. Theorizing that he might be invisible, he walks through the business district and notes all of the people staring straight through him. Ultimately, he ends up standing in front of a busy intersection and has to be removed by police. At the station, Brian asks him what he was thinking. Internally, Jesse admits that he wasn't thinking; he just wanted to be noticed.

Once again, as Kate and Anna's situations escalate, so does Jesse's behavior. Having his car taken away not only doesn't deter him but actually propels him to commit an even more visible act of theft. Furthermore, his decision to invite someone to witness his arson for the first time illustrates just how badly he wishes to be seen by someone else—even if they're seeing him at his worst moment.



Much like the flashback in which Sara refused to follow through on her promise to get Jesse new cleats, this flashback shows how regularly Jesse was discarded whenever an emergency with Kate came up. In this case, Jesse doesn't understand the gravity of Kate's nosebleed (that it's a sign of her cancer returning), making the slight cut even deeper. Thus, this scene further contextualizes how invisible Jesse feels in comparison to his sisters.



The revelation that someone is in the shed Jesse is burning is the natural consequence of his escalating behavior. In an ironic twist, Jesse's arson—which has been his outlet to come with not being able to save Kate—has led him to put another person in danger. In this way, this terrible mistake serves as a major turning point for Jesse's character arc.



Once again, Jesse's flashback here shows how badly he needs to be acknowledged. This particular scene serves as an early example of Jesse partaking in drastic, dangerous, and illegal behavior in order to get attention—even negative attention—from his parents.



In the present, Jesse wets his shirt and wraps it around his face, then rushes into the shed to rescue Rat. The smoke blinds him, so he calls out, but gets no answer. Dropping to his knees, he feels his way around, badly burning his hand on something metal in the process. Despite this, he manages to find Rat and pull him out of the shed. By the time he does so, the fire engines are already pulling up; Jesse wonders if Brian is there. He leaves Rat on the ground and runs in the opposite direction.

In another ironic twist, Jesse briefly becomes the firefighter rather than the arsonist when he rushes in to rescue The Rat. This role swap is a nod to the fact that, although Jesse's relationship with fire is the opposite of Brian's, both of them use it to enact control in their lives—even though, in this case, Jesse has completely lost control of the situation.



25. THE WEEKEND: ANNA

Anna asks the reader if they ever wonder how humans got here. She disregards the biblical myth of Adam and Eve, stating that Brian likes the Pawnee myth about two **star** deities, Evening Star and Morning Star, who created the first female, with the first boy coming from the Sun and the Moon and humans riding in on the back of a tornado. She then talks about how her science teacher described the process by which natural gases and carbon matter turned into one-celled organisms, which eventually evolved into humans. Anna thinks about how amazing it is that humans came from a point of complete nothingness to the point where they can make decisions—and how they still manage to screw everything up.

Anna explores multiple different origin stories for humans both spiritual and scientific, but the largest thing she gets out of all of them is how humans manage to mess up their own existence. In this way, she laments how the free will humans have been granted is not enough for them to have real control over their lives, since human lives are messy and unpredictable and humans themselves are deeply flawed.



Two days before the hearing, Anna and Sara are spending time in the hospital with Kate, who is doing a crossword. She asks for a four-letter word for vessel. Anna and Sara throw out a few suggestions before Dr. Chance comes in. He asks for Kate's pain number, which is a three; he warns that it will rise in the coming hour, and that moments of lucidity like this will slip away. Sara brings up the transplant, which makes the atmosphere in the room uncomfortable. Dr. Chance points out that the availability of an organ is uncertain. Kate asks how long she has to live, and Dr. Chance guesses about a week. Clearly heartbroken, he leaves. Kate takes the news stoically, but Sara curls up in a ball. Anna tells her to stop, and Sara tells *her* to stop. Anna posits "Anna" as a four-letter word for vessel, then leaves.

The conversation with Sara and Dr. Chance, which ends in the revelation that Kate will only live for another week or so, underscores just how grave the stakes of Anna's lawsuit are. Interestingly, Kate takes this news more easily than Sara; unlike her mother, she has prepared herself for the inevitability of her death. Kate also does not express anger towards Anna for withholding her kidney, while Sara does. Anna's description of herself as a "vessel" highlights how dehumanized she feels by Sara's anger and resentment now that she wishes to be more than Kate's donor.



Later that day, Anna is at the station, talking to Julia. She looks at the family photos on Brian's desk. She asks Julia if she has a boyfriend, and Julia quickly says no. Anna confides that she went on a date with her crush Kyle but realized after that he had an erection. She asks Julia if it's weird to think about this. Julia says no, and that Kyle isn't weird, either. They discuss their family's different approaches to sex, with Anna admitting that her family doesn't talk about it. She asks if Julia thinks Campbell is cute, which shocks Julia, and she says that he looks like a character on one of Kate's soaps. She then muses that it's weird she'll be able to get married and Kate won't. Julia asks her what happens if Kate dies, but Anna doesn't answer. She stares at a photo of her and Kate.

Anna's conversation with Julia about love and sex illustrates her attempt to navigate normal parts of adolescence, even as she struggles with her status as a donor to Kate. Because her parents have been so wrapped up in Kate, she has not received a great deal of sex education and clearly feels relief that she can talk about these things with Julia. However, even these mundane things are wrapped up in her conundrum with Kate, as she thinks about how Kate will never grow old enough to get married to anyone.



That night, the station phone rings, and Anna's surprised to find that her name is being called to answer it. When she picks it up, it's Sara. Anna, immediately assuming something has happened with Kate, asks if everything is okay—but according to Sara, Kate is asleep. Sara says that she called for two reasons: the first is to apologize. Anna apologizes as well, remembering how Sara used to tuck her and Kate in at night. The second reason, Sara says, is to say goodnight. Anna asks if that's really all, and Sara responds: "Isn't that enough?" Anna says yes but doesn't really agree that it is enough.

Anna can't sleep, so she goes to the roof to read the *Guinness Book of World Records*. She spends a long time reading the "Survivors and Lifesavers" section, mentally adding herself and Kate to it. She tries to look for **stars**, but it's too cloudy. Brian comes up. Anna asks him how grown-ups find their way without a map, and Brian says they just get used to taking the same turns. Anna then asks if it's true that you can use the stars as a map. Brian says yes, using celestial navigation, but it requires a great deal of convoluted math. Anna, though, thinks that she'd be able to figure it out by heading to the place where every star position crosses.

26. THE WEEKEND: BRIAN

Sunday morning, a woman in an octopus costume walks into the station holding a small dog. Brian recognizes her as Mrs. Zegna, whose house **burned** down a few days ago. She explains that her Ursula Halloween costume is the only clothing she has and that she needs help. Brian tells her that he can help her get into a station and contact her insurance company to expedite her reimbursement. Mrs. Zegna says that she doesn't have insurance because she doesn't live her life expecting the worst. Brian stares at her, trying to remember what it's like to feel immune to disaster.

Brian goes to visit Kate at the hospital. She's asleep, but Sara is there. Brian tells her that her call the night before meant a lot to Anna. He thinks back to a time when he and Sara went on a road trip when, after running out of gas, they walked and found a purported psychic. She told them that they would have three children and a long life, but it wouldn't be good enough. Brian asks Sara if she remembers this, but she doesn't. She asks to review Brian's testimony, and he confesses that he wants to speak on Anna's behalf. Sara says that this will cause the judge to rule in Anna's favor. Brian replies that this is the point. He asks what Sara wants from him, and she asks for him to take him back. However, he thinks, they've both changed too much.

This phone call is the first instance since Anna's lawsuit that Sara has shown some humility. It is notable that this moment comes shortly after she discovers that Kate will soon die. Rather than continuing to lash out at Anna, this tragic revelation leads her to apologize to Anna, suggesting that Sara is beginning to rethink her priorities as Kate's death approaches.



Anna's fantasies about her and Kate being in the "Survivors and Lifesavers" section of the Guinness Book serves as a form of escapism for Anna, where she can retreat into an alternate reality where Kate is not about to die. Her conversation with Brian and her confidence in her own sense of navigation suggests that, although her situation is uncertain and painful, she wishes to keep trusting her own instincts as she moves forward with her lawsuit.



Mrs. Zegna's interlude in the novel is darkly humorous, but it also serves to show how distanced some people are from catastrophe in comparison to the Fitzgeralds. Brian, who has learned to expect disaster around corner, cannot relate to someone who doesn't even have home insurance because they feel they are invincible against senseless tragedies.



Brian and Sara's reunion goes to show how emotionally estranged they are from each other. Brian, the more sentimental of the two, still remembers important memories of the two—but Sara, pragmatic and focused on their current predicament, has forgotten the emotional moments they've shared together. The rift between them increases when Brian confesses that he's testifying for Anna, putting the two of them firmly on opposite sides of the lawsuit. As Brian points out, they are no longer alike at all despite being married.



27. 2001: SARA

Anna comes into the living room and asks Sara and Brian for \$614.96. Sara asks her what she needs it for; Anna is initially evasive but then reluctantly answers that she needs goaltender leg pads for hockey. When Sara says that she doesn't play hockey, Anna explains that she happened to start playing with a team a few months ago, and that while the coach invited her onto the team, she has to supply her own equipment. Sara tells her that she and Brian have to discuss whether they can buy it for her, and Anna, disappointed, leaves. Sara and Brian realize that neither of them knew Anna was playing hockey.

The Fitzgeralds are about to leave to watch one of Anna's hockey games, but Kate doesn't want to go; she's self-conscious about a rash on her face, which is a side effect of her bone marrow transplant. Sara refuses to let her stay home but wraps her in scarves to hide her face. At the game, Anna plays goalie fantastically, causing all the other Fitzgeralds—even Kate—to get invested in the match. Brian is shocked at her natural talent, but Sara isn't. After all, "Anna saves, every time."

That night, Kate begins to hemorrhage uncontrollably. Sara and Brian rush her to the ER; although they're used to doing this, they have never seen anything this bad. Dr. Chance sees them and suggests arsenic therapy, a treatment that is so new that there aren't even any success stories yet. He points out that Kate has already lived 10 years past her prognosis, subtly suggesting that her time has come. Sara, however, insists on the treatment. When Dr. Chance comes out and says that the hemorrhaging will likely outpace the treatment, Sara stares at a children's growth chart on the wall and tries to remember if she told Kate she loved her before putting her to bed.

Around two in the morning, Brian slips out of Kate's room. Sara looks for him and finds him writing on a scrap of paper at the end of the hallway. When he sees Sara, he suggests bringing Kate home immediately, since he believes she would want to die in her own bed. When Sara protests, Brian tells her that Kate is dying, and they'll be lucky to have her for another year. Sara says that she loves Kate, and Brian says he does too—too much to see her suffer. Sara looks at Brian's paper and realizes he's writing a eulogy. Brian, beginning to cry, says he wants to do it now while he's still able. An hour later, Sara calls Suzanne sobbing and asks her to come down.

This scene illustrates how out-of-touch Sara and Brian are with Anna. Despite the fact that Anna has been playing hockey for months, neither of them have noticed at all—and, perhaps more significantly, Anna did not feel comfortable telling them about it. In other words, Sara and Brian have been so wrapped up with Kate that they have paid no attention to where Anna has been in her spare time.



In a rare instance of support for Anna, the entire Fitzgerald family goes to see her play hockey. The fact that she plays shockingly well shows the potential that Anna has when she's not forced into living for Kate. However, as Sara alludes to, Anna's role as goalie also symbolizes how she is constantly acting as a protector for other people.



The worst development in Kate's illness serves to emphasize how committed Sara is to Kate's, no matter what the odds are. Even though Sara's own doctor suggests that she's out of time, Sara refuses to let her go and instead insists on a treatment that has almost no data around it. This shows how Sara is incapable of letting go of control and acknowledging that Kate is going to die—but, given that this chapter is a flashback and Kate is alive in the present, it's also clear that her instincts are correct.



In contrast to Sara, who insists that Kate will survive her hemorrhaging, Brian forces himself to accept her imminent death, to the point that he wants to take her home to die in her own bed and is even writing a eulogy for her. This contrast once again illustrates the couple's differing approaches to Kate: Sara insists on battling to the very end, while Brian sees the value of ending Kate's suffering and letting her go peacefully.



Kate slips into a coma on her 11th day of transfusions and arsenic therapy. Sara attempts to hold a vigil but is pulled away because Jesse has been suspended for exploding the school's septic tank. She goes to pick him up, and he complains about the principal. When Sara responds that he will always be up against something, Jesse accuses her of making everything about Kate and says that she doesn't know what it's like being the brother of a girl with cancer, and Sara points out that she's the *mother* of a girl with cancer. She then notices injection marks on his arm and confronts him about it. He tells her that he's the one who's been donating blood to Kate, then runs out of the car.

Two weeks into Kate's hospital stay, Sara goes home. She's hanging out in the kitchen with Suzanne when Anna comes in and happily shows her an acceptance letter from a hockey camp, which she was able to get a full scholarship for. Sara tells her that she can't go, but Anna points out that it isn't until next summer—implying that Kate will be dead by then, freeing her of her obligation as a donor. Even so, Sara worries that, if Kate survives, they will need Anna as a donor when she is away. Anna insists on knowing why she can't go, and Sara asks that Anna not make her do this. Anna retorts that *she* doesn't make Sara do anything, then runs out to shoot against the wall of the garage.

Seventeen days into the hospital stay, Kate develops an infection. One day, Dr. Chance comes in to check on her and tells Sara that she needs to say goodbye. The Fitzgeralds prepare to do so, with Jesse and Anna spending time at Kate's side. Later, Sara and Brian sit with her. Sara says that Brian was right and that they should've taken her home, but Brian says they would've always wondered if they didn't try the arsenic. He says that Kate is waiting for Sara's permission to leave and starts to cry. After he falls asleep, Sara talks to Kate and says goodbye to her, telling her that she'll be able to see Sara waiting for her in Heaven. Sara squeezes Kate's hand, then feels her fingers move.

Jesse exploding the septic tank at his school is another clear example of him acting out in an attempt to be seen and cope with his grief over Kate; he himself confirms this when he alludes to the difficulty of being Kate's brother. However, the revelation that Jesse has been donating platelets shows that he is also acting on his helplessness in a more productive way: although he is not a donor match like Anna, there are still parts of his body he can give to Kate in order to keep her alive.



Sara's refusal to let Anna go to hockey camp is a vivid and painful example of how being Kate's donor affects Anna's quality of life. Although Kate will likely be gone by the time of the camp, Sara is unable to accept this and therefore refuses to grant Anna any semblance of freedom from her life as a donor. Anna's angry comment about how she doesn't force Sara into things is a clear allusion to her resentment at being forced into so many donations.



As the Fitzgeralds prepare to say goodbye, it appears as if Brian was right in accepting that Kate would not survive her hemorrhaging—but, importantly, he concedes that he's glad they attempted every last treatment before letting her go. This is by far the closest the Fitzgeralds come to losing Kate, but the faint movement of her hand at the end of the chapter confirms what the reader already knows: despite the near-impossible odds, Kate is going to live.



28. THE WEEKEND: ANNA

Anna wonders to herself how old people are when they go to Heaven—whether they appear in their prime, or if people appear as they were when they died. Anna theorizes that people get a choice, that they fill out an application where they can specify (Anna wants to appear at 17). She thinks of when Brian once said that he was 21 in his heart and wonders if everyone has a certain point in their life that they always come back to. She wonders how it would work if people tied to find each other in Heaven but were drastically different ages. She wonders what would happen if Kate died at 16 but chose to appear 35, an age that she never reached in life, and worries that she'd never be able to find Kate.

At Campbell's firm, Campbell and Anna meet Sara at the latter's request. Brian is there as well. Sara is awkward and uncomfortable; she moves forward to hug Anna, then stops herself. She explains that she is here to offer Anna a deal: she will never ask Anna for another donation if the cancer comes back, so long as Anna donates her kidney. Anna observes how small Sara looks; it's like she's the child, and Anna is the mother. She thinks back to when she realized that Santa wasn't real and realized that her parents weren't what she wanted them to be. She rushes forward to hug Sara, who interprets this as Anna's acceptance of the offer until Anna whispers that she can't. Sara pulls away, smiles, touches Anna's head, then leaves. Campbell asks Anna if this is what she really wants. Anna answers him.

Anna's musings about Heaven come immediately after the end of the last chapter, when Sara spoke of seeing Kate in Heaven again after her own death. This connection between the two chapters reorients the narrative in the present and serves as a reminder that, although Kate survived her last brush with death, the Fitzgeralds are once again staring down the barrel of her imminent passing. Furthermore, Anna's fear of not being able find Kate in Heaven contrasts with Sara's assurance she'd see Kate again in Heaven, reflecting Anna's fear of losing Kate forever.



Anna's rejection of Sara's deal marks a loss of innocence for her. This is signified by her feeling that she is the mother and Sara is the child, trying to convince Anna to give her something she wants. By rejecting Sara's offer, Anna has taken a firm step away from her instinct to fold under her mother's pressure and instead has begun to stand up for what she really wants. Her ability to firmly and immediately answer Campbell's question at the end of the chapter reinforces the fact that she is beginning to come into her own.



29. THE WEEKEND: JULIA

Julia asks Izzy if she thinks Julia likes Campbell "because he's an asshole, or in spite of it." Izzy is watching a movie and is initially annoyed at being interrupted, but she responds that maybe Julia just has an attraction to jerks, and it's also difficult to get over the first person you have sex with. She warns Julia that Campbell might be handsome, but he's rotten inside. Just then, Campbell himself arrives. He tells Julia about Sara's bargain and invites her to dinner to talk about it. Julia refuses at first but ultimately relents.

Campbell drives Julia to the edge of the water, but Julia doesn't see a restaurant. Julia tells him that her first rule is that they only talk about the trial. He tells her to take off her shoes and put her feet in the grass to relax; he does so himself. Julia, watching him, wonders if he took the case for PR or if he wants to help Anna; she can't help but hope it's the latter. She then relents, sitting on the grass with Campbell. He asks her what the second rule is, and Julia tells him that she makes all the rules. He smiles.

Izzy once again provides sisterly support to Julia regarding Campbell by simultaneously validating and criticizing her: she acknowledges that Julia's feelings are understandable, but also warns Julia against pursuing said feelings. Even so, Izzy's advice is not enough for Julia to resist going along with Campbell.



Julia continues to struggle with her feelings surrounding Campbell, particularly since she is unsure whether she can trust him or not. Because Campbell has refused to be forthright about his feelings, it has left Julia constantly seeing ulterior motives in everything he does.



The night before, Julia talks to Seven. He asks her what she's hiding from, and he says she's not hiding from anything. Seven points out that she's hiding out in a gay bar during the evening while wearing a suit. Julia tells him that she won't take fashion advice from him, and he bets her that he could get her to dye her hair again, since "you can take the pink hair dye out of the girl, but you never lose those roots." Julia responds that he doesn't know her, and he says that she doesn't know herself, either.

Julia and Campbell have dinner on a sailboat, and it becomes clear to Julia that Campbell is stalling on giving her information. They drink some wine and discuss which animal they would be. Julia says goose because they mate for life, and while Campbell doesn't answer directly, he says that Anna told him she'd be a phoenix. He then asks Julia what she thinks of Anna, causing her to stiffen as she realizes Campbell is trying to figure out what her decision for the hearing is. The two of them argue over Campbell's unethical behavior, and Julia asks him if anything that comes out of his mouth is honest. Campbell claims that he never lied about anything, and she asks him what Judge is for. He kisses her, and the two begin to undress.

Seven's comment about Julia's hair is a nod to the fact that, although Julia has fallen into a more conventional life, she still has the independent streak that guided her as an adolescent. Although Julia argues against this, Seven's claim that she doesn't even know herself reflects is hard for her to refute and reflects just how lost she really is.



Although Julia and Campbell reconcile (at least physically) in this scene, it is clear from their argument beforehand that this has not solved the issues between them. Julia still distrusts him, especially once she realizes that he's trying to glean her decision about Anna. However, the fact that she sleeps with him is evidence of how she struggles to disentangle her lingering feelings for him with her more pragmatic concerns about his ethics and morals.



30. MONDAY: CAMPBELL

Campbell wakes next to Julia in the sailboat. He looks at her, noticing the little details about her that he never noticed when he was younger and more impulsive. He thinks about how the thing that he's always loved about her is her fierce independence and the way that she never needed anyone. He doesn't want to be the one to take this away from her. Unlike past women he's been with, whom he has always slipped away from, he wants to stay with Julia longer—but Judge whines, and he knows that he has to get up. He does so, getting dressed and leaving Julia his car keys.

At the courthouse, the front steps are overrun with reporters. Campbell fights his way in and finds Sara, who's joined shortly by Brian. None of them know where Anna is. Brian wonders if the reporters scared her away. Julia comes in amidst the commotion. Both Campbell and Sara insist on being the one to find Anna, but they both realize where she is at the same time. As they go to leave, Julia catches up and points out what a bad sign it is that Anna hasn't even shown up for her own hearing. Campbell tells her that everybody gets scared.

Campbell's musings about Julia provide a hint about why he broke things off with her the first time: that it wasn't due to her socioeconomic status but because he did not want to strip her of her independence. However, it is not clear why Campbell feels he would've done this to her. Furthermore, his decision to leave before Julia wakes up means that he will make her feel abandoned all over again.



Although Anna was able to stand up to Sara during her plea deal, her absence at her trial suggests that she's still struggling to face the reality of the lawsuit she's begun. Her fickleness compromises Julia's faith in her ability to commit to her decisions, but Campbell's response suggests that he still has faith in Anna—or is at least determined to save face on her behalf.



Sara and Campbell arrive at Kate's hospital room to find Anna curled up at the foot of the bed. As Campbell crouches down to tell her she needs to leave, Jesse enters, explaining that he's here to look after Kate while everyone is at court. He says that Kate looks terrible, and Anna points out that she's dying, once again piquing Campbell's curiosity about Anna's motivations. Everyone but Jesse leaves the hospital room to return to court.

On the drive to court, Campbell pulls over and asks Anna why they're doing this lawsuit. Anna asks him why he has a service dog. He tells her that he got an ear infection that made him deaf in his left ear, which makes certain aspects of life more difficult. Thus, Judge serves as Campbell's ears. He tells her that he hides it because he doesn't want people's pity. Anna tells him that she filed her suit because she wanted to be the center of attention for once. Campbell immediately clocks this as a lie, but Anna points out that he lied first; his story about an ear infection was false. Campbell laughs and tells her that she reminds him of himself, then takes her to breakfast.

Judge DeSalvo is displeased by Campbell and Anna being late, but Campbell makes up an excuse about Judge having a vet emergency. The judge asks if there's any way to resolve the petition out of court, and although Campbell still does not understand Anna's motivations, he respects her wishes and says no. Sara confirms that she's still representing herself. The judge explains that, in family court, he tries to keep things as informal and painless as possible. As they move into the courtroom, Anna nervously asks if she'll have to testify. Campbell thinks that Judge DeSalvo will probably want her to, but he doesn't want her to panic, so he lies and says that he doubts it. He muses that there are two reasons to lie: to get what you want and to keep someone from getting hurt.

As the hearing begins, Campbell gives an opening statement (much to the chagrin of Judge DeSalvo). He tells the court that Anna has undergone medical treatments for the sake of her sister, rather than herself, and that although it's indisputable that Sara loves her children and has prolonged Kate's life, the court must question her judgment surrounding Anna. He looks at Julia and continues with an example of a homeless woman who started a **fire** and left the building without calling 911, causing six firefighters to die. The court didn't hold the woman liable because, in America, individuals are not responsible for others' safety. He uses this to demonstrate that what is legal and what is moral is not always the same thing.

That Anna has abandoned her hearing to visit Kate suggests that she is feeling guilty about the consequences of her winning her case. This is reinforced by Anna's comment that Kate is dying—with the implication that she's dying in part because of Anna's decision.



Although Anna and Campbell both lie to each other in this scene, it actually serves as a bonding moment for them; Campbell recognizes Anna's defiance as a trait that the two of them share. As a result, rather than continuing to grow frustrated with Anna over her evasiveness, he's able to meet her where she is and empathize with her desire to keep certain things to herself, even though it makes his job significantly more difficult.



Although Campbell's decision to lie to Anna about the likelihood of her having to testify comes in part from his more pragmatic side, his decisions in this moment show that he is giving much more consideration to Anna's emotional state than he did when he first took her case and treated her as nothing more than a client. He continues to advocate for her despite not fully knowing her reasons, and even his decision to lie to her is in part to keep her from panicking during a trial that's already causing her profound anxiety.



Campbell's opening statement sums up many of the issues that have been raised throughout the novel. Most notably, he highlights the contrast between Sara's strong allegiance to Kate and her disregard for Anna's wellbeing. He also makes an argument regarding the legal side of Anna's predicament; rather than focusing on whether what Anna is doing is "right" or not, he advocates for her legal right to have control over her own body, even if it results in a tragic ending for somebody else.



Campbell calls Sara as his first witness. He tries to get her declared as a hostile witness and is denied. Campbell goes over basic information about Sara and the Fitzgeralds, then forces her to go through the entire history of Anna's donations, emphasizing how Anna consented to none of them and pointing out the various side effects she suffered. Multiple times, Sara attempts to discuss Kate's situation, but Campbell deliberately directs her back to Anna. Sara defends herself by saying that, although Campbell represents only Anna, she represents both of her daughters and loves them both equally. Campbell responds that she has favored Kate in all her decisions. Sara suggests that Campbell is asking her to do the same thing, just favoring the other daughter.

Campbell's direct examination encapsulates the issues that have arisen from Sara's attempts to save Kate. As usual, Sara's instinct is to focus on Kate—which Campbell draws attention to when he repeatedly has to turn the attention back to Anna. In this way, Campbell forms his own narrative of the Fitzgeralds where Anna is not an unimportant sidekick for Kate's struggle, but an extremely important person whose wants and needs are important outside of her relation to Kate.



31. MONDAY: ANNA

Anna muses about how, when one is a little kid, they are fluent in "Ifspeak." This language, which people lose in adulthood, causes children to constantly ask about wild hypotheticals, such as getting bitten by a funnelweb spider where the only antivenom is locked up on the top of a mountain. Anna describes this as a "world of possibility," since children are infinitely open-minded. However, Anna believes that adulthood causes people's minds to close once again.

Anna's musings about "Ifspeak" is essentially her conception of the loss of innocence, where children begin to lose their imaginative view of the world and see reality for what it is. Given her own upbringing, it's implied that Anna is familiar with this closing of her mind as she grows older.



During the recess, Campbell brings Anna to a conference room to check in with her. She reflects on how she feels like a ghost due to everyone talking about her like she isn't there. She confesses that before, she was sure she was doing the right thing, but seeing Sara on the stand has made her wonder what it would be like if she was the sick one and Kate was doing what she's doing. She can't answer this—a sign that she's growing up. Campbell tells her not to give up, and she assures him that she's not, but that even if they win, they lose. She thinks back to two twins she babysits and how sometimes she wants to warn them about growing up.

Anna putting herself in Kate's place underscores just how serious the consequences of her petition are; after all, if she was sick, she would probably want Kate to do whatever she could to save her. However, the knowledge of these consequences do not cause Anna to abandon her battle, showing how she's overcome her hesitation about her lawsuit, even though she knows that she won't really enjoy victory even if she wins.



Back in court, Campbell calls Dr. Bergen. The doctor explains the premise of a medical ethics committee. In response to Campbell's questions, the doctor states that the committee has convened twice for Kate, with the second meeting about her kidney donation due to the high risk to Kate. Campbell asks if the committee considered the risk to Anna, but Dr. Bergen claims she isn't a patient. In response, Campbell pulls out Anna's medical records, which outline her multiple procedures. Anna, watching, feels happy to see someone fighting for her. When Campbell asks if the ethics committee would have ruled against the procedure if they knew Anna didn't consent, Dr. Bergen says that this is an unprecedented situation. Campbell points out that the ethics committee is meant to look at unprecedented situations, and Dr. Bergen concedes.

Campbell's interrogation of Dr. Bergen illustrates just how severely the medical establishment has failed Anna in neglecting to examine the ethics of what she's suffered on behalf of Kate. Campbell's point that Anna has undergone multiple procedures in the hospital but is not considered a patient portrays the hospital as absurd and thoughtless. He further indicts the committee by suggesting that, in avoiding Anna's situation because it was unique, they have abandoned the exact duties they're supposed to fulfill. Anna's joy at Campbell's fierce advocacy emphasizes just how rare it is for someone to stick up for her like this.



Campbell asks Dr. Bergen straight-out if he believes it's ethical for Anna to be asked to donate her body parts multiple times over her entire life. Dr. Bergen says that he voted against Kate's procedure since he does not believe Kate would survive, hence subjecting Anna to an invasive procedure for nothing. However, up until this instance, he believes the benefits to the entire family outweighed the risks to Anna. Campbell then asks Dr. Bergen what he would do if he had to give up his car, a Porsche, to save Judge DeSalvo's life, simply because a lawyer decided this was the case. The doctor scoffs at this, arguing that there are safeguards put into place to protect donor rights. Campbell asks how, in that case, Anna slipped through the cracks.

In a flashback to when Anna was just seven months old, the Fitzgeralds are at a block party. Anna is in a baby walker, moving between all the tables. Suddenly, she loses control of the wheels and goes veering past the road barricade towards traffic. Out of nowhere, Kate appears and grabs her just before she gets hit by a car. In the present day, people in the neighborhood still bring this story up. Anna remembers it as the moment Kate saved her life, even though it was also "the other way around."

Sara comes up to question Dr. Bergen after Campbell. She asks him to outline the process of coming up with a plan of action for Kate's treatment, then asks him if his report ever highlighted significant harm or risk to Anna. The answer is no. She then asks him if he has children, and he answers that he has a son. Then, she asks him if, in her position, he would question a course of action that would save his son's life, or if he would simply do whatever it took. The doctor doesn't answer; he doesn't need to.

Judge DeSalvo calls a second recess. Anna goes to follow Campbell out of the courtroom when she feels Sara tug down her t-shirt, which is riding up her back. Anna thinks about her mother's disdain for girls who dress in skimpy clothes. Both Anna and Campbell stop. Sara, embarrassed, apologizes. Anna puts her hand over Sara's, tucks in her shirt, and asks to meet up with Campbell in a minute. Campbell disapproves but leaves them alone. Anna kisses Sara on the cheek and tells her that she did great, because she doesn't know how to say what she really means: that she's constantly surprised by the people she loves.

Although Dr. Bergen generally agrees with the Fitzgeralds' decision to use Anna as a donor up to this point, the fact that even he disagrees with Kate's procedure underscores the various risks to the transplant that Sara has refused to consider. Campbell's hypothetical about Dr. Bergen's car once again raises the question of how much someone should have to sacrifice to save someone else's life—and a Porsche is certainly less of a sacrifice than one's own organ.



Kate's rescue of Anna is clearly an impulsive act of sisterly protectiveness, not born of an ulterior motive—but even so, Anna is correct in stating that Kate was saving her own life by saving Anna's. In this way, this flashback underscores just how intertwined Kate and Anna's lives really are.



Sara's questions to Dr. Bergen allow her to give her side of the story: that she's never put Anna at significant medical risk, and everything she's done was in order to save Kate. Where Campbell's questions center Anna, hers once again bring the narrative of the case back to not only Kate, but Sara's ceaseless efforts to save her.



Although Anna and Sara are on opposite sides in the courtroom, their interaction at the beginning of the recess shows that they still care for each other. Sara cannot resist giving into her maternal instincts in fixing Anna's clothes, and Anna still looks up to her mother to the point that she feels the need to congratulate her performance in court. Interestingly, as the hearing proceeds, the animosity between the two of them seems to be fading somewhat.



32. 2002: SARA

During platelet therapy, Kate strikes up conversation with a boy named Taylor, who is in chemotherapy for acute myeloid leukemia (AML). Sara watches them talk and quickly realizes that they're flirting with each other. He asks for Kate's phone number, and she gives it to him. Once he leaves, Kate gasps dreamily and calls him gorgeous. She excitedly asks Sara if he'll call and where they'll go for their first date. Sara tells her to take it slow, but internally, she's full of joy.

Kate gets into a routine of hiding in the closet and talking to Taylor on the phone every evening, emerging later blushing and overjoyed. Sara is stunned to see her actually get to grow up. One night, Sara finds her in the bathroom staring at herself in the mirror. She asks Sara what Taylor sees when he looks at her, and Sara answers that he probably sees a girl who understands his struggle. Kate answers that Taylor's cancer has a much higher survival rate than hers, and she asks if loving someone means caring more about their life than yours. Sara says yes. Kate then speculates that something bad is going to happen to balance out the good event of meeting Taylor. Sara denies this, but three days later, they learn that Kate has relapsed.

The night Kate comes home from her first date with Taylor, Sara eavesdrops on Kate and Anna talking in their room. Kate tells Anna that she kissed him and that he was a good kisser. Anna doesn't understand the appeal of kissing until Kate compares it to hockey, at which point it clicks for Anna. She then tells Anna that Taylor has scars on his hands from graft-versus-host disease. She felt them when they were holding hands. Anna asks if it was gross, but Kate says that it was like they matched.

To combat her relapse, Kate must undergo a blood stem cell transplant—once again using donations from Anna. Initially, Kate doesn't want to undergo chemo in preparation since it will separate her from Taylor. Sara tells her that it's her life, to which Kate says: "Exactly." The hospital compromises by allowing her to start her chemo as an outpatient, with the condition that they'll hospitalize her if her condition worsens. Neither Sara nor the hospital are happy about this but understand that Kate is reaching the age where she becomes more strong-willed.

Although Kate's illness isolates her from her peers and casts doubt on how much she'll grow up, in a moment of fortuitous irony, it is precisely her cancer that leads her to her first love interest, Taylor. Her flirtation with him signifies the miracle of her survival; after all, she was never expected to grow old enough to have a boyfriend.



Kate's dalliance with Taylor allows her a sliver of normalcy in her otherwise abnormal adolescence. While this is largely for the better, her increased focus on her physical appearance also risks increasing her self-consciousness due to the physical effects of her treatments. Kate's feelings for Taylor are also significant since she puts his wellbeing over her own. Given that Kate is normally the one being looked after, her desire to look after someone else marks an important moment in her process of coming of age—even as her survival prospects are once again jeopardized.



As Kate's relationship with Taylor progresses, the two continue to grow closer because of their cancer rather than in spite of it. While having a relationship with a healthy person might have been difficult for Kate, her comment about their matching scars shows how Taylor's cancer means that Kate can relate to him and truly be herself.



For the first time, Kate pushes back against her own treatments—an echo of Anna's own efforts to resist Sara's control of her medical decisions. However, although Kate's reasoning is more frivolous—she wants to see Taylor—Sara respects her wishes and compromises with her, a sharp difference from how she's responded to Anna.



During Kate's first chemo appointment, Taylor shows up to keep her company. It's 2:50, and he bets her that she can't make it to 3:00 without vomiting. Kate accepts. Sara watches them and thinks about the first time Brian met her: he saved her life during a massive storm in Providence. In the present, Taylor and Kate tease each other about throwing up during chemotherapy—then, at 2:57, Kate throws up. Taylor's demeanor immediately changes as he holds the emesis basin to her chin and rubs her back. Sara is overwhelmed with the realization that Kate has grown up from the tiny child she used to be. Taylor tells Kate that she can pay him for losing the bet by coming to a dance at the hospital with him. Kate accepts, and Taylor cuddles up next to her for the rest of her chemo.

Rather than just being a frivolous fling, Taylor quickly becomes an important source of support for Kate by keeping her company during chemo. Once again, their shared status as cancer patients allows him to be there for her without any judgement or squeamishness; for instance, rather than shying away from the fact that chemo makes you throw up, Taylor is able to draw on his own experiences to help Kate find humor in it and unflinchingly comfort her when she gets sick. Thus, Kate and Taylor's cancer allows them to understand each other on a deeper level.



Sara, Anna, and Kate have been shopping for hours to find Kate a dress for the dance. Since Kate's body is scarred, none of the dresses look good on her. When the saleswoman compliments the dress she's looking at, saying that it covers cleavage, Kate asks her if it will cover her Hickman line, which she reveals, and storms out. Sara tells her that Taylor already thinks she's beautiful, but Kate cries that she doesn't. Sara offers to sew a dress, but Kate angrily tells her that she doesn't know how to sew and can't learn in a day; Sara, she says, can't fix things every time. She leaves, but Anna follows, leading her into a salon. They ask the stylist if they do prom hairstyles, revealing Kate's bald head to confuse them. The two sisters collapse into laughter.

Sara and Anna's different responses to Kate's breakdown highlight their different approaches to Kate and how, at least in this case, Anna's approach works better. Sara's offer to learn sewing in two days only reinforces Kate's hopelessness over her appearance, since it's not a feasible appearance. Anna, by contrast, does not attempt to fix the situation, but instead helps Kate learn to laugh at it. This shows how, sometimes, embracing a bad situation rather than trying in vain to control it is the better option.



Sara acts as a chaperone at the desk. Kate and Taylor are inseparable for the night, Kate in a gold dress that Sara ordered for her online. Before they left that night, Sara caught Brian in tears in the kitchen. He was crying because he'd never expected to see a night like this for Kate. At the dance, Sara tries not to worry too much—especially given Kate's compromised immune system—but becomes concerned when she realizes that Kate and Taylor have vanished. She searches and finds them outside, talking about death. Taylor lifts the mask Kate is wearing and kisses her.

A first prom and kiss are major milestones for most teenagers, but it's especially significant for Kate, who was originally not expected to live past the age of five. This fact is evident in both her parents' reactions: Brian breaking down in tears in disbelief that this night has come, and Sara allowing her to have her first kiss despite the fact that both Taylor and Kate are immunocompromised.



The morning of her transplant, Kate is upset because Taylor hasn't called or returned her calls in three days. Sara goes to ask a nurse if he's in, and the nurse tells her that Taylor died that morning. Sara doesn't tell Kate for a month, fearing it will kill her. When she tells her, she talks about how she went to Taylor's house and talked to his mother, who told Sara that Taylor developed a 105 degree fever the night of the prom and died soon after. She doesn't tell her about how Taylor's mother sat with his body for five hours and still thinks she hears him moving in his room upstairs. Kate begins to sob and rejects Sara's comfort, telling her not to talk to her.

Sara's decision to keep Taylor's death from Kate is a protective act, but it's also a moment where Sara has decided that she knows what's best for Kate, effectively robbing her of her chance to properly mourn for Taylor. This reflects Sara's broader pattern of enacting control over her daughters' lives in an attempt to protect them—especially Kate—even when one or both of their daughters are telling her it's not what they want.



Kate doesn't speak to Sara for a week. Sara is devastated, feeling that she has "lost [her] daughter before she's even gone." But one day, she walks by Kate's room and sees her looking through photos of her and Taylor at the prom. Sara looks at the photos and thinks of how bizarre and terrible it is that such a bright person is instantly gone; Sara thinks of it as "practice." Kate has also taken out older photos of herself, including baby pictures from before she was diagnosed. Kate says that she doesn't remember being this little girl, but that she was beautiful.

The photographs Kate is looking at symbolize the opportunities lost due to cancer. The most straightforward instance of is of course Taylor, who died—but Kate's baby pictures from before her diagnosis also signify the metaphorical "death" of the person that Kate could've been if she'd never gotten cancer.



33. MONDAY: JESSE

In a flashback to when Jesse was 14, Sara and Brian send him to a boot camp on a farm. One day, Jesse is assigned to herd sheep, a job that he hates due to the sheep being difficult to guide. He hears a scream in the distance and finds a sheep giving birth. The sheep has been unable to fully push out the lamb. Jesse doesn't want the sheep to die on his watch, so he grabs the lamb's feet and pulls it out, then cuts it out of a skin sac suffocating it so that it can breathe. The lamb survives, and Jesse recognizes it the entire summer due to its white pupils, a sign that it's been to the other side. Jesse tells the reader that he's describing this because, when Kate opens her eyes in the present, he knows she's been on the other side, too.

Although Jesse is a chronic troublemaker, his encounter with the sheep and her lamb suggests that he does have compassion for other living things and puts a high value on life—a trait that is all the more tragic given that his parents have written him off enough to send him away to a boot camp. As Jesse describes, his experience with the lamb is also an explicit parallel to Kate, who has had a brush with death but manages to return to the living.



When Kate wakes up, she sees Jesse and jokes that she must be in Hell. She asks why he's here; internally, he thinks it's because Kate won't be here much longer, but he jokes that he came to see a hot nurse. Kate laughs and says she's going to miss him, shocking them both into silence. Kate wonders if she'll be reincarnated; Jesse thinks he'll only be reincarnated into carrion. One of Kate's monitors goes off, but she says that she's fine. Jesse thinks back to little bets he made with himself when he was younger—bets like holding his breath to keep the night from coming—and wonders if he can do the same to save Kate. He asks her if she's afraid of dying, and she says she'll let him know. She then falls asleep. Jesse leaves her room and punches a hole in the wall.

In their conversation, both Jesse and Kate find themselves coming to terms with Kate's imminent death. Rather than avoiding the topic, they face it head-on, talking about what they think death will be like for Kate. However, Jesse still struggles with his inability to save Kate, as shown by his punching the wall after she falls asleep. This act, like his past acts of rebellion, are manifestations of emotional pain rather than shallow attempts to cause trouble.



34. MONDAY: BRIAN

To the reader, Brian describes the recipe for a chemical explosive: bleach and potassium chloride, which will form crystals that need to be saved for later. At the courthouse, Brian waits for his turn to testify when his pager beeps, leaving him in a dilemma; after all, he's scheduled to testify, but his job needs him immediately. He gets permission from Judge DeSalvo to leave, and when he leaves, he's immediately bombarded with journalists. He struggles to keep his temper against "these vultures ... who want to rip apart the bleached bones of [his] family."

The recipe that Brian describes to the reader is not given much context, but its volatility sets the tone for the rage that Brian feels at the beginning of this chapter as he struggles through the journalists that are profiting from the Fitzgeralds' suffering. As shown by Brian's previous outburst at work, his ability to maintain control over his own emotions is becoming frayed.



Earlier that morning when Anna was missing, Brian went to search for her in Jesse's room, where he found a recycling bin with a jug of laundry detergent. In the present, Brian investigates a new arson case at an elementary school, which was thankfully empty at the time of the **fire**. The fire was started by dousing couch cushions and paper in gasoline, and a window has been broken, presumably by the firefighters to vent the fire. Caesar finds a cigarette butt, which Brian takes, looking at the brand. On the way out from the scene, Paulie tells Brian that they weren't the ones who broke the window. Brian realizes that the arsonist knew where to break a window to create a wind tunnel and feed the fire. He looks at the cigarette butt and crushes it in his hand.

Returning to the explosive recipe, Brian explains that the crystals must be mixed with distilled water and cooled again, then ground into powder, combined in gasoline, and dipped in wax. He goes home and confronts Jesse in the room, telling him that he knows he's the arsonist. He lifts the laundry detergent and asks why he has it if he never does his own laundry. Jesse initially denies it, but folds when Brian shows him the cigarette butt: a Merit cigarette, the same that Jesse smokes. Jesse begins to cry, saying that he couldn't save Kate. He asks if Brian has told Sara, and Brian realizes that Jesse wants to be punished. Instead, he hugs Jesse, realizing that he's partially responsible for neglecting Jesse due to him not being a match for Kate. He vows not to report Jesse.

In the scene where Brian investigates the fire, Picoult spends a somewhat unusual amount of time describing the specific clues he finds, such as the cigarette butt and the arsonist's understanding of fire. These details seem to be connected in some way to Brian going up to Jesse's that morning and finding laundry detergent, a seemingly insignificant item. Given that the reader already knows that Jesse is the arsonist, this slight shift in narrative style hints that these clues might be leading Brian to surmise the identity of the arsonist.



Brian completes the explosive recipe, further building on the tense tone of the chapter. In Jesse's room, the clues that Brian has found converge and allow him to confront Jesse regarding his arson. Although this confrontation gives Brian an opportunity to send Jesse away to prison and give up on him once and for all, Brian choosing not to report Jesse represents him refusing to do this in order to give him a second chance. In other words, Brian's decision signifies a major shift in his relationship with Jesse.



35. MONDAY: CAMPBELL

Campbell's next witness is Dr. Chance. At Campbell's pressing, the doctor explains how the Fitzgeralds conceived Anna after learning of another family who happened to conceive a perfect match for their sick child. Campbell asks if he would recommend a treatment that required Anna to cut off her own head; Dr. Chance, of course, says no. Campbell, however, argues that Dr. Chance has endangered Anna's life due to the risk of the procedures she's undergone. He also points out that Sara was the one who signed the release form, not Anna. Dr. Chance argues that the risks are low. Campbell also goes over the effects of a kidney transplant, such as needing to avoid contact sports. Campbell informs Dr. Chance that Anna is a hockey player. Campbell then asks if Anna has benefited from any of these procedures. Dr. Chance says yes: she's saving her sister.

Campbell's debate with Dr. Chance, who knows Kate's treatment more than anyone, provides a look at both sides of the debate. Although the nature of Dr. Chance means that he's biased towards Kate, he provides more objective reasoning for why Anna should donate her kidney: the risk of kidney donation is quite low, and Anna benefits in a very real way since she doesn't have to lose her sister. However, Campbell's point about Anna's love for hockey highlights one of Dr. Chance's blind spots: that even if Anna is unlikely to die from her procedure, it will still rob her of other important things in her life.



Campbell and Anna are eating lunch during recess when Julia joins them to check on Anna. Anna tells her that she just wants the whole thing to be over, and Julia reassures her that it will be soon. Suddenly, Anna excuses herself, first by offering to walk Judge—which Campbell denies her—and then by going to the bathroom. Campbell realizes she left him alone with Julia on purpose. Julia asks why Campbell didn't wake her up, and Campbell jokes that they were anchored in a "no-wake zone." Julia, however, doesn't laugh. She asks him if the previous night was a joke to him, and Campbell abruptly leaves without answering.

Court adjourns that afternoon. Campbell brings Anna out to find Brian, but he's gone, so Campbell offers to drive her to the station. Once they get there, Campbell reassures her that their first day in court was great, but Anna isn't enthusiastic; she gets out of the car without another word. Campbell follows her. Anna asks him if he's ever done anything he knew was wrong; Campbell says yes. Anna then says that she hates herself sometimes, and Campbell says he feels the same. The two of them talk briefly about the **stars**, with Campbell admitting he used to wish on a star every night. Anna asks Campbell if he's close with his parents, and Campbell tells the truth: he's not like them and doesn't want to be. Anna tells him that he was invisible, too.

36. TUESDAY: CAMPBELL

Brian, Campbell's key witness, is testifying today. He shows up early with Anna wearing his captain's uniform. Campbell asks Anna to walk Judge—even though he told her she couldn't the day before—but she sees through his ploy and insists on staying for their conversation. Campbell asks Brian if he's all right just as Sara enters the building. She pauses when she sees Brian with Campbell, then keeps walking. Brian stiffly responds: "We're fine."

Brian takes the stand. Campbell leads him into discussing how he was not always comfortable with Anna's donations, particularly how Anna was originally only supposed to donate cord blood but then this turned into more and more donations. Even so, Brian discusses how difficult of a decision it was given Kate's condition. He recalls how, when Kate was hemorrhaging, he wanted to give up on her and Sara didn't, and Sara was right—which makes him reluctant to give up on Kate now. Campbell redirects Brian to talking about how he moved Anna out of the house, then asks him the key question: Does Brian agree with Sara about Anna continuing to be a donor? To Campbell's dismay, Brian says yes. He asks Campbell what the right answer is in this situation, because he hasn't found a better solution. Then, he begins to cry.

Even after the night he spent with her, Campbell struggles to open up to Julia. Although he attempts to deflect his emotional distance with humor, Julia's solemn and hurt response shows that Campbell has repeated his mistake of hurting her, the same way he did in high school. Their interaction highlights how difficult it is for Campbell to be emotionally vulnerable, even at the cost of Julia's trust.



In contrast to the emotional distance he just showed to Julia, Campbell's ability to express empathy with Anna's self-loathing and uncertainty shows that, although he still struggles to be in touch with his own emotions around other people, Anna brings out a gentler part of him. His frankness regarding his self-worth and his own relationship with his parents is a stark contrast to how he began his relationship with Anna, where he viewed her solely as a client and refused to find any emotional common ground with her.



Brian is the most important witness for Campbell and Anna's case, since a testimony from one of Anna's parents agreeing to emancipation will essentially end any debate. However, Brian's anxious response to Sara's entrance suggests that he might be having doubts about his decision and how it could affect his marriage.



Brian's about-face on the stand is a massive disappointment to Campbell, but it also shows just how impossible Brian's situation is. His testimony highlights the suffering Anna underwent during her donations, but his memory of Sara refusing to give up on Kate during her hemorrhaging raises the question of whether Kate could survive her liver transplant against all odds, too. With this in mind, Brian's answer to Campbell's last question is understandable and shows how he is constantly torn between both Kate and Anna when considering what the right thing to do is.



Judge DeSalvo calls for a 10-minute recess before Sara cross-examines Brian. Campbell and Anna go downstairs, where Anna says that she's never seen her dad cry and worries that she did that to him. Campbell tells Anna that, since Brian wasn't the breakout witness Campbell was hoping for, she will have to take the stand herself. Anna blanches at this, but Campbell tells her that now is the time to show everyone that she has the maturity to make difficult choices. Even so, Anna staunchly refuses. Campbell asks her why she's so against testifying, and Anna refuses this as well. She says she's not going to change her mind; in response, Campbell tells her not to expect him to change her life.

Although Anna and Campbell's relationship has made significant progress, the two once again find themselves at odds due to Campbell's dishonesty and Anna's stonewalling. The latter is especially significant since Anna refuses to even state why she won't testify. Her stubbornness and secretiveness serves as a reminder, both to Campbell and the reader, that her true motivations for the lawsuit have never been explicitly spelled out.



37. TUESDAY: SARA

As Brian takes the stand, Sara looks at his face and thinks about the features of him that she still loves, even though he's changed so much over the years. She gets up to question him but ends up reminiscing about bringing the kids on an aimless road trip until they ended up in a dark cabin. Brian joins in, talking about how they lit candles and stayed inside all week to avoid the flies; it was a terrible place and a wonderful experience. Sara asks if Anna would miss these experiences if Kate was gone, and Brian says that they all would. In an instant, Sara and Brian are on the same page again; she realizes that, though they've disagreed on the details, they've accomplished so much together. Sara finishes her cross-examination by asking Brian when he's coming home.

Brian and Sara's recollection of their time in the cabin symbolizes the significance of their marriage despite difficult their difficult circumstances. Although the cabin was an unpleasant place, the fact that the family was able to spend time together and make meaningful memories reflects how Brian and Sara have made a beautiful life together despite struggling with Kate's illness. By remembering the moments of their lives that have brought them together, Brian and Sara are able to emotionally reconcile while Brian is on the stand.



During a recess, Sara goes to the courthouse basement to buy something from the vending machines. Brian comes down and recommends the Oreos, putting in the coins to buy them for her. The two of them sit down at a table, where Sara admits to him that she had no idea what to say to him on the stand. She then asks him if he thinks they're good parents. Brian says he doesn't know, wondering if anyone does. He puts an Oreo in her mouth and delicately brushes the crumbs from her lips.

The intimate moment that Sara and Brian share highlights that, although their marriage has been rocky for a long time, they're beginning to reconcile with each other. They're both honest with each other about their thoughts and feelings—a trait that they've struggled with in their relationship up until this point.



That night, Brian and Anna move back home. Before returning to the hospital, Sara goes into Anna's room to talk to her. She tells Anna that she's not bad for wanting to be her own person, and that it's okay to have turned out differently than the person everyone expected her to become. She gives the example of a kid who's bullied at one school but is popular at a new one because nobody had any expectations of her. Anna says she's not making much sense, and Sara says that what she's trying to say is that Anna reminds her of herself.

Sara's reconciliation with Brian also moves her to find common ground with Anna. After a long time of disregarding Anna's needs, she finally acknowledges them, seeing Anna's desire for agency for what it is. Her acceptance of Anna's wants more broadly signify her letting go of the need to control everything, since accepting Anna means accepting her right to keep her kidney.



Sara muses about how, when you've been with the same person for so long, they start to feel like a well-worn map—until one day, you find an unfamiliar turnoff that you wonder if you've missed all along. That night, Brian lies next to Sara in bed and begins to kiss her, then bites her lip hard enough to draw blood. He then licks it off, surprising her. He then puts his head on her belly, a familiar gesture he did when she was pregnant. The two start to have sex. At one point, Sara says, "We're going to lose her," not knowing if she's talking about Anna or Kate. Brian kisses her and tells her to stop, and they don't talk anymore.

Most of the scenes with Sara and Brian up to this point have emphasized how stagnant and cold their relationship has become. In contrast, Brian's surprising and provocative behavior signifies the new life being breathed into their marriage, as symbolized by the blood that Brian draws. Notably, although it was their children's situations that strained their marriage, now they're drawn back together by their love and grief for their children.



38. WEDNESDAY: JULIA

Julia returns home after going on a jog at 4:30 in the morning. When Izzy asks if she's okay, Julia says yes. But then, she goes into the kitchen and discovers her coffeemaker is broken. Izzy calmly asks if it's under warranty, but Julia says she doesn't care; she just wants a cup of coffee. Slamming the carafe into the sink and breaking it, she sinks to the ground and begins crying. Izzy asks what Campbell did, and Julia answers that he did the same thing as always. Izzy asks how Julia wants her to torture Campbell, making Julia smile. Julia says that lightning isn't supposed to strike the same place twice, and Izzy responds that it does if you're too stupid to move.

Julia's outburst over her coffeemaker is an instance of her lashing out over something small in place of a larger issue in her life: namely, her relationship with Campbell. The coffeemaker being broken is trivial, but it serves to remind Julia of how many things in her life are outside of her control. That such a small thing overwhelms her emphasizes just how badly Campbell has hurt her.



When Julia gets to the courthouse, Judge runs to her and drags her over to Campbell, who is arguing loudly with Anna over her refusal to take the stand. Anna storms off, calling Campbell an asshole, and Julia remembers how angry at herself she was when she woke alone on the boat.

Julia witnessing Campbell's argument with Anna reignites her distrust in him. She's been worried that Campbell is not doing right by Anna, and seeing this argument validates those fears.



Judge jumps on Campbell, drawing the latter's attention to Julia. She tells him that he shouldn't be surprised that Anna won't testify given her lack of commitment. Campbell asks Julia what she's going to tell DeSalvo, and she asks him if he's asking for Anna's sake or his own. She tells him that he and Anna are both cowards, bent on running from themselves, and accuses Campbell of pushing away anyone who gets away close. Campbell initially responds coldly, but as Julia walks away, he calls after her. However, Judge DeSalvo convenes the hearing before he can finish. Campbell then tells Julia that she's his next witness.

Julia's criticism highlights the major flaw that both Campbell and Anna share: that they struggle with commitment. Campbell struggles to commit to other people; Anna, however, struggles to commit to herself. Julia points out how, although Campbell is icing her out, he's similar to Anna in that he's running from himself by refusing to acknowledge what he truly wants: specifically, a relationship with Julia.



39. WEDNESDAY: CAMPBELL

As court convenes, Campbell's hands are trembling from the nerves of calling Julia. However, Sara requests to call her witness, a psychiatrist, first. Dr. Beata Neaux takes the stand. At Sara's request, Dr. Neaux has prepared an expert opinion about the mental harm Anna will face if Kate dies. The doctor claims that Anna defines herself as a member of an intact family rather than a broken one and cites studies that show that donor children have high self-esteem. Campbell doesn't buy any of this, but Judge DeSalvo and Julia seem engaged. Sara asks if Anna can make her own medical decisions, and Dr. Neaux says no; her age means all her decisions will be looking at the short-term, so she needs someone to guide her. In Dr. Neaux's words, "the parents need to be the parents."

Campbell cross-examines Dr. Neaux. He asks her what sort of psychological harm Anna will sustain if, after donating her kidney, Kate dies anyway. Dr. Neaux says that she trusts Anna's parents to help her through that. Campbell then asks about the harm of Anna's agency being taken from her. The doctor concedes that this harm matters, but that Anna doesn't understand how her decision will play out long-term. Campbell points out that this is the same for Sara, who's constantly reacting to Kate's situation. Dr. Neaux grudgingly concedes this point. Campbell suggests that, since Sara defines herself by her ability to keep Kate healthy and makes choices in reaction to short-term circumstances, Sara is psychologically a "donor" for Kate and thus no more capable of making these decisions than Anna. Campbell then says that parents do need to be parents, but "sometimes that isn't good enough."

Dr. Neaux's psychological analysis of Anna is ironic in that it contrasts sharply with Anna's established characterization. Dr. Neaux says that Anna defines herself as an intact family, but throughout the novel, Anna has felt isolated from her family and often dreams of being raised by other parents. Dr. Neaux also cites donors having higher self-esteem, but Anna repeatedly expresses self-loathing for her conflicted feelings about Kate. This discrepancy ultimately casts doubt over Dr. Neaux's final recommendation to deny Anna her emancipation.



In his cross-examination of Dr. Neaux, Campbell flips her reasoning on its head by applying psychological analysis to Sara. His claim that she is constantly making short-term reactions and therefore is no more able to make rational decisions than Anna implicitly criticizes Dr. Neaux's implication that, as a child, Anna is somehow less entitled to agency than an adult in the exact same psychological condition. In this way, Campbell successfully refutes the argument that Anna is psychologically incapable of making her own decisions.



40. WEDNESDAY: JULIA

During a break, Julia goes into the bathroom and puts down her bag, a Guatemalan woven knapsack, on the counter. Anna exits a bathroom stall and washes her hands. Julia asks her about her decision not to testify. When Anna is evasive, Julia tells her that getting what you want sometimes requires doing things you don't want to do. Anna blows her off but compliments her bag. Julia explains that it takes 20 spools of thread to make the pattern. Anna compares this to truth, then leaves.

Julia takes the stand; she watches Campbell's hands tremble. He asks her what her recommendation is. Julia looks at Anna and says that she understands the profound responsibility that Anna feels, having been conceived to save Kate. However, she also understands Sara and Brian's drive to do whatever it takes to save Kate. Julia testifies that there is a point where the Fitzgeralds must let go.

Anna continues to stubbornly refuse to testify or provide a reason for her silence, clearly showing that she's not yet ready to put down her walls and share her true reasons for her lawsuit. However, her odd comparison of Julia's knapsack to the truth suggests that whatever she is hiding might disrupt everyone's understanding of the lawsuit.



Julia's testimony underscores the complicated moral conflict that the Fitzgeralds face: namely, that while it's understandable that Sara and Brian want to do anything they can to save Kate, they can only do this at the cost of Anna's agency and quality of life.



In a flashback to after her breakup with Campbell, Julia is inconsolable and is barely getting out of bed. Finally, she musters the energy to go to Wheeler and approaches a boy on the sailing team, asking him for a ride home. The two of them have sex in the back of his car. Julia explains that she did this so that she could get the smell and taste of Campbell off of her, and so that she could stop feeling as hollow as a balloon.

Back in the present, Julia explains how, when she first accepted this assignment, she initially thought that medical emancipation was the best choice. The easy part of the decision is determining that, physiologically, donating a kidney is not in Anna's best interest. However, Julia also feels that, given the entire family's inability to make informed decisions due to the constant state of crisis they're in, Anna is not able to make independent decisions without the pressure of her parents' wishes weighing on her. In other words, Julia says that nobody in the family has the ability to make unbiased decisions about Anna's care. Judge DeSalvo asks what her recommendation is.

Julia's encounter with the boy on the sailing team is an example of her attempting to reclaim her body from Campbell after their breakup. However, it is an ultimately hollow attempt to feel a sense of control, since her physical fulfillment will not heal her emotional scars.



In an echo of Campbell's cross-examination of Dr. Neaux, Julia alludes to the fact that Anna is not the only Fitzgerald incapable of making objective decisions; every single one of them has had their judgement clouded by the trauma of Kate's illness. In this way, Julia shows profound empathy for the entire Fitzgerald family—but she also subtly questions their ability to handle the current situation with any real rationality.



41. WEDNESDAY: CAMPBELL

Campbell feels confident that Julia isn't going to veto his petition. At his side, Judge is frantically tugging at his coat, but Campbell ignores him. Julia answers the judge and admits that she doesn't know what her recommendation is. She understands Sara and Brian's decisions but wants to respect Anna standing up for herself. She tells the judge that she doesn't feel comfortable tearing apart a family. Suddenly, Anna tugs at Campbell's sleeve and tells him that she's willing to testify. Judge begins to whine. Anna stands up and tells Judge DeSalvo that she has something to say.

In a parallel to Brian's testimony, Julia finds herself incapable of committing to a solution for the Fitzgeralds' situation. The fact that multiple characters have been left at a loss reflects how ethically complex Kate and Anna's predicament is, and how there is no answer that will result in a happy ending. The reality of this, it seems, propels Anna to finally decide to speak for herself.



42. WEDNESDAY: ANNA

Having just taken the witness stand, Anna is afraid of saying too much. She looks at her parents and thinks of sitting back down, but then she sees Campbell, who is sweating and has dilated pupils. He comes up to confer with her and leans in to tell her he had a friend named Joseph Balz as a kid, and he points out how funny it would be if Dr. Neaux married him. He backs away while she's still smiling. Judge is extremely agitated; Campbell tells him to calm down and begins questioning Anna. He asks her why she wants to file her petition, and Anna says: "She asked." When Campbell asks for clarification, she says that Sara asked for her kidney—but Anna knows she's not being fully honest.

Anna's noticing that Campbell doesn't look well, as well as Campbell telling Anna a joke to help calm her nerves up on the stand, show how Anna and Campbell have come to care for each other beyond their professional relationship. However, Anna's response to Campbell's question and her admission that she's not being honest suggests that she is still holding something back. Given the brevity of her response, it's likely that the "she" in her answer was not actually Sara.



In a flashback to two months earlier, shortly after Kate is diagnosed with kidney failure, Sara and Brian come into the girls' room. Sara tells Kate that she's been talking to Dr. Chance about a kidney transplant, and that he won't recommend the procedure unless the kidney comes from Anna. Brian points out that this is an invasive surgery, and Anna internally worries about the effect losing a kidney would have on her life. Kate responds first, saying she's sick of the whole thing and wants to be left alone. Sara, infuriated, tells her that she can go ahead and die by suicide, then. Kate says that "it's not suicide [...] if you're already dying."

Campbell asks Anna if she ever told anyone she didn't want to be a donor. Judge is running all around the courtroom, causing Judge DeSalvo to threaten to remove him, but Campbell ignores both, focusing on Anna. He asks her if she decided to file this lawsuit all by herself. Anna knows he wants her to say yes and prove that she's capable of making decisions on her own, but she confesses that someone did convince her: Kate. Before anyone in the courtroom can react to this revelation, Campbell collapses.

43. WEDNESDAY: BRIAN

Brian, thinking about how time moves faster on Earth than in space, feels as though he's just returned "to a world where nothing quite makes sense." He tries to listen to what Anna is saying and compares making sense of her words to trying to find shapes in a **constellation**. Then, he realizes he's been looking in the wrong places; other cultures look for shapes in the dark spots, not the light. As he's thinking this, Campbell collapses and begins to have a seizure.

Brian takes care of Campbell through his grand mal seizure with the help of Judge, who brings him a bite block to ensure that Campbell doesn't bite his own tongue. Julia comes to Campbell's side in tears, asking Brian what's happening and why; he reassures her that Campbell will be fine. Brian thinks of how the sky is off-kilter because the Earth's axis wobbles; in Brian's words, "life isn't nearly as stable as we want it to be."

Throughout the novel, there have only been a few moments where Kate has been shown to express her feelings about her treatment. This flashback suggests that, although Sara is determined to save Kate at all costs, Kate does not feel the same way, but in fact is growing tired of undergoing her treatments, especially when said treatments put Anna in a difficult position. Her feelings suggest that Sara has been ignoring her desires as well as Anna's.



Anna's revelation that Kate asked her to file the lawsuit recontextualizes everything that has happened so far. In addition to being about Anna's bodily autonomy, this case is also about Kate's bodily autonomy—which revolves not around her desire to live, but around her desire to let go. Campbell's mysterious collapse also mirrors the dramatic turn in the case.



Brian's comparison between Anna's words and the dark spaces in the sky highlights the truth that's been hidden for much of the novel. Rather than focusing on what Anna has been saying, Brian realizes that he should have been focusing on what she wasn't saying: her explicit reason for filing her lawsuit.



Julia's tearful concern for Campbell reveals that, despite the anger she feels towards him, she still cares deeply for him. The shocking nature of his seizure is reflected in Brian's thoughts about the Earth's off-kilter axis, highlighting how little control people have over the events of their lives and, sometimes, their own bodies.



Campbell comes to. Brian helps him to Judge DeSalvo's quarters and explains that he had a seizure. Campbell has wet himself, so Brian brings him some pants and helps him change, having been desensitized to changing people's clothes due to his EMT experience. He can tell Campbell is mortified, especially once he discovers everyone in the courtroom saw his seizure. Campbell tells Brian that he developed epilepsy from a car crash when he was 18 and has hidden it ever since. He struggles to remember Anna's testimony and says that he needs to go back to court, but Julia comes in and tells him to wait. Brian, sensing the tension between the two of them, leaves them alone. Brian thinks of how **stars** are not always how they first appear.

Campbell and Brian's interactions show the former man at his most vulnerable, sharply contrasting with the façade of control that he has kept up for the entire novel. The reveal of his epilepsy shows that, much like Kate, Campbell struggles with lacking control over his body, which has led him to feel the need to control the rest of his life by isolating himself and hiding his condition. This impulse of his has most seriously harmed Julia, but her entrance into the room at the end of the chapter hints that a reconciliation may be imminent.



44. WEDNESDAY: CAMPBELL

As Julia walks towards Campbell, he wearily tells her that Judge is a seizure dog. She tells him that she figured as much. Julia asks why he didn't tell her about his epilepsy, and Campbell explains that when he got sick, he decided that he didn't want to rob Julia of her independent spirit by making her deal with it. Julia points out that, in doing this, Campbell robbed her of the ability to make that choice for herself. She confesses that Campbell's leaving her made her think something was wrong with her. Campbell thinks this is ridiculous, but Julia points out that she has flaws, too. She then tells him that this time, she gets to leave him, and Campbell, dejected, tells her to go. She tells him that she will—in 50 or 60 years.

Much like Anna's revelation, Campbell's motivations for his behavior are now laid bare as well: he felt that his epilepsy would rob Julia of her independent spirit. However, the irony of this, as Julia points out, is that Campbell compromised her independence by assuming what she wanted without asking her. But now that the truth has come out and Campbell has been forced to be vulnerable with Julia and cede control over everything, he is able to truly reconcile with her for good.



45. WEDNESDAY: ANNA

Campbell can't make it upstairs to the conference rooms, so Anna meets him in the men's room to talk privately. He apologizes to her about what happened, and she asks him about Judge. He explains that Judge can sense his seizures coming, which usually gives him about 20 minutes to prepare for it. Anna finds herself shy around him, even though she's used to being around Kate's illness. She asks if he took her case because he understands what it's like to not have control over his body, and he concedes this might be the case—but that he also needed his doorknobs polished. Anna is reluctant to get back on the stand, but Campbell encourages her by telling her that if he can go back after his seizure, she can go back, too.

In this scene, the full truth of both Campbell and Anna's situations have come out, allowing them to be fully honest with each other for the first time in the novel. As a result, they are able to find more common ground, specifically when it comes to bodily autonomy; as Anna points out, Campbell also understands the powerlessness that can come from lacking control over one's body. Campbell is also able to use his epilepsy to encourage Anna, showing how his emotional vulnerability can be a boon just as much as a drawback.



Back in the courtroom, Campbell gets a refresher as to what Anna said from the transcriptionist, then asks Anna to elaborate. She confesses to the court that Kate didn't ask her to file the suit—she asked Anna to kill her. In a flashback, Anna remembers coming into the bathroom one night to discover whiskey in the cabinet. She confronts Kate, only to see Kate holding pills. Kate tells her that she's tired of waiting for the inevitable and ruining everyone else's life. Anna tells her that she can't just kill herself, and Kate tearfully says she knows this. Anna realizes that Kate has attempted suicide before.

In court, Sara accuses Anna of lying, because Kate would have told her if she was that upset. Anna begins to cry and says Kate was afraid of hurting Sara by killing herself, but that Anna could always give her what she wants. In another flashback after Sara talked to the girls about the kidney transplant, Kate tells Anna not to donate her kidney. Anna asks her if she thinks the kidney transplant would work, but Kate simply looks at Anna and repeats her demand that Anna not do it. Anna realizes that Kate is asking her to let her die.

Sara comes up to the stand, but Brian pulls her back. Campbell asks Anna why she was willing to take an action that would kill the sister she loves, and Anna answers that she thought it was what Kate wanted—and admits that she wanted it, too. In a flashback when the two sisters are doing dishes, Kate tries to convince Anna that, if Kate was gone, Anna would be able to live any life she wants without having to be bound to Kate. Anna is uncomfortable with how easily Kate is able to discern that, although she loves Kate, part of her wants to be free of it all.

Anna is convinced that everyone in the courtroom thinks she's a monster now that she's revealed her true feelings: she wants Kate to live, but she also wants a chance to live her own life, even if it means Kate doesn't get to grow up. She thinks about how, sometimes, she hates herself and wants to go back to doing exactly what's expected of her. Campbell gently asks Anna why she thought Kate was ready to die. Anna answers that Kate said she was ready. Campbell suggests that Kate wanted Anna to help her so that Anna could be free. Then, Campbell asks Anna what Kate said when Anna told her she was going to stop being a donor. Kate thanked her.

The question of bodily autonomy is especially complicated for Kate. With both Anna and Sara's endeavors, their focus is on the preservation of life: Anna wishes to preserve the quality of her life, while Sara wishes to preserve Kate's life. Kate's suicidality, however, raises the question of how much of a right someone has to end their own life, particularly if they are suffering from an illness likely to kill them eventually.



That Kate asks Anna to refuse kidney donation in order to avoid hurting Sara's feelings reveals an important truth: while Sara's drive to keep Kate alive has done profound harm to Anna, it has also put immense pressure on Kate to continue surviving despite the severe suffering she has to undergo in order to stay alive. In this way, Kate is revealed to feel her own sense of heavy responsibility towards Sara, just as Anna does.



Although the revelation of Kate's interference in the case shifts the narrative focus to her bodily autonomy, Anna's confession that part of her also wanted Kate to die serves as a reminder that Anna's motivations for filing the lawsuit were not solely to help Kate. Both sisters wish to be free of their roles in the family: for Kate, this is the role of the sick daughter who constantly fights to save a life, and for Anna, it is the role of Kate's savior.



Although Anna believes that everyone in the courtroom must hate her, Campbell's gentle tone as he questions her suggests this is not remotely the case. The tragedy of her answers is that, even though Anna views herself as monstrous, she and Kate are on the exact same page: both of them understand the profound emotional burden Kate's illness has put on all the Fitzgeralds, including Kate herself.



46. WEDNESDAY: SARA

Judge DeSalvo decides the hearing parties should go see Kate. When they get to her room, she and Jesse are talking about which celebrities would win against each other in boxing matches. Kate is initially happy to see Sara but is uneasy when she sees the judge. Judge DeSalvo asks to talk to Kate alone, so everyone else files out of the room. As Sara leaves the room, she hears Kate say that she knew Judge DeSalvo would come, since everything “always comes back to [her].”

Judge DeSalvo emerges, tells everyone that closing will be the next morning, then leaves. Campbell offers to have Sara take Anna home, then leaves. Anna asks to see Kate, so the Fitzgeralds go back to her room. They spend time with her for a while; eventually, everyone but Sara leaves. She climbs into bed with Kate and ponders how parents don't have children—they receive them. She tells Kate she's sorry, but Kate says she isn't because she's had a good life. Sara, tearing up, agrees that it was the best.

Kate's reaction to Judge DeSalvo coming to question her shows how well she understands her position in the family. In admitting that everything always comes back to her, she is acknowledging that she and her illness have defined her entire family—to the point that, even now, she is the driving force behind Anna filing her lawsuit.



Now that Sara knows that Kate catalyzed Anna's lawsuit out of a desire to die, she is able to accept Kate's imminent death. Rather than attempting to control Kate's future, she instead embraces the past they've had together by celebrating the life Kate lived for 16 years, when she was expected to have so much less.



47. THURSDAY: CAMPBELL

The morning sees heavy rain. Campbell gets up, and though he knows he should be preparing for his case, he watches the raindrops and thinks of how he used to watch the rain in his father's car. Julia emerges and comments on the weather. Campbell says it's good weather for court, but in reality, he's dreading Judge DeSalvo's verdict—not because he's worried about losing, but because he wants to do right by Anna and knows that either verdict will lead to more pain. Julia comes over to Campbell and tells him that she hates his apartment. Campbell looks around, thinking about how sleek and sterile it is, and admits that he hates it, too.

Although the day is stormy, it marks a new dawn for Campbell. Not only has he reconciled with Julia, but his dread over the prospect of letting Anna down shows how much he's come to care for her, as opposed to when they first met where he thought little of her wellbeing. His newfound dislike of his sleek, impersonal apartment symbolizes how he's come to once again embrace his emotions and do away with the mask of coldness he's worn for most of the novel.



48. THURSDAY: JESSE

Jesse walks outside into the rain. He heads towards the elementary school and begins to run fast until he reaches the high school soccer field. There, he flops down onto the grass and watches the storm. He thinks of a time he came here to take acid; then, he stared up at the sky and hoped for lightning to come down and strike him, but it didn't. It doesn't strike him now, either so he gets up and decides to move forward.

Jesse's brief hope of lightning striking him reflects his self-destructive impulses that he developed as a result of feeling useless. However, the fact that he gets up once the lightning doesn't strike signifies how he's beginning to find meaning in his life once again.



49. THURSDAY: ANNA

Anna observes the rain. It's the kind of rain that feels like a giant shower and evokes apocalyptic images of floods and Noah's Ark. She describes the water cycle as it evaporates and comes back down again: how water never stops moving, but repeats its process over and over again, “like everything else.”

Anna's comparison between the rain and the apocalypse creates an ominous tone for the day, reflecting the gravity of Judge DeSalvo's impending judgment.



50. THURSDAY: BRIAN

Brian, looking at the rain, thinks back to how the day of Anna's birth was also marked by a torrential downpour. He remembers struggling to see through his windshield while driving Sara to the hospital. Later that night, although there were no **stars** out, Brian suggested naming their new baby Andromeda, like the princess who remained in the sky between her mother and father.

The parallel between this day and the day of Anna's birth reflects just how important today is for Anna. Just as the day of her birth marked the start of her life, this day as the potential to grant her a new lease on her life—or, alternatively, prevent her from ever being able to grow on her own terms.



51. THURSDAY: SARA

In the courtroom, just before starting her closing statement, Sara thinks about how the rain spells a bad omen. She begins to read a prepared statement off index cards, but a crash of thunder causes her to drop them all. She decides to start over. Turning to Anna, she tells her that she loves her and that she worries she has lost her perspective on Anna because of her attention on Kate. She admits that she's done everything she can to save Kate, because she wants nothing more than for her children to grow up well. She admits that she doesn't have all the answers, and she doesn't know what she would do if Anna was granted emancipation. What she does know, she says, is that although she does not know if her decision to have Anna be a donor was moral or legal, she knows that it was right.

Sara deciding not to use index cards and speak from the heart is a symbol of her learning how to cede control. Furthermore, although Sara still argues against Anna's emancipation, she does so in a much more humble and empathetic way than her initial rejections of Anna's lawsuit. Now, although she still stands by her efforts to save Kate, she acknowledges that Anna's feelings are valid and admits that she may not have always made the correct decisions. This reflects how Sara has learned to value Anna's feelings, even if the two of them still don't agree.



52. THURSDAY: CAMPBELL

Campbell delivers his closing statement. He argues that the case is not really about bodily autonomy or medical emancipation, but about Anna herself, who is on the cusp of becoming her own person and deserves the chance to find out who she's going to become—and he thinks she's going to be amazing. He admits that the Fitzgeralds have been put in an impossible position, but he asserts that, in such impossible situations, the person whose bodily autonomy is at stake deserves to have the final say. He reminds the court that Anna's motivations for filing her suit were not selfish or shallow. He speculates that Anna might end up donating her kidney after all, but that what he—or anyone else—thinks is irrelevant, because Anna's voice is the only one that matters.

In delivering his closing statement, Campbell decides not to focus on cold issues such as logic or legality, but the emotional core of the case, which is Anna's wants and needs. The case itself has become complicated by the ambiguous ethics surrounding Anna and Kate's respective medical treatments; thus, the strength in Campbell's rhetoric is that he simplifies it by acknowledging that there is no good answer—then, therefore, the answer should be left to Anna, since she is the one who has to sacrifice something if the transplant moves forward.



During a recess, Campbell takes Judge for a walk in a little bit of greenspace by the courthouse. A little boy runs up to them, excited to pet Judge before he's pulled back by his mother. She asks if they can pet him, and Campbell explains that Judge is a service dog. When the woman points out that he's not blind, he considers telling the truth, but decides there's value in laughing at himself. Instead, he tells the woman that he's a lawyer and that Judge chases ambulances for him.

Campbell still refuses to divulge his condition to strangers—but rather than out of shame, he now does it in order to keep his sense of humor about his condition. In this way, although Campbell has learned to be more vulnerable with those that he cares about, this scene also serves as a reminder that he has a right to agency and privacy when it comes to his health.



Court reconvenes for Judge DeSalvo to give his verdict. He muses about how Kate's livelihood and Anna's quality of life have been inextricably intertwined. He talks briefly about his late daughter and how his loss has made him deeply compassionate to Sara and Brian's plight, but that, as both attorneys have pointed out, this case is about navigating complex ethical decisions. He declares that, given Kate's predicament of wanting to live but not wanting to suffer, Anna is the only one in a position to make a decision about it. He states that the premise behind emancipation is simple: you don't take something without asking. With that, he grants Anna medical emancipation and asks Campbell to be her medical power of attorney, which Campbell happily accepts. As court adjourns, Anna finds herself faced with her parents, who embrace her in a hug.

Much like Campbell's closing statement, Judge DeSalvo's verdict in Anna's favor cuts through the ethical complications of the case in order to focus primarily on Anna's wellbeing. As he points out, even though nobody in the Fitzgerald family is capable of making a fully unbiased decision, Anna's closeness with Kate as well as the stakes she has in giving up her kidney means she is the one most equipped to answer the question of what to do. His statement that no one should take something without asking emphasizes the importance of Anna's right to bodily autonomy, regardless of other ethical concerns.



53. THURSDAY: ANNA

Campbell drives Anna to the hospital. They had to stay after to fill out paperwork at the courthouse, so Sara and Brian left before them. The heavy rain is hampering visibility, and Anna imagines the raindrops crushing the car like a Coke can. She asks Campbell what she should do, but he refuses to answer—after all, he just fought for her to make that choice herself. Anna says she doesn't even know who she is, so Campbell lists off some things about her, some of which are real and some that he's making up. Anna asks him if he meant it when, during his closing statement, he said Anna was going to be amazing. Campbell teases her for “fishing for compliments,” but tells her that yes, he can imagine her doing all sorts of amazing things. Anna tells him that, in 10 years, she wants to be Kate's sister.

Anna imagining the car getting crushed like a Coke can casts an ominous tone over this chapter given the heavy rain. However, in contrast to this, Anna and Campbell's conversation is full of hope as they look forward to Anna's future. Anna still struggles with the idea of making her own choices, but it's clear that Campbell believes in her ability to forge her own path as she grows up. Notably, Anna's comment that she wants to be Kate's sister in 10 years shows that she still holds her identity as such close to her heart—but in contrast to previous chapters when she struggled to extricate herself from this identity, she now has room to grow outside of her relationship with Kate.



54. THURSDAY: BRIAN

Brian gets paged about a two-car accident with injuries. He arrives at a dangerous intersection to find a T-bone, with a giant truck rammed into a tiny BMW, which has been crushed. The truck driver is on the way to the hospital, but Red is trying to use the jaws of life to rescue the two people in the BMW. Brian tries to climb in through the top of the truck, but as he begins to wiggle into the car, Red pries open the door, at which point Brian realizes a horrible truth: Anna is the passenger. He frantically extracts Campbell and reaches for Anna, punching Red when he tries to intervene. They get her into the ambulance. Anna has a pulse but is not moving.

In a tragically ironic twist from the last chapter in which Campbell and Anna were discussing Anna's future, her future has now once again been jeopardized by a senseless tragedy. Her comment about Campbell's car being crushed like a can is revealed to have been an example of foreshadowing, with both her and Campbell severely injured. The fact that Anna is not moving suggests that the situation is extremely grave.



At the hospital, Brian is not allowed into the trauma ward. Sara joins him, frantic, and he explains the basic facts, but is unsure how much he should tell her about Anna's lack of responsiveness. Campbell emerges, beaten and bloodied, furiously asking where Anna is. He sees Brian, and Brian's expression is enough for him to realize something terrible has happened to Anna. The doctor comes out and tells Brian that Anna's not responding to noxious stimuli, causing Brian to scream. When Sara asks what's going on, the doctor explains that Anna has received a fatal head injury and is brain-dead—then asks if they want to pursue organ donation. Brian thinks about **stars** that initially appear like single bright stars but turn out to be twin stars rotating around each other. Campbell pipes up and volunteers for Anna's kidney to go to Kate.

In a twist of tragic irony, Anna ultimately loses control of her body after fighting so hard for her bodily autonomy. Although Campbell was her biggest advocate in her case, now that he has medical power of attorney over her, it would make no sense to waste the chance, however remote, to save Kate's life. Thus, Anna's story ends with her not only undergoing what she tried to avoid for the entire novel, but with her losing her life instead of Kate.



55. THURSDAY: SARA

Sara points out how, although English has the words “widow” and “orphan,” there is no word for a parent who has lost a child. After Anna's donated organs are removed, they bring her back down to say goodbye. Brian and Sara go in to turn off her life support. Sara picks up her hand, which is still warm, and tells Brian that she can't do this. Brian reminds her that Anna is already gone; it's only her body that remains. They cry together for a while, then look down at the shell that was once Anna. Brian flips her respirator while Sara rests her hand on Anna's chest, feeling her heart stop beneath her palm: “that tiny loss of rhythm, that hollow calm, that utter loss.”

Sara and Brian going down to say goodbye to Anna is another moment of tragic irony. While the two of them have been preparing themselves to lose Kate this entire time, it is Anna that they ultimately have to say goodbye to. More poignantly, as Brian points out, Anna is already just a body before she fully dies. At the end of her life, she has been reduced to the physical body that has been used to keep Kate alive—something she has been from the very beginning of her life to the very end.



56. 2010: KATE

Kate muses about how grief should have a statute of limitation, so that after a certain point, the pain gets gradually less and less intense and it's easier to move on without feeling guilty about it. She describes how, for some time after Anna's death, Brian claimed he could see Anna in the sky, and Sara looked for signs that Anna would come back for her. Kate, on the other hand, hated herself, since she felt that, had Anna never filed her lawsuit, Anna never would have been at the intersection for that split-second moment.

The last chapter is the first one in Kate's voice, as she describes the Fitzgeralds' profound grief at losing Anna. Her guilt over Anna's death happening because of the lawsuit is representative of her greater guilt surrounding how much of Anna's life was given up for Kate—a major reason Kate asked Anna to file her lawsuit in the first place.



Kate explains how, after her kidney transplant nearly failed, she inexplicably recovered and has not been in relapse since. Dr. Chance thinks it's an effect of the various treatments she's had, but Kate believes that Anna had to take her place for her to survive. She recounts how her household was overcome with debilitating grief for a long time, then gradually began to reconstitute itself through small moments, such as Kate laughing at an episode of "I Love Lucy." Kate felt embarrassed by this, but Jesse came up to hold her hand and told her that Anna would've laughed, too. Kate thinks about how, even when a loved one leaves the world, you still have to live in it, which eventually causes grief to fade.

Kate wonders if Anna watches over them. She wonders if she knows that the Fitzgeralds stayed close to Julia and Campbell and went to their wedding, but eventually had to drift apart due to the pain of their shared memories of Anna. She wonders if Anna knows that Jesse has become a police officer and that Brian struggled with alcoholism after her death but eventually recovered. She wonders if Anna knows that she's now a ballerina teacher, who thinks of Anna every time she looks at her young students.

Almost a year after Anna's death, Sara comes home with some film from Kate's graduation. The two look at the photos, and when they reach the end, they find a photo of Anna at the beach, holding up her hand to avoid being photographed. The two of them stare at it for a long time. Sara lets Kate keep the photo, and she puts it in an envelope in her desk drawer so that she can look at it in case she starts to forget Anna's face. Whenever she worries about this, she goes in front of a mirror and looks at the scar from her kidney transplant, reminding herself that Anna's blood is running through her veins. She thinks about how she takes Anna with her wherever she goes.

Kate's feeling that Anna has to die for her to survive reflects the dynamic that the two had for their entire sisterhood, and especially during Anna's lawsuit: one sister would have to die for the other to live fully. In this way, the grief that the Fitzgeralds feel could be seen as grief that was meant for Kate—but instead, she is the one who has to undergo the never-ending and difficult process of living with grief.



Although all of the surviving characters have relatively happy endings, Kate's description of how everyone's lives have turned out reflects just how deeply Anna's death has affected them. In particular, Brian's alcoholism and the Fitzgeralds' inability to keep close to Julia and Campbell shows that Anna's death has left permanent scars.



Kate's feeling that she carries Anna with her wherever she goes encapsulates the core of the sisters' relationship. Although the lawsuit highlighted the ethical difficulties of Anna's donations, the fact that the novel ends with narration from Kate's perspective serves as a reminder that Kate is alive because of Anna. In this way, Anna's blood and kidney become symbols of her love for Kate, which has outlasted her even after she's died.





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